

# **Omnisoot: a process design package for gas-phase synthesis of carbonaceous nanoparticles**

by  
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In memory of those who sacrificed their lives for  
freedom and prosperity in Iran







## Declaration

I hereby declare that except where specific reference is made to the work of others, the contents of this dissertation are original and have not been submitted in whole or in part for consideration for any other degree or qualification in this, or any other university. This dissertation is my own work and contains nothing which is the outcome of work done in collaboration with others, except as specified in the text and Acknowledgements.

Mohammad Adib  
2026



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## Abstract

The formation of carbonaceous nanoparticles such as soot and Carbon Black (CB) is a complex phenomenon that involves heat transfer, fluid dynamics, chemical kinetics, and particle dynamics. Understanding the effect of process parameters on the morphology, internal structure, and composition of carbonaceous nanoparticles is essential for assessing the environmental impact of soot as a major air pollutant and for producing specific grades of CB, a key reinforcing ingredient in rubber and tire industries. However, the wide span of time and length scales involved in the process, together with strong temperature and pressure sensitivities, complicates accurate prediction of CB and soot properties.

This project is aimed at developing a robust computational package, titled *Omnisoot*, to describe the formation of carbonaceous nanoparticles, such as soot and CB, from the reactions of gaseous hydrocarbons. *Omnisoot* extends the chemical-kinetics capabilities of Cantera for gas-phase chemistry to the simulation of solid particles based on well-justified assumptions. It integrates constant volume, imposed pressure, perfectly stirred, and plug flow reactor models with three widely used inception models, as well as a new inception model based on E-Bridge bond formation. The particle dynamics are described using two population balance models, a monodisperse model and a fixed sectional model, that account for the evolving fractal-like structure of soot agglomerates. The implementation captures soot inception, surface growth, and oxidation coupled with detailed gas-phase chemistry to close the mass and energy balances of the gas-particle system. A step-by-step validation approach was followed to ensure the reliability of all sub-models, enabling the package to serve as an integrated process design tool to predict soot mass, morphology, and composition under varying process conditions.

The developed tool was then used to investigate the temperature dependence of the implemented inception models and its impact on predicted soot mass, morphology, and size distribution for various use-cases. The importance of combined soot yield and morphology data as calibration targets was emphasized for constraining the inception flux and surface growth rate. Special attention was paid to methane pyrolysis because of its practical significance in plasma reactors for co-generation of hydrogen and CB.

Shock-tube pyrolysis of methane was studied at high fuel loadings in post-reflected-shock temperature and pressure ranges relevant to CB synthesis. Detailed comparison of model predictions with time-resolved species mole fractions and soot volume fraction ( $f_v$ ) recorded in collaboration with Stanford University enabled evaluation of several kinetic mechanisms and highlighted the major carbon flux pathways from small hydrocarbons to soot precursors. The impact of fuel loading on gas chemistry and soot formation was interpreted in terms of the endothermicity of pyrolysis. Omnisoot successfully predicted the time history of  $f_v$  and the final primary particle diameter ( $d_p$ ) in agreement with measurements. The different stages of soot formation were identified by analyzing the time histories of predicted  $f_v$ , inception flux, and surface growth rates. The evolution of the hydrogen-to-carbon ratio (H/C) predicted using Omnisoot showed strong correspondence with the maturity index ( $\beta$ ) inferred from extinction ratios at multiple wavelengths, highlighting its potential as a quantitative, time-resolved probe of soot maturity.

# Publications

## Primary contributions

1. **M. Adib**, S. Kazemi, M. R. Kholghy, Omnisoot: a process design package for gas-phase synthesis of carbonaceous nanoparticles, *Combustion and Flame* (2026).
2. **M. Adib**, G. Clark, J. Jahanzamin, C. Li, J. W. Streicher, E. Dames, S. Dasappa, M. R. Kholghy, R. K. Hanson, Gas-phase chemistry and soot formation during shock-tube pyrolysis of methane at high fuel loadings, Under review<sup>1</sup> in *Proceedings of the Combustion Institute* (2026).
3. **M. Adib**, G. Clark, C. Li, T. Rault, J. W. Streicher, R. K. Hanson, M. R. Kholghy, Yield, morphology and maturity of carbon black made by methane pyrolysis in a shock tube, Under review in *Carbon* (2026).

## Secondary contributions

1. G. Clark, C. Li, **M. Adib**, J. Jahanzamin, J. W. Streicher, E. Dames, S. Dasappa, M. R. Kholghy, R. K. Hanson, Carbon particle formation, nanostructure and morphology in H<sub>2</sub>-doped CH<sub>4</sub> pyrolysis: shock tube experiments and modeling, Under review<sup>1</sup> in *Proceedings of the Combustion Institute* (2026).
2. G. Clark, **M. Adib**, C. Li, T. Rault, J. W. Streicher, M. R. Kholghy, R. K. Hanson, Carbon black and hydrogen co-production from methane pyrolysis: measured and modeled insights from integrated gas- phase and particulate diagnostics in shock tubes, Under review in *Carbon* (2026).

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<sup>1</sup>The paper was accepted for presentation in The 41st International Symposium on Combustion





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# Nomenclature

## Acronyms

CFD Computational Fluid Dynamics

DEM Discrete Element Modelling

HACA H-abstraction-C<sub>2</sub>H<sub>2</sub>/Carbon-addition

MPBM Monodisperse Population Balance Model

SPBM Sectional Population Balance Model

## Constants

$Av$  Avogadro's number .....  $6.02214076 \times 10^{23}$  1/mol

$k_B$  Boltzmann constant .....  $1.3806488 \times 10^{-23}$  J/K

$R$  Global gas constant ..... 8.314 J/mol

## English symbols

$A$  Surface area.....m<sup>2</sup>

$c_p$  Heat capacity at constant pressure.....J/kgK

$c_v$  Heat capacity at constant volume.....J/kgK

$c_{soot}$  Heat capacity of soot ..... J/kgK

$C_{tot}$  Total carbon content of soot particles (per section).....mol/kg

$D$  Diffusion coefficient of particles ..... m<sup>2</sup>/s

---

|           |                                                              |                                |
|-----------|--------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| $d$       | Diameter .....                                               | m                              |
| $d_c$     | Collision diameter .....                                     | m                              |
| $d_g$     | Gyration diameter .....                                      | m                              |
| $D_H$     | Duct hydraulic diameter .....                                | m                              |
| $d_m$     | Mobility diameter .....                                      | m                              |
| $d_p$     | Primary particle diameter .....                              | m                              |
| $e$       | Internal energy .....                                        | J/kg                           |
| $E(m)$    | Absorption function of soot .....                            | —                              |
| $f$       | Friction factor .....                                        | —                              |
| $f_v$     | Soot volume fraction based on gas volume .....               | m <sup>3</sup> /m <sup>3</sup> |
| $h$       | Enthalpy .....                                               | J/kg                           |
| $H_{tot}$ | Total hydrogen content of soot particles (per section) ..... | mol/kg                         |
| $I$       | Partial source terms for soot variables .....                | mol/(kg · s)                   |
| $k$       | Reaction rate constant .....                                 | m <sup>3</sup> /(mol · s)      |
| $k_{dep}$ | Deposition velocity .....                                    | m/s                            |
| $Kn$      | Knudsen number .....                                         | —                              |
| $m$       | Mass .....                                                   | kg                             |
| $n_p$     | Number of primary particles of per agglomerate               |                                |
| $N_{agg}$ | Number density of agglomerates .....                         | mol/kg                         |
| $N_{pri}$ | Number density of primary particles .....                    | mol/kg                         |
| $p$       | Pressure .....                                               | Pa                             |
| $P_c$     | Wetted perimeter of the flow reactor .....                   | m                              |
| $R_H$     | Duct hydraulic radius .....                                  | m                              |
| $Re$      | Reynolds number .....                                        | —                              |



---

|      |                                        |                |
|------|----------------------------------------|----------------|
| $S$  | Source terms for soot variables.....   | mol/(kg · s)   |
| $Sc$ | Schmidt number .....                   | —              |
| $SF$ | Sectional spacing factor .....         | —              |
| $Sh$ | Sherwood number.....                   | —              |
| $T$  | Temperature .....                      | K              |
| $u$  | Velocity.....                          | m/s            |
| $V$  | Volume .....                           | m <sup>3</sup> |
| $W$  | Molecular weight .....                 | kg/mol         |
| $Y$  | Mass fraction of gaseous species ..... | —              |

### Greek symbols

|              |                                                          |                      |
|--------------|----------------------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| $\beta$      | Collision frequency.....                                 | m <sup>3</sup> /s    |
| $\delta_a$   | Mean distance of particles.....                          | m                    |
| $\epsilon$   | Wall roughness.....                                      | m                    |
| $\eta_{ads}$ | PAH adsorption adjustment factor .....                   | —                    |
| $\eta_{inc}$ | Inception adjustment factor .....                        | —                    |
| $\lambda$    | Mean free path .....                                     | m                    |
| $\lambda_a$  | Mean stopping distance of particles .....                | m                    |
| $\mu$        | Gas dynamic viscosity .....                              | Pa · s               |
| $\omega$     | The rate of production of gaseous species.....           | mol/m <sup>3</sup> s |
| $\rho$       | Density.....                                             | kg/m <sup>3</sup>    |
| $\tau_w$     | Wall shear stress .....                                  | Pa                   |
| $\tau_{psr}$ | Nominal residence time of perfectly stirred reactor..... | Pa                   |
| $\varphi$    | Soot volume fraction based on reactor volume .....       | kg/m <sup>3</sup>    |

$\zeta$  Collision efficiency.....—

### **Subscripts**

ads Adsorption

agg Agglomerate

coag Coagulation

cont Continuum

f Forward

fm Free molecular

grow Surface growth

inc Inception

ox Oxidation

pri Primary particle

r Reverse

reac Reactive

# Chapter 1

## Introduction

### 1.1 Motivation

Carbonaceous nanoparticles, such as Carbon Black (CB) and soot, are widely encountered in nature and engineering. Every year, nearly 9.5 megatons of soot are emitted into the atmosphere from anthropogenic activities and natural sources such as wildfires and volcanoes [1]. The wide light absorption range of soot reduces the albedo of snow-covered areas and alters the radiative forcing balance in the atmosphere, making soot the third strongest contributor to climate change after methane and carbon dioxide [1]. Exposure to combustion-generated soot can also promote respiratory and cardiovascular diseases [2]. Strict regulations thus target combustion engines to limit environmental and health risks from soot emissions [3]. Accurate and affordable models are essential for predicting soot composition and morphology in combustion devices and for reducing emissions in engines. They can also provide better understanding of soot optical properties, which are major indicators of soot's environmental effects.

On the other hand, CB with a similar synthesis process and structure to soot but higher elemental carbon to hydrogen ratio ( $>97\%$ ) [4] is commercially produced and sold on a large scale. In fact, CB is the largest industrially produced nanomaterial by value and volume ( $\sim 15$  megatons per year with a value of  $\sim \$17\text{B}$ ) with applications as a reinforcing agent in rubber and tire industries [5], and as a conductive additive in lithium-ion batteries [6].

The majority of global CB ( $>95\%$ ) is produced through the furnace black process, in which fuel combustion provides the energy required for thermal decomposition of the hydrocarbon feedstock and CB formation. The reaction mixture is quenched by water injection, and the generated CB is collected using bag filters [7]. A schematic of the process is shown in Fig. 1.1. Despite its industrial dominance, this method suffers from

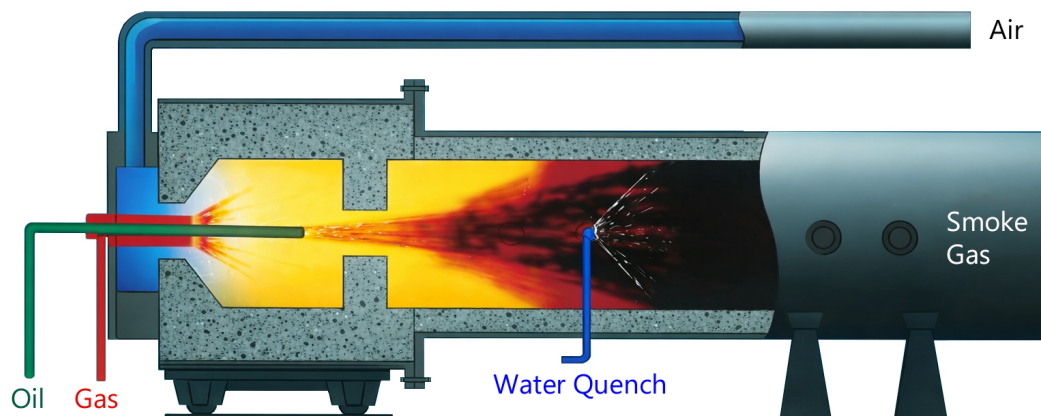


Fig. 1.1 The schematics of furnace black reactor for carbon black synthesis.

relatively low mass yield ( $\sim 60\%$  for rubber grades and  $10\text{--}30\%$  for color grades) and significant emissions, averaging  $\sim 4$  tons of  $\text{CO}_2$  per ton of product [8]. Plasma reactors have recently emerged as low-emission, combustion-free alternatives that can achieve nearly  $\sim 100\%$  mass yield [9], with no direct  $\text{CO}_2$  emissions or other pollutants [10].

Controlling CB properties such as its specific surface area (or primary particle diameter), hard agglomerate size (or gyration diameter of agglomerates with primary particles connected by strong chemical bonds), and composition (or particle carbon-to-hydrogen ratio) is to achieve specific grades of CB in both conventional and new production method. However, this is challenging because of the complexity of CB formation and mass growth processes, their coupling with gas-phase chemistry, and dependence on local temperature and pressure. Accurate process design and optimization tools are thus required to inform manufacturers' decisions for production of CB with desired grades [11].

The term *soot* usually refers to unwanted particulate matter formed during incomplete combustion of carbon-containing materials ranging from jet and diesel fuel to wood, heavy oil, and plastics, with variable organic content and a wide range of C/H ratios [4]. However, this research focuses on soot particles generated under controlled laboratory conditions from fuels with known compositions. Mature soot formed in methane and ethylene premixed flames can reach 95% elemental C/H ratio [12], which is close to CB composition. The comparison of transmission electron microscopy (TEM) images of industrially produced CB [13] with soot sampled from diesel fuel [14, 15], shown in Fig. 1.2, indicates similarity in their morphology and structure. Hereafter, soot will be used to collectively refer to carbonaceous nanoparticles produced in flames or reactors during combustion or pyrolysis processes.

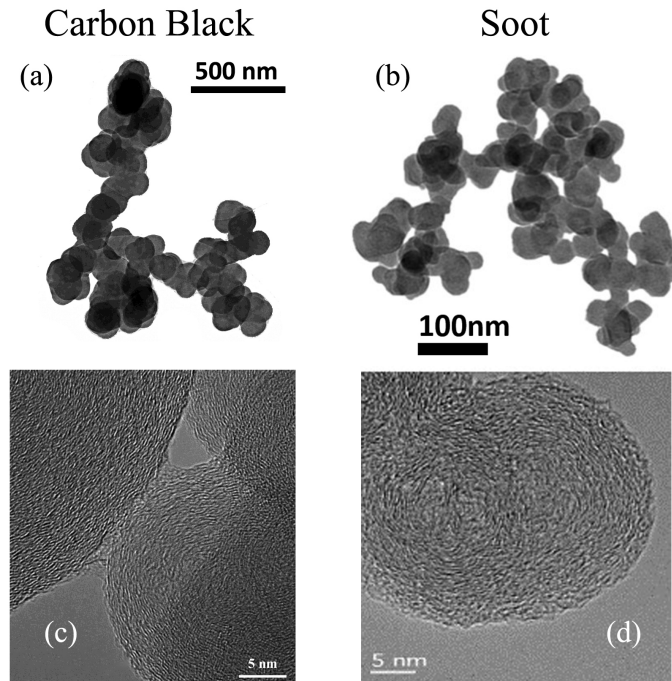


Fig. 1.2 The TEM images of Carbon black (a & c) [13] and soot (b & d) [14, 15] that shows soot and CB has similar morphology and nanostructure.

## 1.2 Background

### 1.2.1 Soot inception and surface growth

Soot formation involves concurrent processes with different time and length scales, starting from the breakdown of hydrocarbon molecules to formation of intermediate species and radicals that transition into soot particles and grow via heterogeneous surface reactions as well as coagulation [16]. TEM analysis of soot sampled from flames [15], reactors [17], and engines [18] with different fuels and process conditions revealed a common fractal-like morphology, often characterized as agglomerates of primary particles. High-resolution transmission electron microscopy (HRTEM) of soot primary particles showed clusters of precondensed polycyclic aromatic hydrocarbons (PAH) [19], pointing to PAHs as main soot precursors. This hypothesis was also supported by the thermodynamic stability of PAHs, enabling them to resist dissociation at high flame temperatures [20].

However, the transition of PAHs (soot precursors) to incipient soot, known as *soot inception*, has not been well understood at the level of pathways and elementary reactions [21], primarily due to uncertainties in PAH (precursor) chemistry. The

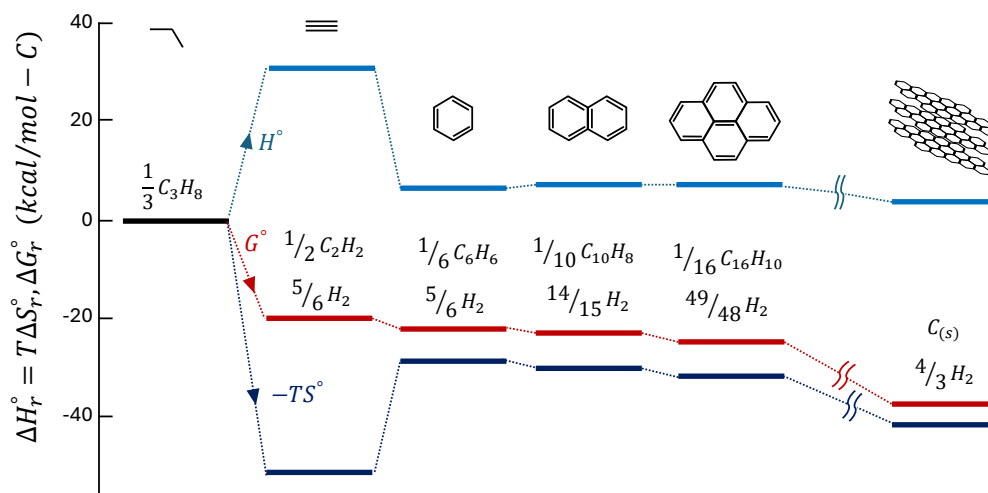


Fig. 1.3 Standard enthalpy ( $\Delta H$ ) and entropy ( $T\Delta S$ ) contributions to Gibbs function of reaction  $\Delta G$  at 1600 K for carbon formation from propane (reprinted from Ref. [21]).

formation of carbonaceous particles is kinetically controlled and is known to be an entropy-driven process [21]. Wang [21] used the pyrolysis of propane at 1600 K to highlight how the thermodynamics of soot formation differ from those of inorganic nanomaterial synthesis. As shown in Fig. 1.3, acetylene formation is highly endothermic, but it is accompanied by a drastic increase in entropy due to hydrogen release, resulting in an overall decrease in Gibbs free energy, which explains why acetylene ( $C_2H_2$ ) is the dominant hydrocarbon species. The growth of PAHs from acetylene does not involve a significant enthalpy release or entropy increase, so the pathway is driven by a gradual reduction in Gibbs free energy. As a result, the kinetics of PAH growth into subsequent soot particles can be highly reversible and therefore sensitive to local temperature, pressure, and intermediate species concentrations.

The growth of PAHs beyond the first ring (benzene) is predominantly driven by the so-called hydrogen abstraction carbon (acetylene) addition (HACA) mechanism [22], where a hydrogen radical abstracts a hydrogen atom at the edge of a PAH, providing a reactive site for acetylene addition. The kinetic reversibility of HACA opens the door for competing pathways such as chain reactions of resonance-stabilized radicals (RSR). Propargyl is a prominent example of these radicals, whose combination is known as a major contributor to benzene formation [23]. Building on this hypothesis, Johansson et al. [24] proposed a radical-driven growth mechanism by addition of vinyl ( $C_2H_3$ ) starting from cyclopentadienyl ( $C_5H_5$ ) to larger hydrocarbon radicals that can survive long enough at high temperatures to react with other radicals, PAHs, and unsaturated aliphatic species through radical chain reactions. However, low concentrations of these

radicals limit the growth rate through RSR pathways [25]. Moreover, some intermediate steps for radical regeneration, such as formation of vinylcyclopentadienyl, were shown to be kinetically unfavorable [25] compared to HACA. Regardless of their mechanistic details, these sequential growth mechanisms, termed *chemical growth*, cannot account for rapid soot formation [22] and its nanostructure [26].

There is abundant but mostly indirect experimental and computational evidence pointing to an alternative collision-based mechanism for soot inception. HRTEM images of nascent and mature soot shows disordered PAH clusters highlighting the role of PAH collisions. The bimodality of particle size distribution (PSD) of nascent soot particles in premixed flames [27] indicates that the kinetics of inception is second order in precursor concentration [28]. The time-of-flight mass spectrometry (TOFMS) experiments in a 13 kPa acetylene-oxygen flame showed a series of peaks with a periodicity of 500 amu [29].

It is not clear how PAH clusters form and what forces allow binding to occur and resist dissociation at flame temperatures ( $T \geq 1600$  K). Frenklach [22] described clustering of PAHs as an irreversible process where two PAHs collide and stick upon collision, forming dimers held together by van der Waals (vdW) forces. Herdman and Miller [30] found that the binding energy of PAH dimers due to dispersive and electrostatic forces increases linearly with molecular mass and reaches the limit of graphite exfoliation energy. However, the entropy barrier of dimerization increases with PAH size, making it unfavorable under equilibrium conditions. Thus, PAHs as large as circumcoronene ( $C_{54}H_{18}$ ) can only form dimers that survive flame temperatures [21]. However, the concentrations of large PAHs are too low to account for the observed number density of soot particles in flames [31].

There is also the possibility of PAH clustering governed by non-equilibrium kinetics. PAH molecules can form rovibrationally excited dimers with a long enough lifetime [32] to react with H atoms, forming covalent bonds. Another possibility is that these clusters are joined by aliphatic linkages. Micro-FT-IR spectroscopy analysis by Cain et al. [33] showed that the ratio of aliphatic-to-aromatic C–H bonds can exceed unity at flame temperatures. Using these findings, they suggested that aliphatic components in the form of alkyl and alkenyl groups can covalently bind to aromatic units in soot particles. Although such a mechanism is viable near the flame region, it cannot explain persistent soot inception in the post-flame zone [34], where the H atom concentration is too low to initiate H abstraction reactions that produce those radicals.

There are other complicating factors that hinder the fundamental understanding of soot inception, such as the lack of a decisive criterion to distinguish gaseous molecules

from particles [16], and the overlap of inception with surface growth and agglomeration [35]. Measurement techniques have limited capability for soot detection due to the short time and length scales of soot inception and surface growth, ranging from picoseconds to milliseconds and micrometers to millimeters [36]. Fig. 1.4 demonstrates the length and time scales relevant to different stages of soot formation from PAH precursors to incipient, nascent, and mature soot in flames. Moreover, data collected from measurements might not be true representatives of soot formed at the probed location in the studied process. For example, intrusive diagnostic methods based on thermophoresis or dilution have a sampling probe that can perturb flow dynamics or alter the structure and composition of soot [37]. Non-intrusive techniques such as optical methods also rely on assumptions about the light absorption and scattering of soot [38] and its morphology [39].

Despite the gaps in fundamental understanding of soot formation and limitations of diagnostic methods, models have been developed to describe soot inception and growth. These models have been formulated as a set of clear pathways that explain soot inception based on collisions of PAH molecules. They must be consistent with current knowledge of soot inception, feasible to couple with chemistry and particle dynamics models, and able to predict soot mass, PSD, and morphology observed in flames and reactors.

The classic description of soot inception relies on PAH dimerization, where collision of two PAH molecules (monomers in this context) forms a dimer held together by van der Waals forces [40]. The dimerization is modeled as an irreversible process with an efficiency that accounts for the reversibility or dissociation of dimers. The theory postulates that PAH growth continues by sequential addition of a monomer (PAH molecule), forming stacks of dimers, trimers, tetramers, and so on to reach a certain mass threshold that marks the emergence of incipient soot [40], but for practical purposes, a dimer is usually considered as incipient soot. Here, we call this model *Irreversible Dimerization*. Irreversible Dimerization has been used to predict soot formation in burner-stabilized premixed [41, 42], counterflow diffusion [43, 44], and coflow diffusion flames [45, 46]. A collision efficiency factor ranging between  $10^{-6}$  and 1 is also employed to adjust the inception flux and PAH adsorption rates to achieve the desired soot mass and size distribution. PAHs of moderate sizes, such as pyrene (4 rings) to coronene (7 rings), have been considered as the starting point of inception due to their thermodynamic instability, which justifies the irreversibility at high temperatures [40]. However, theoretical calculations [47] and experiments [48] indicate that PAH dimerization is highly reversible under flame conditions.



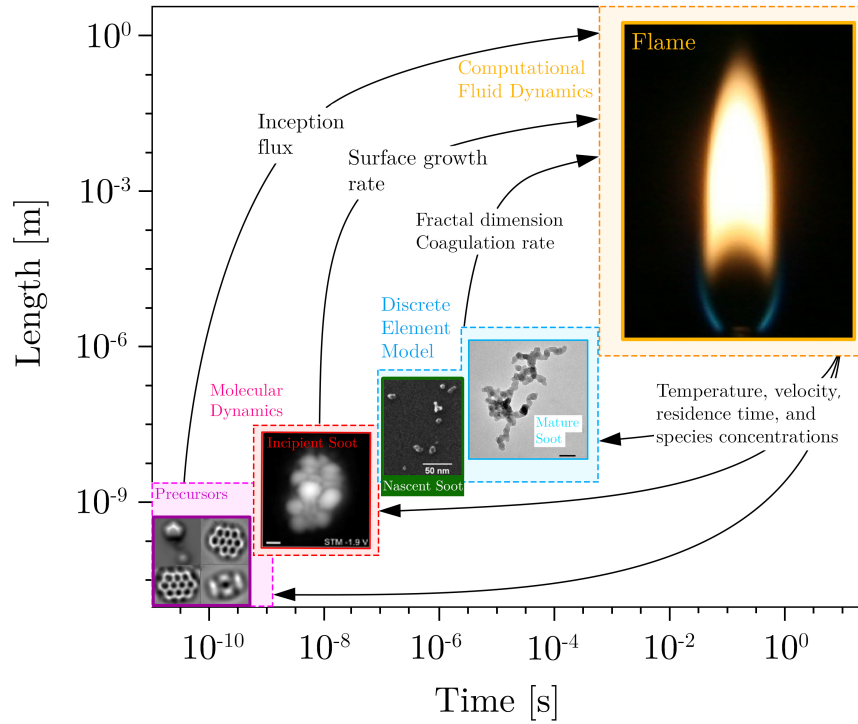


Fig. 1.4 The range of time and length scales of the processes involved in soot formation from molecular reactions to particle-fluid interaction in flames.

The inception flux of irreversible dimerization is determined from PAH collisions, which is proportional to  $\sqrt{T}$ , so new particles can form at low temperatures (even below 500 K) [49], despite experimental evidence for termination of inception below 1200 K [50, 51]. Moreover, the arbitrary selection of efficiency factors, which alters the distribution of mass between inception and surface growth, can significantly change soot mass, PSD, and morphology [52]. A two-step irreversible model, referred to here as *Dimer Coalescence*, was proposed by Blanquart and Pitsch [53]. In this model, PAH molecules collide with each other to form dimers, which represent an intermediate state between gas-phase PAHs and solid soot particles. These dimers can either undergo self-coalescence to form incipient soot particles or adsorb onto existing soot surfaces, contributing to their surface growth.

Eaves et al. [54] relaxed the irreversibility assumption and developed a reversible clustering model to simulate inception using an array of PAHs from naphthalene to benzo-pyrene. Building on that work, Kholghy et al. [55] emphasized the necessity of chemical bond formation after physical PAH clustering for accurate prediction of volume fraction, primary particle diameter, and PSD in ethylene coflow diffusion flames.

Later, Kholghy et al. [56] proposed the "*Reactive Dimerization*" model, which starts with reversible collision of PAHs leading to physically bonded dimers held by vdW forces. Physical dimers can then be graphitized to form chemically bonded dimers that serve as soot nuclei and grow via surface reactions. Kholghy et al. [56] also performed a systematic analysis of the contribution of different PAHs and concluded that one- and two-ring aromatics account for almost all of the inception flux in the so-called "*sooting flame*" [42]. However, Frenklach and Mebel [25] pointed out that an inception model initiated with a highly reversible step similar to Reactive Dimerization [56] cannot produce sufficient particle flux to match measurements from the benchmark burner-stabilized stagnation flame [28]. Instead, they proposed a HACA-driven mechanism where addition of a monomer molecule to its radical, activated by hydrogen abstraction, forms a stable dimer via E-Bridge bond formation, and this sequential process continues to form trimers, tetramers, and larger PAH clusters.

The gas-phase chemistry of aromatics can be extended to account for chemical growth of incipient soot via surface reactions [22]. This hypothesis, known as "chemical similarity," postulates that the reactions occurring on the soot surface are similar to those involving large PAH molecules in the gas phase. It also provides a means to describe the rates of surface growth and particle oxidation in terms of elementary chemical reactions. In other words, it assumes that the surface of soot particles is made up of lateral faces of large PAHs covered with C–H bonds. This is the basis for the HACA mechanism [40, 57], which assumes the soot surface to consist of hydrogenated sites with a predefined density. Mass growth on the soot surface requires H abstraction to form a radical site, followed by acetylene attack, similar to growth of PAH molecules in the gas phase. The reactivity of these sites changes with time and temperature [58, 59], a phenomenon described as soot aging. For modeling purposes, a temperature-dependent multiplier, usually represented by  $\alpha$ , was introduced to account for these effects. Appel et al. [57] showed that  $\alpha$  changes with temperature and particle size.

Adsorption of PAHs on the surface of soot particles is also a viable growth mechanism [40], more specifically called physisorption or chemisorption depending on the mechanisms driving the adsorption process [60]. There is still debate over the stability of adsorbed PAH molecules on the soot surface [61]. Following the hypothesis that PAHs are building blocks of soot particles, a mechanism similar to inception is often used to describe soot growth via PAH adsorption.

### 1.2.2 Coagulation and agglomeration

In typical soot formation processes such as those occurring in flames and reactors, soot particles are formed at high number concentrations ( $10^{12}$  1/cm<sup>3</sup>), and inception and surface growth are relatively short compared to the total residence time of soot particles. As a result, coagulation becomes dominant rapidly, attaining both self-preserving size distribution (SPSD) [62] and asymptotic fractal-like structure [63]. The evolving fractal-like structure of agglomerates, quantified by their mobility diameter normalized by primary particle diameter,  $d_m/d_p$ , and gyration diameter,  $d_g/d_p$ , can be described with power laws derived from mesoscale simulations [64]. The collision frequency of agglomerates depends on their evolving fractal-like morphology.

Additionally, polydisperse agglomerates collide more frequently than monodisperse ones. The enhancement in their collision frequency reaches an asymptotic value of 35% [65] or 82% [66] in the free molecular or transition regimes, respectively, at PSD regardless of the polydispersity in their constituent primary particles. Particle morphology formed by inception, surface growth, and agglomeration can be tracked precisely by mesoscale simulations such as Discrete Element Modeling (DEM) [67], where each agglomerate is tracked separately. However, they are computationally expensive, and interfacing them with chemical kinetics in computational fluid dynamics (CFD) is not trivial [68]. This limits their application in simulations of realistic flames and reactors. Sectional population balance models (SPBMs) are therefore used to track agglomerate and primary particle size distribution [69], morphology [70], and composition [45] in complex laminar [45] and turbulent flames [71]. Using SPBMs coupled with relations for agglomerate fractal-like structure [72] and collision frequency, particle size distribution, morphology, and composition can be tracked accurately. However, the computational cost of SPBMs increases exponentially with the number of sections [69] and the number of tracked particle properties [45]. Thus, typically only one property (e.g., agglomerate mass) is tracked with SPBMs to reduce computational cost. This approach does not account for agglomerate fractal-like structure [73, 74], which limits the accuracy of SPBMs in predicting surface growth and coagulation rates of agglomerates and their size distribution.

Alternatively, particle dynamics can be tracked by the method of moments (MOM) [75] or monodisperse population balance models (MPBM) [76]. Such models only track average particle properties (e.g. moment ratios) and their accuracy could be limited if unrealistic assumptions (e.g. approximating agglomerates as monodisperse and perfect spheres) are used. However, when inception and surface growth are short [77] and high particle (number) concentrations are formed [64], they lead to rapid attainment of self-

preserving size distributions (SPSD) and agglomerates having asymptotic structure [65]. In this case a MPBM or MOM can be assembled on a firm scientific basis with accuracy on par with DEM [67], SPBM [78] and experimental data [79–81]. Such models can be readily interfaced with CFD simulations [82] without significant computational cost, making them ideal for three-dimensional and even turbulent flame simulations.

In MOM, the moments of PSD are tracked and used to estimate soot properties [83]. MOM with four equations was used to describe synthesis of optical fibers by simultaneous reaction, diffusion, coagulation, and thermophoresis of  $\text{SiO}_2$  in laminar flow reactors, assuming a lognormal PSD [84]. The MOM with interpolative closure (MOMIC) was developed to predict simultaneous nucleation, surface growth, and coagulation of soot agglomerates and to estimate its PSD using six equations [75]. To calculate source terms of the transported moments, additional moments that are not tracked are needed, preventing closure of the system of differential equations with MOM [83, 85]. Thus, the PSD shape is often assumed a priori [83] or extra equations are solved to estimate it [76].

MPBMs do not have a closure problem and calculate average particle properties by tracking their total concentration, mass [76], and area [86, 87]. Leung et al. [88] used a 2-equation MPBM to track soot concentration and mass in non-premixed flames, assuming spherical particles. Good agreement was achieved for measured soot mass. However, the specific surface area [87] and coagulation frequency of spheres were significantly smaller compared to those of agglomerates with the same mass, which resulted in underestimating their oxidation rate [78] and overestimating their concentration [76]. Kruis et al. [76] proposed a 3-equation MPBM to account for the fractal-like structure of nanoparticle agglomerates during coagulation and sintering. Agglomerate volume and area were used to obtain their equivalent  $d_p$  and  $n_p$ . Then, agglomerate collision diameter was calculated by  $D_f$ ,  $d_p$ , and  $n_p$  to account for their fractal-like structure that affects collision frequency. Tsantilis and Pratsinis [86] extended MPBM to predict hard and soft agglomerates during synthesis of  $\text{SiO}_2$  and  $\text{TiO}_2$  [89] nanoparticles with simultaneous reaction, surface growth, coagulation, and sintering.

### 1.2.3 Soot maturity and its optical properties

The maturity level of soot describes the evolution of its physical and chemical properties from incipient to graphite-like mature soot [90]. It involves the growth of the graphitic crystallite fine structure within, and perpendicular to, the aromatic layers [91, 92], known as graphitization, followed by an increase in the crystallite-layer plane size and

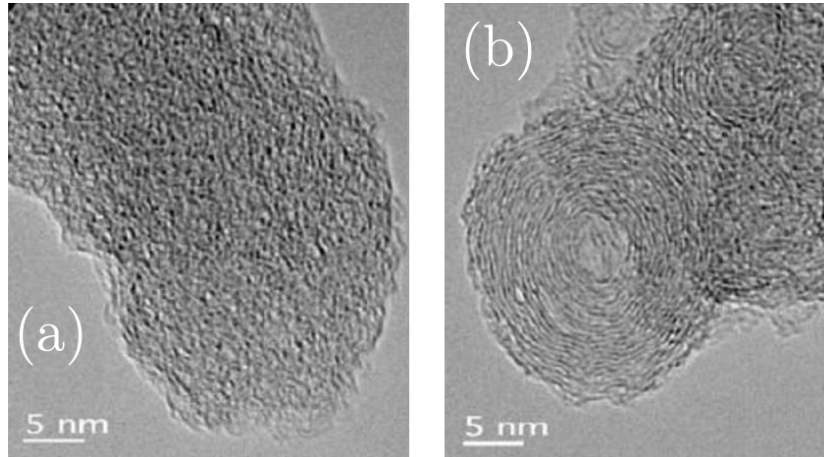


Fig. 1.5 The HRTEM image of (a) a nascent soot primary particle with disordered internal nanostructure juxtaposed with that of (b) a mature soot primary particle with well-organized cluster near the shell sampled from soot generated by pyrolysis of ethanol at 1250 and 1650, respectively (Reprinted from [97]).

a decrease in the interlayer spacing [19]. This process is accompanied by the pyrolytic conversion of hydrocarbon species and substituted hydrocarbons to elemental carbon and an increase in C/H, known as carbonization. Soot maturity is closely associated with the reactivity of surface sites [93]. Fig. 1.5 compares the nanostructure of nascent soot, composed of disoriented PAH clusters, with that of mature soot exhibiting a core-shell structure in which a disordered core is surrounded by concentrically oriented graphitic layers [29]. The core-shell nanostructure of mature soot strongly depends on process conditions such as pressure, fuel identity, temperature, and particle residence time.

Evolution of soot maturity and morphology affects its optical properties. Incipient and nascent soot preferentially absorb shorter wavelengths ( $\lambda < 600$  nm), whereas mature soot particles act as broadband light absorbers [94]. Non-intrusive optical diagnostic methods such as light extinction (absorption and scattering) [95] and Laser Induced Incandescence (LII) [38] are widely used to measure soot volume fraction,  $f_v$ , using the extinction coefficient and the absorption function,  $E(m)$ , which depends on the soot refractive index,  $m$ , as well as soot composition and morphology [96].

However, the effects of soot composition and morphology on  $E(m)$  are not yet fully understood. Previous experimental studies have shown that soot absorption efficiency increases with height above burner (HAB) in methane [98], ethylene [99], and acetylene [100] laminar premixed flames. For example,  $E(m)$  measured by two-color LII at  $\lambda = 1064$  nm increases from 0.193 at 8 mm to 0.349 at 14 mm in an ethylene

premixed flame with an equivalence ratio of  $\phi=2.1$  [101]. Similarly, during acetylene pyrolysis in a shock tube,  $E(m)$  increases from 0.05 to 0.25 when  $d_p$  grows to 20 nm within 1.6 ms [102]. It is common to use  $E(m)$  of mature soot to estimate  $f_v$  from absorption measurements [103]. However, this assumption can lead to significant errors depending on process conditions and the optical properties of soot at the measurement location. Kelesidis and Pratsinis [104] showed that using  $E(m)$  of mature spherical soot [105] overestimates  $f_v$  by a factor of 2 at HAB=2 cm compared to mass-mobility measurements [81] in a benchmark ethylene premixed flame. Therefore, accurate estimation of the evolving optical properties of soot is essential to close the carbon mass balance in measurements [104] and to analyze reaction kinetics for soot inception [56], surface growth [57], and oxidation [106].

The dependence of soot  $m$  on morphology and composition can be quantified using the soot optical band gap,  $E_g$  [107]. The optical band gap concept was originally proposed by Tauc et al. [108] for semiconductors and later developed for amorphous carbon [109]. It can be used to describe the crystalline character of PAH clusters in soot [109]. Incipient flame-made soot with diameters less than 20 nm exhibits quantum dot behavior [110], with  $0.7 < E_g < 2$  eV, which is larger than the  $E_g$  of graphitized soot, 0.12 eV [110]. The optical band gap of organic carbon coated on soot remains nearly constant ( $\sim 1.8$ -1.9 eV) during soot evolution [111]. In contrast, Russo et al. [112] measured the soot optical band gap using ex-situ and in-situ methods and showed that  $E_g$  decreases from 0.7 eV at HAB=8 mm to 0.2 eV at HAB=14 mm in an ethylene premixed flame with  $\phi=2.3$  as particles grow and become more mature through carbonization. Kelesidis and Pratsinis [113] correlated the evolving  $m$  of soot with its  $E_g$ , obtained from quantum confinement theory (QCT) [110], for wavelengths of  $\lambda=532$  and 1064 nm by linear interpolation between nascent and mature soot values [113]. The proposed relations were then combined with soot morphology obtained from DEM simulations to determine the evolving mass absorption cross-section (MAC),  $E(m)$ , and the absorption function ratio,  $E(\lambda=532 \text{ nm})/E(\lambda=1064 \text{ nm})$ . Applying this relation in laser diagnostics to reprocess light extinction data resulted in accurate prediction of  $f_v$  in moderate ( $\phi=2.34$ ) [104] and rich ( $\phi > 3$ ) ethylene premixed flames [114], as well as along the centerline of a coflow ethylene diffusion flame [115].

### 1.2.4 Oxidation

Soot oxidation is described as the removal of soot mass through reactions with molecular oxygen,  $O_2$ , atomic oxygen,  $O$ , and hydroxyl radicals,  $OH$ , at the soot surface. Due to its heterogeneous reaction kinetics and mechanisms, oxidation is expected to be sensitive

to surface structure and composition. Therefore, oxidation mechanisms depend on soot maturity and its temperature-time history. Under near-stoichiometric and fuel-rich conditions, the contribution of OH radicals to soot oxidation is predominant [116] compared to that of O atoms [117]. Fenimore and Jones [118] investigated soot oxidation rates at low oxygen partial pressures and temperatures ranging from 1530 to 1890 K and highlighted the importance of OH as a major oxidizing agent. One approach to describing OH oxidation introduces a collision efficiency that represents the fraction of successful collisions with soot particles that result in the removal of a carbon atom [116]. A collision efficiency of 0.13 was suggested based on Scanning Mobility Particle Sizer (SMPS) measurements in a two-stage burner [119].

The empirical relation of Nagle and Strickland-Constable (NSC) [120], originally developed for the oxidation of pyrolytic graphite, has been widely used to describe soot oxidation by O<sub>2</sub>. It expresses O<sub>2</sub> oxidation rates as a function of the partial pressure of O<sub>2</sub> and the fraction of reactive edge sites relative to less reactive basal planes, using a graphite analogy for soot. O<sub>2</sub> oxidation kinetics has also been described using power-law expressions [121] and shown to be first order with respect to oxygen concentration [122]. Alternatively, soot oxidation can be interpreted through the chemical similarity to the HACA mechanism, assuming a single reaction step of O<sub>2</sub> with a surface radical at steady state [40], and through OH attack on a generic surface active site [116], both leading to the removal of surface carbon and release of CO.

A different oxidation regime has been identified for soot at low temperatures ( $T < 1000$  K), where O<sub>2</sub> diffuses into and reacts within the bulk soot, accounting for most of the soot mass consumption [80]. Internal oxidation compacts the pore network of soot, resulting in hollow diesel [123], and biodiesel [124] soot particles, and increases their SSA by up to a factor of four [123]. Oxidation can also cause fragmentation of soot particles, thereby altering their morphology.

## 1.3 Research objectives

This research aims to develop an integrated computational package that extends the chemical kinetic functionality of Cantera [125] to predict the yield, morphology, and composition of soot formed during hydrocarbon pyrolysis and combustion. A theoretical framework is established based on zero-dimensional reactor models with simplifying assumptions that reduce the complexity of fluid dynamics and heat transfer in gas-particle systems (Section 2.1), while emphasizing gas-phase chemical kinetics, gas-to-soot conversion, and particle dynamics. Within this framework, the transport

equations for gas species and tracked soot properties were uniquely derived and implemented as part of this research (Section 2.2). In addition, governing equations for soot inception (Section 2.4), surface growth and oxidation (Section 2.5), and coagulation (Section 2.3) from the literature are described in detail. A new inception model based on E-Bridge formation [25], referred to as E-Bridge Modified, was proposed and further refined for consistency with the Omnisoot implementation (Section 2.4.4). A rigorous multi-step validation procedure was followed to ensure the reliability of the model predictions (Chapter 2.3).

The ultimate goal of this work is to provide a process design and optimization tool for carbon black synthesis that offers insight into the influence of process parameters, such as pressure, temperature time history, and residence time, on carbon black structure, including agglomerate size and specific surface area, as key performance indicators [126]. Such a tool also enables systematic investigation of the effects of additives on pyrolysis chemistry, inception flux, and surface growth rates, which ultimately determine carbon black properties. Two notable examples are hydrogen, which has a well-established inhibitory effect on PAH and soot formation [127], and toluene, which promotes soot inception [128]. Omnisoot simulations were employed to elucidate the impact of hydrogen addition on soot yield, morphology, and maturity during shock-tube pyrolysis of methane. The results and analysis of this study, the first paper in the list of secondary publications, are not included here to prioritize the main contributions of the author. Ongoing work further examines the combined effects of hydrogen and toluene on methane pyrolysis.

Model versatility is a central development principle of Omnisoot. The package allows any detailed kinetic mechanism in Cantera format to be coupled with particle dynamics through inception, surface growth, and oxidation models, thereby enabling the assessment of uncertainties arising from gas-phase chemistry due to variability in reaction pathways and rate constants. Leveraging this flexible structure, the fundamental differences among the implemented inception models were analyzed in terms of their temperature dependence. Predictions of soot yield, morphology, and particle size distribution obtained using these inception models were compared against benchmark measurements from methane and ethylene pyrolysis and combustion (Section 4.1).

The performance of several kinetic mechanisms was evaluated for predicting key intermediate species during shock-tube pyrolysis of methane at high fuel loadings. Simulation results were used to explain differences among mechanisms in terms of dominant pathways that transfer carbon from methane to larger intermediates, such as



ethylene, acetylene, and propargyl. The mechanism that best reproduces the measured species profiles was selected for detailed soot analysis. These investigations indicate that the E-Bridge Modified inception model captures both the temperature dependence and time history of soot volume fraction in good agreement with light extinction measurements (Section 4.2).

The same combination of kinetic mechanism and inception model was subsequently applied to identify distinct stages of soot formation. The proposed coupled model successfully predicts primary particle diameters in close agreement with TEM measurements, while the sources of observed model-data discrepancies were discussed in terms of precursor chemistry and potential late-stage processes not represented in Omnisoot due to theoretical limitations. A carbonization model was employed to describe the evolution of soot composition and the associated reduction in active sites for surface growth. A strong correspondence was demonstrated between the modeled soot hydrogen-to-carbon ratio and the maturity index inferred from extinction ratios at two wavelengths (Section 4.3).

Finally, it is noted that the oxidation model implemented in Omnisoot is functional and has been applied in limited cases, but it has not been thoroughly validated against benchmark data due to the scarcity of measurements relevant to zero-dimensional reactors. Furthermore, the scope of this work is primarily focused on soot formation in the absence of oxidizing agents such as  $O_2$  and  $OH$ .

## 1.4 Code availability

Omnisoot is published as a standard Python package and is publicly accessible through PyPi<sup>1</sup>. The programming interface provides an easy-to-use workflow that allows users to load reaction mechanisms via Cantera, select reactor configurations, and specify the desired soot sub-models. Multiple example scripts are provided in the public GitHub repository<sup>2</sup> of Omnisoot to demonstrate typical workflows and to enable developing custom simulations for various applications. In addition, the validation scripts used in this work are available in the same repository<sup>3</sup> for transparency and community feedback.

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<sup>1</sup><https://pypi.org/project/omnisoot/>

<sup>2</sup><https://github.com/mohammadadib-cu/omnisoot-cv/tree/main/examples>

<sup>3</sup><https://github.com/mohammadadib-cu/omnisoot-cv/tree/main/validations>



# Chapter 2

## Theoretical Foundation

The mathematical basis for *Omnisoot* is explained in the top-to-bottom hierarchical order. First, the governing equations for constant volume, constant pressure, perfectly stirred and plug flow reactor models are reviewed in Sections 2.2.1-2.2.4. These equations differ from pure gas-phase transport formulation as they consider the solid phase. The transport equations of “soot variables” include the source terms that account for change in each soot variable due to inception, surface growth, oxidation and coagulation. Then, particle dynamics models are explained in Sections 2.3 that entails description of size distribution and morphology of soot particles and their collision rate, which is used to determine the coagulation source term. Section 2.4 focuses on the “*PAH growth model*”s that take care of inception and adsorption from designated precursors and calculates the corresponding source terms. Similarly, the “*surface reactions*” model are detailed in Section 2.5 that elaborates on the surface growth and oxidation rates based on HACA mechanism. Figure 2.1 illustrates the general structure of *Omnisoot* and the sub-models.

### 2.1 Assumptions and conventions

Here, the main conventions and assumptions used in the derivation of the mathematical models are listed below.

1.  $f_v$  and  $\varphi$  denote the volume of soot particles normalized by the gas volume and reactor volume, respectively. Their relationship can be expressed as:

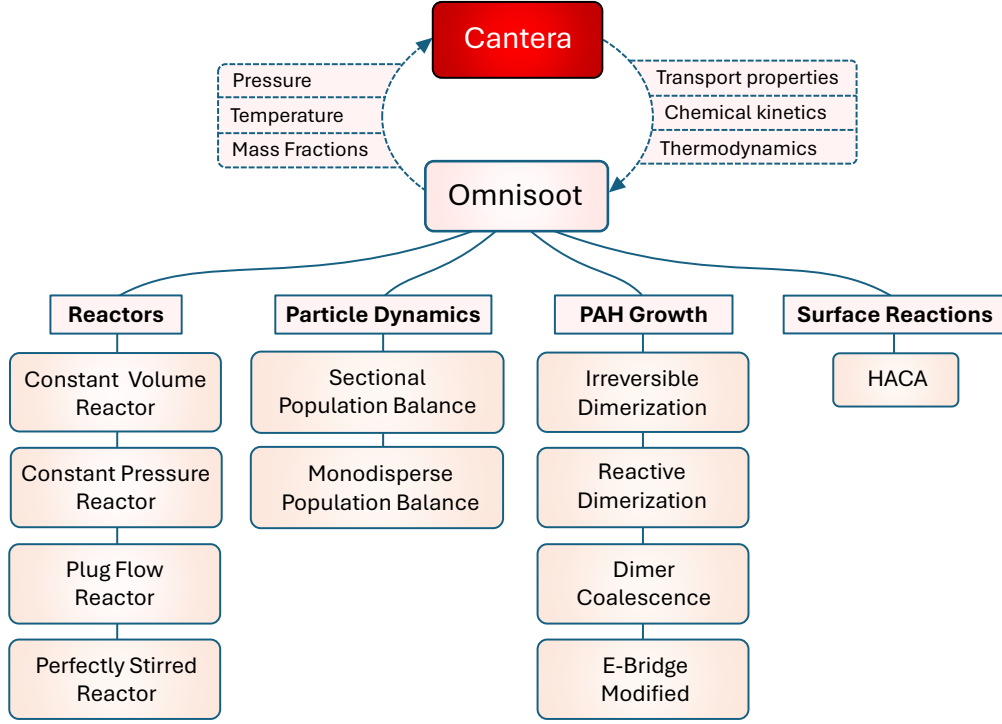


Fig. 2.1 The structure of Omnisoot that illustrates the coupling with Cantera and sub-models including reactors, particle dynamic models, PAH growth models and surface reactions models.

$$\begin{aligned}
 f_v &= \frac{V_{soot}}{V_{gas}}, \\
 \varphi &= \frac{V_{soot}}{V_{gas} + V_{soot}}, \\
 \varphi &= \frac{f_v}{1 + f_v}.
 \end{aligned} \tag{2.1}$$

2.  $\dot{s}_k$  denotes the rate production/consumption of  $k_{th}$  gaseous species (i.e., gas scrubbing) due to soot inception, surface growth and oxidation. It is positive when the species is released to the gas mixture.
3. Each soot agglomerate consists of monodisperse spherical primary particles, which are in point contact. So, the model does not consider formation of necking (or sintering) in soot agglomerates by surface growth.
4. The word “*particle*” refers to soot both in spherical and agglomerate shape.

5. The density of soot is assumed constant at the value of  $1800 \text{ kg/m}^3$ . Soot density changes with its maturity level, which is often linked to the elemental C/H ratio of soot particles [129]. Here, the considered value represents an average between density of mature soot with high C/H ratios ( $\rho = 2000 \text{ kg/m}^3$ ) and that of nascent soot with low C/H ratios ( $\rho = 1600 \text{ kg/m}^3$ ) [130, 129].
6. The incipient soot particles are 2 nm in diameter, so the model does not allow particles with a primary particle diameter smaller than 2 nm. The number of carbon atoms in the incipient soot particle,  $n_{c,min}$ , is calculated from the mass of a sphere with a diameter of  $d_{p,min} = 2 \text{ nm}$  assuming pure carbon content, which results in:

$$n_{c,min} = \frac{\pi}{6} \rho_{soot} d_{p,min}^3 \frac{1}{W_{carbon}} \approx 378. \quad (2.2)$$

7. The specific heat, internal energy and enthalpy of soot are approximated by those of pure graphite, and are employed to close the energy balance in the system [131].
8. Soot particles and gas are in thermal equilibrium during soot formation processes, and there is no temperature gradient within each agglomerate.
9.  $\psi$  denotes a *soot variable* that represents a mean property of soot particles in each section tracked in Omnisoot by solving transport equations for the total concentration of agglomerates,  $N_{agg}$  and primary particles,  $N_{pri}$ , and the total carbon,  $C_{tot}$  and hydrogen content,  $H_{tot}$  of soot.  $S_\psi$  is the source term of the soot variable,  $\psi$ , which appears in soot equations.
10. *PAH growth* is a sub-model of Omnisoot with a set of pathways that determine the rate of inception and adsorption from PAHs (designated as soot precursors) in the gas mixture.
11. *Surface reactions* is a sub-model of Omnisoot that describes the addition of acetylene to soot surface, and removal of carbon via oxidation by OH and O<sub>2</sub> following the HACA scheme. The model does not consider soot oxidation with CO<sub>2</sub>, H<sub>2</sub>O and NO<sub>x</sub>.
12. The single superscript  $i$  denotes the section number of a soot variable or a derived property. For example,  $d_p^i$  represents the primary particle diameter of section  $i$ . The double superscript  $ij$  indicates a property related to two sections; for

Table 2.1 The names, symbols, chemical formula and molecular weight of the soot precursors used by Omnisoot.

| Species name      | Symbol | Chemical formula                | W [kg/mol] |
|-------------------|--------|---------------------------------|------------|
| Naphthalene       | A2     | C <sub>10</sub> H <sub>8</sub>  | 0.128      |
| Phenanthrene      | A3     | C <sub>14</sub> H <sub>10</sub> | 0.178      |
| Pyrene            | A4     | C <sub>16</sub> H <sub>10</sub> | 0.202      |
| Acenaphthylene    | A2R5   | C <sub>12</sub> H <sub>8</sub>  | 0.152      |
| Acephenanthrylene | A3R5   | C <sub>16</sub> H <sub>10</sub> | 0.202      |
| Cyclopentapyrene  | A4R5   | C <sub>18</sub> H <sub>10</sub> | 0.226      |

example,  $\beta^{ij}$  denotes the collision frequency between sections  $i$  and  $j$ . In the case of the monodisperse model, the section number can be omitted because it is equivalent to the sectional model with only one section.

13. The computation of morphological parameters is done similarly in both particle dynamics models, but they are explained separately in Section 2.3.1.
14. *precursors* refer to the PAHs larger than naphthalene used for inception and PAH adsorption. The list of precursors with their chemical formula and molecular mass is provided in Table 2.1. It should be noted that the precursors can be dynamically changed by Omnisoot's user interface.

## 2.2 Reactors

The governing equations of reactor models implemented in Omnisoot are briefly presented in the following sections. The control volume encompasses the gas mixture and soot particles, as illustrated in Figure 2.2. The equations ensure conservation of total mass and energy of the gas and particle system, which can also receive or lose heat through the reactor walls.

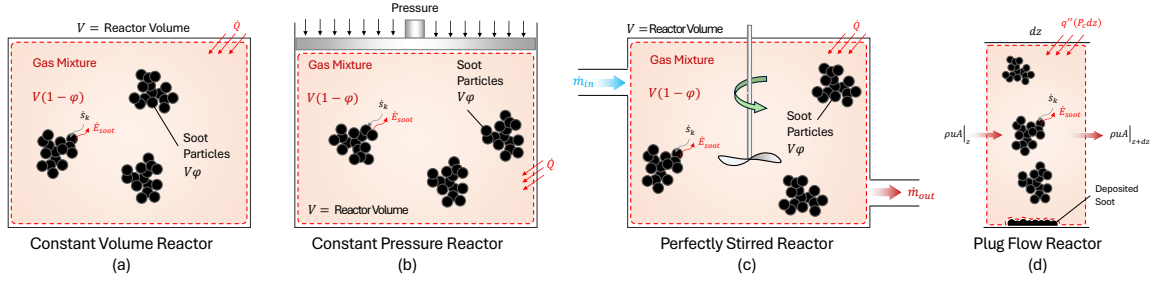


Fig. 2.2 The schematics of (a) constant volume reactor, (b) constant pressure reactor, (c) perfectly stirred reactor, and (d) plug flow reactor.

### 2.2.1 Constant Volume Reactor (CVR)

As shown in Figure 2.2a, CVR represents a closed system constant volume where chemical reactions converts part of the gas mixture to soot particles. The mass balance equation is written as:

$$\frac{d}{dt}(m) = (1 - \varphi)V \sum_i \dot{s}_i W_i, \quad (2.3)$$

where  $m$  is the mass of the gas mixture. The rate of change of  $m$  is equal to the rate of production of soot mass. Similarly, the species equation for species  $k$  is expressed as:

$$\frac{dY_k}{dt} = \frac{1}{\rho} (\dot{\omega}_k + \dot{s}_k) W_k - \frac{1}{\rho} Y_k \sum_i \dot{s}_i W_i. \quad (2.4)$$

The transport equation for a generic soot variable,  $\psi$ , can be written as:

$$\frac{d\psi}{dt} = S_\psi - \frac{\psi}{\rho} \sum_i \dot{s}_i W_i. \quad (2.5)$$

The second term on RHS of Equations (2.4) and (2.5) denotes the change in  $Y_k$  and  $\psi$ , respectively, due to the removal or addition of gas mass by soot-related processes. The energy conservation for the gas mixture is written in terms of the rate of change of temperature. An external heat source of  $\dot{Q}$  is considered to account for possible heat loss/gain of the reactor.

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{dT}{dt} = \frac{1}{\rho c_v + \rho_{soot} f_v c_{soot}} & \left[ - \sum_k e_k (\dot{\omega}_k + \dot{s}_k) W_k \right. \\ & \left. + e_{soot} \sum_k \dot{s}_k W_k + \frac{\dot{Q}}{V(1 - \varphi)} \right], \end{aligned} \quad (2.6)$$

where  $\rho_{soot} f_v c_{soot}$  and  $e_{soot} \sum_k \dot{s}_k W_k$  represent the formation and sensible energy of soot, respectively. We investigated the effect of considering soot formation and sensible energy on gas and soot properties by simulating the pyrolysis of 30% CH<sub>4</sub>-Ar with and without considering the above mentioned term. As shown in Figure 2.3a, neglecting soot sensible energy results in the overprediction of temperature by nearly 150 K and mobility diameter by a factor of 3 during the 80 ms of the simulation. The overprediction of temperature changes gas chemistry, leading to a noticeable decrease in the residual methane and benzene (Figure 2.3b).

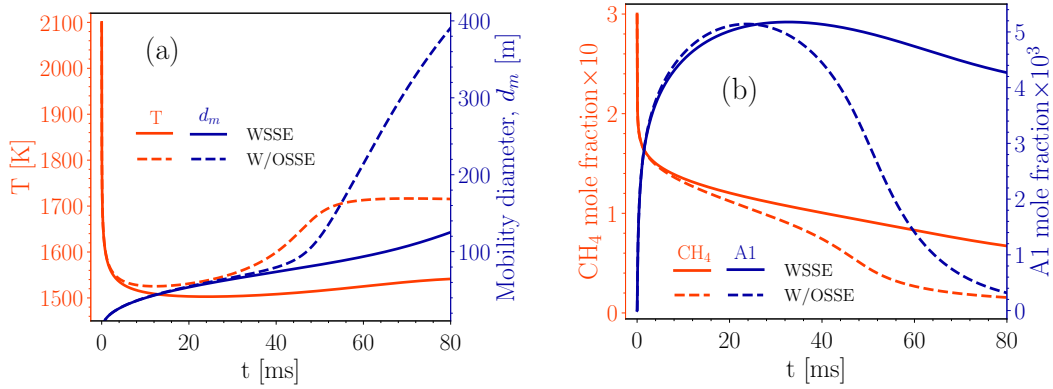


Fig. 2.3 The comparison of (a) temperature and soot mobility diameter,  $d_m$  and (b) the mole fraction of methane, CH<sub>4</sub>, and benzene, A1 in the simulation of the pyrolysis of 30%CH<sub>4</sub>-Ar when soot sensible energy is considered (labeled as “WSSE”) and neglected (labeled as “W/OSSE”). The CVR is used along with Caltech mechanism, Reactive Dimerization and MPBM.

## 2.2.2 Imposed Pressure Reactor (IPR)

As show in Figure 2.2b, this reactor is a closed system similar to CVR with a main difference that the boundary can move and change the volume of the system due to an external pressure that can stay constant or vary with time. In either case, the pressure is known a priori in this model. The heat transfer can occur through reactor walls, which changes the internal energy of the gas-particle system.

The equations of mass, species, and soot variables in IPR are the same as those in CVR, but the energy equation is written based on enthalpy,  $h$ , instead of internal energy,  $e$ , as:



$$\frac{dT}{dt} = \frac{1}{\rho c_p + \rho_{soot} f_v c_{soot}} \left[ - \sum_k h_k (\dot{\omega}_k + \dot{s}_k) W_k + h_{soot} \sum_k \dot{s}_k W_k + \frac{dP}{dt} + \frac{\dot{Q}}{V(1-\varphi)} \right]. \quad (2.7)$$

where  $dP/dt$  represents the effect of variable pressure on the gas temperature, which is zero when the pressure is constant throughout the process.

### 2.2.3 Perfectly Stirred Reactor (PSR)

In this reactor, gas enters with a mass flow rate, composition, and temperature of  $\dot{m}_{in}$ ,  $Y_{in}$ , and  $T_{in}$ , respectively, and homogeneously reacts with the mixture inside the reactor. The reacting gas reaches a spatially uniform temperature and composition described by  $T$  and  $Y$ . It is assumed that temperature, composition and soot properties of the outflow are the same as the mixture inside reactor. Without soot formation, the inlet and outlet mass flow rates are equal (i.e.  $\dot{m}_{in} = \dot{m}_{out}$ ), but when soot is formed,  $\dot{m}_{out}$  is slightly less than  $\dot{m}_{in}$ . The nominal residence time of PSR is calculated as:

$$\tau_{psr} = \frac{\rho V}{\dot{m}_{in}}. \quad (2.8)$$

The conservation of mass of PSR can be written by considering the mass flux of in- and outflow, and the removal of mass due to soot formation as:

$$\frac{dm}{dt} = \dot{m}_{in} - \dot{m}_{out} + V(1-\varphi) \sum_i \dot{s}_i W_i. \quad (2.9)$$

Gas composition is obtained by solving the species transport equations as:

$$\frac{dY_k}{dt} = \frac{\dot{m}_{in}}{\rho V (1-\varphi)} (Y_{k,in} - Y_k) + \frac{1}{\rho} \left[ (\dot{\omega}_k + \dot{s}_k) W_k - Y_k \sum_i \dot{s}_i W_i \right]. \quad (2.10)$$

The soot transport equations can also be expressed as:

$$\frac{d\psi}{dt} = \frac{\dot{m}_{in}}{\rho V (1-\varphi)} (\psi_{in} - \psi) + S_\psi - \frac{1}{\rho} \psi \sum_i \dot{s}_i W_i. \quad (2.11)$$

The energy equation for this reactor is written as:

$$\frac{dT}{dt} = \frac{1}{\rho c_p + \rho_{soot} c_{p,soot} f_v} \left[ \frac{\dot{m}_{in}}{V(1-\varphi)} (h_{in} - h) - \frac{\dot{m}_{in}}{V(1-\varphi)} \sum_k (Y_{k,in} - Y_k) h_k - \sum_k (\dot{\omega}_k + \dot{s}_k) W_k h_k + \sum_i \dot{s}_i W_i h_{soot} + \frac{\dot{Q}}{V(1-\varphi)} \right]. \quad (2.12)$$

## 2.2.4 Plug Flow Reactor (PFR)

PFR is an ideal representation of a channel or duct where the temperature, composition, and soot properties of a steady-state one-dimensional flow evolve along the reactor. There is no spatial gradient over cross-section due to strong mixing. The diffusion along reactor is negligible.

The continuity equation for PFR is written as:

$$\frac{d\dot{m}}{dz} = (1-\varphi)A \sum_i \dot{s}_i W_i. \quad (2.13)$$

The momentum equation can also be established as:

$$u(1-f_v) \sum_i \dot{s}_i W_i + \rho u(1-\varphi) \frac{du}{dz} = -\frac{d}{dz}(p(1-\varphi)) - \frac{\tau_w}{R_H}, \quad (2.14)$$

where  $\tau_w$ , and  $R_H$  are the wall shear stress and hydraulic radius of the reactor.  $\tau_w$  can be determined from the friction factor,  $f$ , as:

$$\tau_w = \frac{1}{2} \rho u^2 f, \quad (2.15)$$

where  $f$  can be accurately calculated over the entire range of Reynolds numbers, from laminar to turbulent flow, using the explicit formula provided by Haaland [132]:

$$\frac{1}{f^{1/2}} = -1.8 \log \left( \frac{6.9}{Re} + \left[ \frac{\epsilon/D_H}{3.7} \right]^{1.11} \right), \quad (2.16)$$

where  $\epsilon$  and  $D_H$  are the wall roughness and the hydraulic radius of the reactor. The species equation can be expressed as:

$$\frac{dY_k}{dz} = \frac{1}{\rho u} \left[ (\dot{\omega}_k + \dot{s}_k) W_k - Y_k \sum_i \dot{s}_i W_i \right]. \quad (2.17)$$

The soot transport equations can also be written as:

$$\frac{d\psi}{dz} = \frac{S_\psi}{u} - \frac{\psi}{\rho u} \sum_i \dot{s}_i W_i - \frac{4}{D_H} \frac{k_{dep}^i \psi}{u}, \quad (2.18)$$

where  $k_{dep}^i$  is the deposition velocity of soot particles of section  $i$ , which is calculated as:

$$k_{dep} = \frac{Sh \cdot D^i}{D_H}, \quad (2.19)$$

where  $Sh = 3.66$  for laminar flows, and it calculated using the Berger and Hau correlation [133] for the turbulent flow as:

$$Sh = 0.0165 Re^{0.86} Sc^{1/3}. \quad (2.20)$$

The energy equation can be expressed as:

$$\frac{dT}{dz} = \frac{1}{\rho u c_p + \rho_{soot} u f_v c_{p,soot}} \left[ - \sum_k h_k (\dot{\omega}_k + \dot{s}_k) W_k + h_{soot} \sum_k \dot{s}_k W_k + q'' \frac{P_c}{A} \right], \quad (2.21)$$

where  $q''$  is the wall heat flux of the reactor.

## 2.3 Particle Dynamics

Population balance models rely on the Eulerian description of particles where average properties of particle population such as number density, mass or surface area are treated as continuous quantities and tracked by solving scalar transport equations. These methods are computationally cheaper compared with mesoscale models such as DEM, and can be easily interfaced with chemical kinetics in CFD solvers to simulate soot formation in laminar and turbulent configurations. Here, we use two particle dynamics models: a monodisperse population balance model (MPBM), which tracks four variables and results in four transport equations, and a fixed sectional population balance model (SPBM), which tracks three variables per section. In the SPBM approach, the total number of transport equations equals the number of tracked variables multiplied by the number of sections.

Having the total number concentration of agglomerates and primary particles and total carbon content of soot enables the model to describe evolving fractal-like morphology and surface area of soot agglomerates, which is essential to compute their collision frequency [134] as well as oxidation and surface growth rates [78]. Tracking hydrogen content of soot allows capturing the soot composition, thereby its maturity [45], and surface reactivity [53].

The common features of implemented particle dynamics models are reviewed in Section 2.3.1. The composition (H/C), diffusion coefficient, and morphology of soot particles are calculated in the same manner for MPBM and each section in SPBM. However, particle dynamics models differ in terms of the calculation of coagulation, and the processing of the contributions from inception, surface growth, and coagulation to generate the source terms of soot variables,  $S_\varphi$ , incorporated into the transport equations.

### 2.3.1 Common Features

#### Soot Morphology

The evolving fractal-like structure of agglomerates is quantified by their mobility diameter normalized by primary particle diameter,  $d_m/d_p$ , and gyration diameter,  $d_m/d_g$ , that can be described with power-laws derived from mesoscale simulations. Incipient soot is initially a sphere formed of PAHs that grows in size by surface reactions and forms agglomerates by coagulation. The collision frequency of particles depends on their evolving fractal-like structure [134]. Mobility and gyration diameters are calculated using power-laws developed to describe the morphology of soot from premixed [79], diffusion [135] flames, and diesel engines [136]. Figure 2.4 shows the schematic of a soot agglomerate composed of 12 primary particles, with  $d_p$ ,  $d_m$ , and  $d_g$  annotated.

$n_p^i$  is the number of primary particles per agglomerate of the  $i^{th}$  section that can be obtained by dividing the number concentration of primary particles in the  $i^{th}$  section by that of agglomerates in that section as:

$$n_p^i = \frac{N_{pri}^i}{N_{agg}^i}. \quad (2.22)$$

The primary particle diameter,  $d_p^i$ , is determined from the total carbon content and the number density of primary particles using:

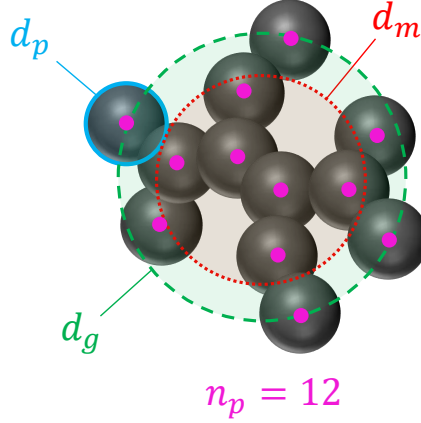


Fig. 2.4 The schematics of a soot agglomerates with 12 primary particles ( $n_p = 12$ ). Primary particle,  $d_p$ , mobility  $d_m$ , and gyration  $d_g$ , diameters are shown.

$$d_p^i = \left( \frac{6}{\pi} \frac{C_{tot}^i \cdot W_{carbon}}{\rho_{soot}} \frac{1}{N_{pri}^i \cdot Av} \right)^{1/3}. \quad (2.23)$$

The DEM-derived power-laws [64] relate  $d_m^i$  and  $d_g^i$  to  $d_p^i$  and  $n_p^i$  as:

$$d_m^i = d_p^i \cdot n_p^{i 0.45}, \quad (2.24)$$

$$d_g^i = \begin{cases} d_m^i / (n_p^{i -0.2} + 0.4), & \text{if } n_p^i > 1.5 \\ d_m^i / 1.29 & \text{if } n_p^i \leq 1.5 \end{cases} \quad (2.25)$$

The collision diameter,  $d_c^i$ , is the maximum of  $d_m^i$  and  $d_g^i$ :

$$d_c^i = \max(d_m^i, d_g^i). \quad (2.26)$$

The volume equivalent diameter,  $d_v^i$ , is the diameter of the sphere with the same mass as the agglomerate, and it is obtained as:

$$d_v^i = d_p^i \cdot n_p^{i 1/3}. \quad (2.27)$$

The primary particle surface area is calculated from  $d_p^i$  assuming spherical primary particles as:

$$A_p^i = \pi d_p^{i 2}. \quad (2.28)$$

$A_{tot}^i$  (for each section) is defined as the total surface area of soot particles per unit mass of gas mixture obtained as:

$$A_{tot}^i = N_{pri}^i \cdot Av \cdot A_p^i. \quad (2.29)$$

Mass of each agglomerate,  $m_{agg}^i$  is expressed as:

$$m_{agg}^i = \frac{C_{tot}^i \cdot W_{carbon}}{N_{agg}^i \cdot Av}. \quad (2.30)$$

### Soot composition

The composition of soot characterized by their elemental carbon to hydrogen ratio (C/H) is a measure of soot maturity and increases from  $C/H < 2$  for incipient soot [137] to  $2 < C/H < 10$  for nascent soot [138] and  $C/H > 20$  for mature soot [90]. The soot agglomerates are assumed to have pure carbon graphitic core [45] with all hydrogen atoms on the surface [53]. C/H ratio can be obtained from the total carbon and the hydrogen content as:

$$\left(\frac{C}{H}\right)^i = \frac{C_{tot}^i}{H_{tot}^i}. \quad (2.31)$$

The carbon content of each agglomerate is a predefined parameter in the SPBM (depending on the section the agglomerate is placed), but it can be calculated from dividing  $C_{tot}$  by  $N_{agg}$  for the MPBM. The hydrogen content of each agglomerate is calculated for both particle dynamics models as:

$$H_{agg}^i = \frac{H_{tot}^i}{N_{agg}^i}. \quad (2.32)$$

### Diffusion of soot particles

The diffusion coefficient of soot particle,  $D^i$ , is calculated as:

$$D^i = \frac{k_B T}{f^i}, \quad (2.33)$$

where  $f^i$  is the friction factor of particles in the gas mixture, and it is calculated as:

$$f^i = \frac{3\pi\mu d_m^i}{C^i(d_m^i)}, \quad (2.34)$$

where  $C^i$  is the Cunningham correction factor for the particle friction factor that accounts for non-continuum effects in the transition and free molecular regimes.  $C^i$  is calculated for a given diameter,  $d$ , as:

$$C^i(d) = 1 + \frac{2\lambda}{d} \left( 1.21 + 0.4 \exp\left(\frac{-0.78d}{\lambda}\right) \right), \quad (2.35)$$

where  $\lambda$  is the mean free path of gas given as:

$$\lambda = \frac{\mu}{\rho} \sqrt{\frac{\pi W_{gas}}{2k_B A v T}}. \quad (2.36)$$

Note that  $\lambda$  is a property of the gas mixture that does not depend on particle mass and morphology.

### 2.3.2 Sectional Population Balance Model (SPBM)

A SPBM with fixed pivots is used to describe particle dynamics [139]. The mass range of particles is divided into discrete sections each of which includes agglomerates of the same mass. Figure 2.5 illustrates the interaction between the gas phase and mass sections, as well as the mechanisms by which particles move between sections. Inception introduces new particles to the first section with the mass corresponding to the incipient particle. The particles of each section can migrate to upper sections by gaining mass via surface growth and coagulation, and return to lower sections when they lose mass through oxidation without breaking into smaller particles (i.e., fragmentation is not considered). Particles attach at point contact without coalescence. The mass of sections is determined by a geometric progression that has an initial value equal to the mass of incipient soot particle, and a common ratio of SF, known as sectional spacing factor. The mass of each section is approximated by the carbon content of agglomerates in moles as:

$$C_{agg}^i = \frac{n_{c,min}}{A_v} \cdot SF^{(i-1)}, \quad (2.37)$$

where  $(i - 1)$  represents the exponent of SF. The mass of hydrogen is ignored in the placement of agglomerates in the sections. The total number density of agglomerates,  $N_{agg}^i$ , and primary particles,  $N_{pri}^i$ , and the hydrogen content,  $H_{tot}$ , are tracked for each section. The mass of each section is fixed, so  $C_{tot}$ , for each section can be easily calculated by knowing the number of agglomerates; that is,  $C_{tot} = N_{agg}^i \cdot A_v \cdot C_{agg}^i$ .

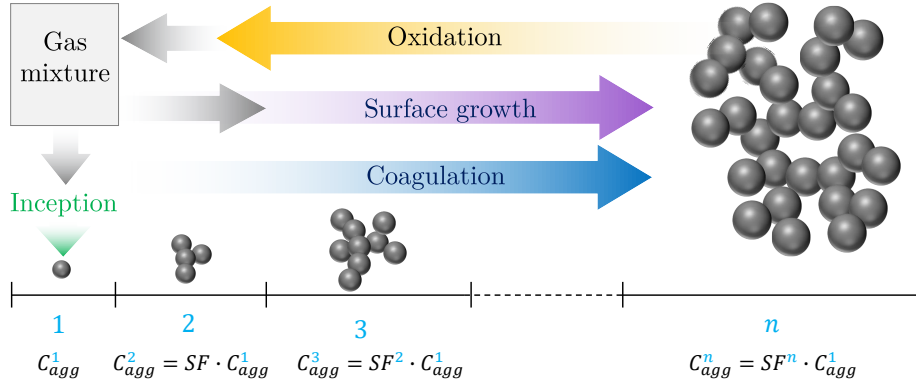


Fig. 2.5 The illustration of sections in SPBM. The mass of sections grows progressively by the scale factor of  $SF$ . Inception introduces new particles to the first section that propagate to the upper section via coagulation and surface growth and return to lower sections by oxidation. Carbon and hydrogen pass from gas to solid phase through inception and surface growth and goes back via oxidation.

Morphological parameters for each section are determined according to the equations provided in Section 2.3.1.

New particles formed by coagulation are assigned to an upper section, with a total mass equal to the sum of the masses of the colliding particles. If the mass of resulting particle falls between two consecutive sections, the mass is distributed between them proportionally. In some cases, the mass of the newly formed particle may exceed the upper bound of the last section, causing it to fall outside the tracked mass range. This leads to potential mass loss, which is a known limitation of the fixed pivot sectional model [140]. However, this issue can be mitigated by choosing an appropriate number of sections and a suitable spacing factor to ensure the uppermost sections remain unoccupied during the simulation. In the SPBM, the source terms of tracked soot variables (which appear in Equations 2.5, 2.11, and 2.18) are split into four parts showing the contribution of inception, surface growth, oxidation and coagulation. The effect of HACA and PAH adsorption are combined (denoted by the subscript *haca,ads*) because they are similar mass-gaining mechanisms. The source terms for section  $i$  are given as:

$$S_{N_{agg}}^i = (S_{N_{agg}}^i)_{inc} + (S_{N_{agg}}^i)_{haca,ads} + (S_{N_{agg}}^i)_{ox} + (S_{N_{agg}}^i)_{coag}, \quad (2.38)$$

$$S_{N_{pri}}^i = (S_{N_{pri}}^i)_{inc} + (S_{N_{pri}}^i)_{haca,ads} + (S_{N_{pri}}^i)_{ox} + (S_{N_{pri}}^i)_{coag}, \quad (2.39)$$



$$S_{H_{tot}}^i = \left(S_{H_{tot}}^i\right)_{inc} + \left(S_{H_{tot}}^i\right)_{haca,ads} + \left(S_{H_{tot}}^i\right)_{ox} + \left(S_{H_{tot}}^i\right)_{coag}. \quad (2.40)$$

Coagulation redistributes the total number of agglomerates and primary particles as well as hydrogen atoms among the sections. The partial coagulation source terms for  $N_{agg}^i$ ,  $N_{pri}^i$  and  $H_{tot}^i$  can be calculated as:

$$\left(S_{N_{agg}}^i\right)_{coag} = \sum_{k=1}^{n_{sec}} \sum_{j=k}^{n_{sec}} \left(1 - \frac{\delta_{jk}}{2}\right) \eta_{ijk} \zeta^{jk} \beta^{jk} N_{agg}^j N_{agg}^k - N_{agg}^i \sum_{m=1}^{n_{sec}} \zeta^{im} \beta^{im} N_{agg}^m, \quad (2.41)$$

$$\left(S_{N_{pri}}^i\right)_{coag} = \sum_{k=1}^{n_{sec}} \sum_{j=k}^{n_{sec}} \left(1 - \frac{\delta_{jk}}{2}\right) \eta_{p,ijk} \eta_{ijk} \zeta^{jk} \beta^{jk} N_{agg}^j N_{agg}^k - N_{pri}^i \sum_{m=1}^{n_{sec}} \zeta^{im} \beta^{im} N_{agg}^m, \quad (2.42)$$

$$\left(S_{H_{tot}}^i\right)_{coag} = \sum_{k=1}^{n_{sec}} \sum_{j=k}^{n_{sec}} \left(1 - \frac{\delta_{jk}}{2}\right) \eta_{h,ijk} \eta_{ijk} \zeta^{jk} \beta^{jk} N_{agg}^j N_{agg}^k - H_{tot}^i \sum_{m=1}^{n_{sec}} \zeta^{im} \beta^{im} N_{agg}^m. \quad (2.43)$$

where  $\delta_{jk}$  is the Kronecker delta defined as:

$$\delta_{jk} = \begin{cases} 1, & \text{if } j = k \\ 0, & \text{if } j \neq k \end{cases} \quad (2.44)$$

The collision frequency between sections  $j$  and  $k$  ( $\beta^{jk}$ ) can be obtained from the harmonic mean of the values in the continuum ( $\beta_{cont}^{jk}$ ) and free molecular ( $\beta_{fm}^{jk}$ ) regimes as:

$$\beta^{jk} = \frac{\beta_{fm}^{jk} \cdot \beta_{cont}^{jk}}{\beta_{fm}^{jk} + \beta_{cont}^{jk}}, \quad (2.45)$$

$$\beta_{fm}^{jk} = \sqrt{\frac{\pi k_B T}{2} \left( \frac{1}{m_{agg}^j} + \frac{1}{m_{agg}^k} \right) (d_c^j + d_c^k)^2}, \quad (2.46)$$

$$\beta_{cont}^{ij} = \frac{2k_B T}{3\mu} \left( \frac{C^j}{d_m^j} + \frac{C^k}{d_m^k} \right) (d_c^j + d_c^k)^2. \quad (2.47)$$

The collision frequency can also be determined from the Fuchs interpolation as:

$$\beta^{jk} = \beta_{cont}^{ij} \left[ \frac{d_c^j + d_c^k}{d_c^j + d_c^k + 2 + \delta_r^{jk}} + \frac{8(D^j + D^k)}{\bar{c}_r^{jk} (d_c^j + d_c^k)} \right]^{-1}, \quad (2.48)$$

where  $\delta_r^{jk}$  and  $\bar{c}_r^{jk}$  are the mean square root of mean distance and velocity of particles, respectively, and they are obtained as:

$$\delta_r^{jk} = \sqrt{\delta_a^{j2} + \delta_a^{k2}}, \quad (2.49)$$

$$\bar{c}_r^{jk} = \sqrt{c^j{}^2 + c^k{}^2}. \quad (2.50)$$

The mean velocity,  $c^i$ , and mean stop distance of particles,  $\lambda_a^i$ , can be calculated as:

$$c^i = \sqrt{\frac{8k_B T}{\pi m_{agg}^i}}, \quad (2.51)$$

$$\delta_a^i = \frac{1}{d_c^i \lambda_a^i} \left[ (d_c^i + \lambda_a^i)^3 - (d_c^{i2} + \lambda_a^{i2})^{3/2} \right] - d_c^i, \quad (2.52)$$

$\lambda_a^i$  is the agglomerate stopping distance defined as:

$$\lambda_a^i = \frac{8D^i}{\pi c^i}. \quad (2.53)$$

In Equation (2.41),  $\eta_{ijk}$  assigns newly formed agglomerates to the two consecutive sections in order to conserve mass during coagulation [70].

$$\eta_{ijk} = \begin{cases} \frac{C_{agg}^{i+1} - C_{agg}^{jk}}{C_{agg}^{i+1} - C_{agg}^i}, & \text{if } C_{agg}^i \leq C_{agg}^{jk} < C_{agg}^{i+1} \\ \frac{C_{agg}^i - C_{agg}^{jk}}{C_{agg}^i - C_{agg}^{i-1}}, & \text{if } C_{agg}^{i-1} \leq C_{agg}^{jk} < C_{agg}^i \\ 0, & \text{else} \end{cases} \quad (2.54)$$

where  $C_{agg}^{jk} = C_{agg}^j + C_{agg}^k$ . Similarly,  $\eta_{p,ijk}$  in Equation (2.42) and  $\eta_{h,ijk}$  in Equation (2.43) adjust the number of primary particles and hydrogen atoms added to consecutive sections based on their mass, respectively.

$$\eta_{p,ijk} = \frac{C_{agg}^i}{C_{agg}^{jk}} (n_p^j + n_p^k), \quad (2.55)$$

$$\eta_{h,ijk} = \frac{C_{agg}^i}{C_{agg}^{jk}} (H_{agg}^j + H_{agg}^k). \quad (2.56)$$

In Equation (2.41),  $\zeta^{jk}$  is the coagulation efficiency of soot particles in sections  $j$  and  $k$ . A value of  $\zeta^{jk} = 1$  indicates that every collision between two soot particles

successfully results in the formation of a new agglomerate. However, numerical models [141] and experimental evidence [142] have shown that coagulation efficiency drastically decreases for particles smaller than 10 nm in the free-molecular regime ( $\text{Kn} \gg 10$ ), due to their high kinetic energy exceeding the magnitude of attractive forces [143]. The coagulation efficiency between two colliding particles can be described by [141]:

$$\zeta^{ij} = 1 - \left(1 + \frac{\Phi_0^{ij}}{k_B T}\right) \exp\left(-\frac{\Phi_0^{ij}}{k_B T}\right), \quad (2.57)$$

where  $\Phi_0$  is the potential well depth, i.e., the minimum interaction energy between two colliding particles. Hou et al. [144] calculated  $\Phi_0$  for soot particles ranging from 1 to 15 nm by considering the attractive and repulsive interactions between constituent carbon and hydrogen atoms, and proposed an equation based on the reduced diameter,  $d_r^{jk}$ , of colliding particles as:

$$\Phi_0^{ij} = -6.6891 \times 10^{-23} (d_r^{jk})^3 + 1.1244 \times 10^{-21} (d_r^{jk})^2 + 1.1394 \times 10^{-20} d_r^{jk} - 5.5373 \times 10^{-21}, \quad (2.58)$$

$$d_r^{jk} = \frac{d_c^i \cdot d_c^j}{d_c^i + d_c^j}. \quad (2.59)$$

Equation (2.58) is valid for  $d_r^{jk}$  between 1 and 7 nm, and  $\zeta^{ij}$  is assumed as unity for particles with a reduced diameter larger than 7 nm.

Inception introduces equal number of agglomerates and primary particles to the first section.

$$(S_{N_{agg}}^i)_{inc} = \begin{cases} \frac{1}{Av} \frac{I_{N,inc}}{C_{agg}^i}, & \text{if } i = 1 \\ 0.0, & \text{else} \end{cases} \quad (2.60)$$

$$(S_{N_{pri}}^i)_{inc} = \begin{cases} \frac{1}{Av} \frac{I_{N,inc}}{C_{agg}^i}, & \text{if } i = 1 \\ 0.0, & \text{else} \end{cases} \quad (2.61)$$

$$(S_{H_{tot}}^i)_{inc} = \begin{cases} I_{H,inc}, & \text{if } i = 1 \\ 0.0, & \text{else} \end{cases} \quad (2.62)$$

Surface growth and PAH adsorption increase both the carbon mass and hydrogen content of agglomerates, transferring them to higher sections. The rate at which

agglomerates are removed from the original section and added to the target section is calculated to ensure mass conservation. Specifically, it is determined by dividing the mass growth rate by the difference in mass of adjacent sections as:

$$(S_{N_{agg}}^i)_{haca,ads} = \frac{1}{Av} \begin{cases} -\frac{I_{C_{tot},haca}^i + I_{C_{tot},ads}^i}{C_{agg}^{i+1} - C_{agg}^i}, & \text{if } i = 1 \\ \frac{I_{C_{tot},haca}^{i-1} + I_{C_{tot},haca}^{i-1}}{C_{agg}^i - C_{agg}^{i-1}} - \frac{I_{C_{tot},haca}^i + I_{C_{tot},ads}^i}{C_{agg}^{i+1} - C_{agg}^i}, & \text{if } 1 < i < n_{sec} \\ \frac{I_{C_{tot},haca}^{i-1} + I_{C_{tot},ads}^{i-1}}{C_{agg}^i - C_{agg}^{i-1}}. & \text{if } i = n_{sec} \end{cases} \quad (2.63)$$

As agglomerates move up/down through sections, they carry the number of primary particles as well as hydrogen atoms, so the transfer rate of agglomerates is multiplied by  $n_p^i$  and  $H_{agg}^i$ , respectively.

$$(S_{N_{pri}}^i)_{haca,ads} = \frac{1}{Av} \begin{cases} -\frac{I_{C_{tot},haca}^i + I_{C_{tot},ads}^i}{C_{agg}^{i+1} - C_{agg}^i}, & \text{if } i = 1 \\ \frac{I_{C_{tot},haca}^{i-1} + I_{C_{tot},ads}^{i-1}}{C_{agg}^i - C_{agg}^{i-1}} n_p^{i-1} - \frac{I_{C_{tot},haca}^i + I_{C_{tot},ads}^i}{C_{agg}^{i+1} - C_{agg}^i} n_p^i, & \text{if } 1 < i < n_{sec} \\ \frac{I_{C_{tot},haca}^{i-1} + I_{C_{tot},ads}^{i-1}}{C_{agg}^i - C_{agg}^{i-1}} n_p^{i-1}, & \text{if } i = n_{sec} \end{cases} \quad (2.64)$$

$$(S_{H_{tot}}^i)_{haca,ads} = \frac{1}{Av} \begin{cases} -\frac{I_{C_{tot},haca}^i + I_{C_{tot},ads}^i}{C_{agg}^{i+1} - C_{agg}^i} H_{agg}^i + I_{H_{tot},haca}^i + I_{H_{tot},ads}^i, & \text{if } i = 1 \\ \frac{I_{C_{tot},haca}^{i-1} + I_{C_{tot},ads}^{i-1}}{C_{agg}^i - C_{agg}^{i-1}} H_{agg}^{i-1} - \frac{I_{C_{tot},haca}^i + I_{C_{tot},ads}^i}{C_{agg}^{i+1} - C_{agg}^i} H_{agg}^i \\ + I_{H_{tot},haca}^i + I_{H_{tot},ads}^i, & \text{if } 1 < i < n_{sec} \\ \frac{I_{C_{tot},haca}^{i-1} + I_{C_{tot},ads}^{i-1}}{C_{agg}^i - C_{agg}^{i-1}} H_{agg}^{i-1} + I_{H_{tot},haca}^i + I_{H_{tot},ads}^i, & \text{if } i = n_{sec} \end{cases} \quad (2.65)$$

Similarly, the agglomerates lose carbon mass by oxidation, and descend to the lower sections carrying primary particle and hydrogen.

$$(S_{N_{agg}}^i)_{ox} = \frac{1}{Av} \begin{cases} \frac{I_{C_{tot},ox}^{i+1}}{C_{agg}^{i+1} - C_{agg}^i} - \frac{I_{C_{tot},ox}^i}{C_{agg}^i}, & \text{if } i = 1 \\ \frac{I_{C_{tot},ox}^{i+1}}{C_{agg}^{i+1} - C_{agg}^i} - \frac{I_{C_{tot},ox}^i}{C_{agg}^i - C_{agg}^{i-1}}, & \text{if } 1 < i < n_{sec} \\ -\frac{I_{C_{tot},ox}^i}{C_{agg}^i - C_{agg}^{i-1}}, & \text{if } i = n_{sec} \end{cases} \quad (2.66)$$

$$(S_{N_{pri}}^i)_{ox} = \frac{1}{Av} \begin{cases} \frac{I_{C_{tot},ox}^{i+1}}{C_{agg}^{i+1} - C_{agg}^i} n_p^{i+1} - \frac{I_{C_{tot},ox}^i}{C_{agg}^i}, & \text{if } i = 1 \\ \frac{I_{C_{tot},ox}^{i+1}}{C_{agg}^{i+1} - C_{agg}^i} n_p^{i+1} - \frac{I_{C_{tot},ox}^i}{C_{agg}^i - C_{agg}^{i-1}} n_p^i, & \text{if } 1 < i < n_{sec} \\ -\frac{I_{C_{tot},ox}^i}{C_{agg}^i - C_{agg}^{i-1}} n_p^i, & \text{if } i = n_{sec} \end{cases} \quad (2.67)$$

$$(S_{H_{tot}}^i)_{ox} = \frac{1}{Av} \begin{cases} \frac{I_{C_{tot},ox}^{i+1}}{C_{agg}^{i+1} - C_{agg}^i} H_{agg}^{i+1} - \frac{I_{C_{tot},ox}^i}{C_{agg}^i} H_{agg}^i + I_{H_{tot},ox}^i, & \text{if } i = 1 \\ \frac{I_{C_{tot},ox}^{i+1}}{C_{agg}^{i+1} - C_{agg}^i} H_{agg}^{i+1} - \frac{I_{C_{tot},ox}^i}{C_{agg}^i - C_{agg}^{i-1}} H_{agg}^i + I_{H_{tot},ox}^i, & \text{if } 1 < i < n_{sec} \\ -\frac{I_{C_{tot},ox}^i}{C_{agg}^i - C_{agg}^{i-1}} H_{agg}^i + I_{H_{tot},ox}^i, & \text{if } i = n_{sec} \end{cases} \quad (2.68)$$

### 2.3.3 Monodisperse Population Balance Model (MPBM)

The MPBM used in this study is based on the monodisperse model presented in [145], and it tracks  $N_{pri}$ ,  $N_{agg}$ ,  $C_{tot}$  and  $H_{tot}$ . The coagulation model follows the same principles as the SPBM, but the calculations are greatly simplified due to the monodispersity assumption. This approach has been shown to achieve accuracy comparable to that of DEM and SPBM when applied with well-justified assumptions [67, 78]. The rate of decay of agglomerates is simply described as:

$$I_{coag} = -\frac{1}{2} \zeta \beta N_{agg}^2, \quad (2.69)$$

where  $\zeta$  is the collision efficiency of agglomerates calculated using Equation (2.57), and  $\beta$  is the collision frequency of agglomerates for the free-molecular ( $Kn > 10$ ) to continuum regimes ( $Kn < 0.1$ ). The value of  $\beta$  in the transition regime ( $0.1 < Kn < 10$ ) can be

calculated from the harmonic mean of the continuum ( $\beta_{cont}$ ) and free-molecular ( $\beta_{fm}$ ) regime values. Additionally, an enhancement factor of 1.82 is applied to take into account the effect of polydispersity [66] as:

$$\beta = 1.82 \frac{\beta_{fm} \cdot \beta_{cont}}{\beta_{fm} + \beta_{cont}}, \quad (2.70)$$

$$\beta_{fm} = 4 \sqrt{\frac{\pi k_B T}{m_{agg}}} d_c^2, \quad (2.71)$$

$$\beta_{cont} = 8\pi d_m D, \quad (2.72)$$

where  $d_c$ ,  $D$ , and  $m_{agg}$  are calculated using Equations (2.26), (2.33), and (2.30), respectively. Alternatively,  $\beta$  can be obtained using Fuchs interpolation [146] as:

$$\beta = \beta_{cont} \left( \frac{d_c}{d_c + 2\sqrt{2}\delta} + \frac{8D}{\sqrt{2}cd_c} \right)^{-1}, \quad (2.73)$$

where  $c$  (mean velocity of particles) and  $\delta$  (mean stop distance of particles) are calculated using Equations (2.51) and (2.52). The source terms of tracked variables combines the effect of the inception, surface growth, oxidation and coagulation.

$$S_{N_{agg}} = \frac{I_{N,inc}}{n_{c,min}} + I_{coag}, \quad (2.74)$$

$$S_{N_{pri}} = \frac{I_{N,inc}}{n_{c,min}}, \quad (2.75)$$

$$S_{C_{tot}} = I_{C_{tot},inc} + I_{C_{tot},haca} + I_{C_{tot},ads} - I_{C_{tot},ox}, \quad (2.76)$$

$$S_{H_{tot}} = I_{H_{tot},inc} + I_{H_{tot},haca} + I_{H_{tot},ads} - I_{H_{tot},ox}. \quad (2.77)$$

## 2.4 PAH growth models

Four different PAH growth models are implemented in Omnisoot to describe the conversion of PAHs into incipient particles and their adsorption onto existing agglomerates. In other words, these models explain the calculation of  $I_{\varphi,inc}$  and  $I_{\varphi,ads}^i$ . The implemented models are: Irreversible Dimerization [40], Reactive Dimerization [56], Dimer Coalescence [147], and E-Bridge Modified [25]. All models are based on PAH collision, as supported by ample evidence in the literature [27–29], but they differ in terms of reversibility, temperature dependence, and the number of steps involved. The

collision frequency of gaseous species including PAH molecules and polymers depends on their mass and diameter, and it is obtained as:

The collision frequency of gaseous species, including PAH molecules and polymers, depends on their mass and diameter and is calculated as:

$$\beta_{dim_{jk}} = 2.2 \cdot d_r^2 \sqrt{\frac{8\pi k_B T}{m_r}}, \quad (2.78)$$

where 2.2 is the vdW enhancement factor [56].  $d_r$  and  $m_r$  are reduced diameter and mass for two PAH molecules/dimers, respectively, calculated as:

$$d_r = \frac{d_{PAH_k} \cdot d_{PAH_j}}{d_{PAH_k} + d_{PAH_j}}, \quad (2.79)$$

$$m_r = \frac{m_{PAH_k} \cdot m_{PAH_j}}{m_{PAH_k} + m_{PAH_j}}, \quad (2.80)$$

where  $m_{PAH_j}$  and  $d_{PAH_j}$  are the mass and equivalent diameter of the  $j^{th}$  PAH molecule, respectively, and are obtained as:

$$m_{PAH_j} = \frac{W_{PAH_j}}{Av}, \quad (2.81)$$

$$d_{PAH_j} = \left( \frac{6 \cdot m_{PAH_j}}{\pi \cdot \rho_{PAH_j}} \right)^{1/3}, \quad (2.82)$$

where  $\rho_{PAH_j}$  is the equivalent density of PAH estimated using the relation proposed by Johansson et al. [148] as:

$$\rho_{PAH_j} = 171943.5197 \frac{W_{carbon} \cdot n_{C,PAH_j} + W_{hydrogen} \cdot n_{H,PAH_j}}{n_{C,PAH_j} + n_{H,PAH_j}}, \quad (2.83)$$

where  $n_{C,PAH_j}$  and  $n_{H,PAH_j}$  denote the number of carbon and hydrogen atoms in the  $j^{th}$  PAH molecule, respectively. The collision frequency of PAH<sub>j</sub> and soot agglomerates in each section can be determined for the entire regime by harmonic mean of the collision frequencies in the free-molecular and continuum regimes as:

$$\beta_{ads_j}^i = \frac{\beta_{fm,ads}^i \cdot \beta_{cont,ads}^i}{\beta_{fm,ads}^i + \beta_{cont,ads}^i}, \quad (2.84)$$

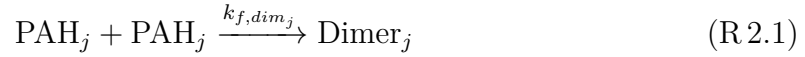
$$\beta_{fm,ads_j}^i = 2.2 \sqrt{\frac{\pi k_B T}{2} \left( \frac{1}{m_{agg}^i} + \frac{1}{m_{PAH_j}} \right) (d_g^i + d_{PAH_j})^2}, \quad (2.85)$$

$$\beta_{cont,ads_j}^i = \frac{2k_B T}{3\mu} \left[ \frac{C^i(d_m)}{d_g^i} + \frac{C^i(d_{PAH_j})}{d_{PAH_j}} \right] (d_g + d_{PAH_j}), \quad (2.86)$$

where  $C^i$  is the Cunningham correction factor calculated using Equation (2.35).

### 2.4.1 Irreversible Dimerization

The Irreversible Dimerization is based on the collision of a pair of PAH molecules forming a dimer. The sequential growth continues leading formation of trimers and tetramers until the PAH cluster mass reaches a threshold that can be considered a solid particle. For practical purposes, a dimer is usually considered as an incipient particle that grows by surface growth and coagulation. A single-step collision of two similar PAHs forms a new dimer as:



Similarly, the adsorption of each PAH molecule on soot particles is described by the irreversible collision of soot and  $PAH_j$  as:



The forward rate of dimerization,  $k_{f,dim_j}$ , and adsorption,  $k_{f,ads_j}$ , in Reactions (R.2.1) and (R.2.2) are calculated as:

$$k_{f,dim_j} = \gamma_{inc} \cdot \beta_{jj,PAH} \cdot Av, \quad (2.87)$$

$$k_{f,ads_j}^i = \gamma_{ads_j} \cdot \beta_{j,ads}^i \cdot Av, \quad (2.88)$$

where  $\beta_{jk,PAH}$  and  $\beta_{j,ads}^i$  are computed using Equations (2.78) and (2.84), respectively, and  $\gamma_{inc}$  and  $\gamma_{ads}$  are the collision efficiencies for dimerization and adsorption, respectively. Their values range from  $10^{-7}$  to 1 and are typically chosen to match the predicted soot properties with experimental data. The dimerization rate of  $PAH_j$  is then calculated as:

$$\omega_{dim_j} = \eta_{inc} k_{f,dim_j} [PAH_j][PAH_j]. \quad (2.89)$$

The partial source terms of inception are calculated as:



$$I_{N,inc} = \frac{1}{\rho} \sum_{j=1}^{n_{PAH}} 2\omega_{dim_j} n_{PAH_j,C}, \quad (2.90)$$

$$I_{C_{tot},inc} = \frac{1}{\rho} \sum_{j=1}^{n_{PAH}} 2\omega_{dim_j} n_{PAH_j,C}. \quad (2.91)$$

$$I_{H_{tot},inc} = \frac{1}{\rho} \sum_{j=1}^{n_{PAH}} 2\omega_{dim_j} n_{PAH_j,H}. \quad (2.92)$$

The rate of PAH adsorption for each section is obtained as:

$$\omega_{ads_j}^i = \eta_{ads} k_{f,ads_j}^i [\text{soot}^i] [\text{PAH}_j]. \quad (2.93)$$

The contribution of PAH adsorption to the source terms are expressed as:

$$I_{C_{tot},ads}^i = \frac{1}{\rho} \sum_{j=1}^{n_{PAH_j}} \omega_{ads_j}^i n_{PAH_j,C}, \quad (2.94)$$

$$I_{H_{tot},ads}^i = \frac{1}{\rho} \sum_{j=1}^{n_{PAH_j}} \omega_{ads_j}^i (n_{PAH_j,H} - 2). \quad (2.95)$$

Note that PAH adsorption is a mass growth phenomenon that only changes  $C_{tot}$  and  $H_{tot}$  but does not affect number of  $N_{agg}$  and  $N_{pri}$ . Each PAH molecule loses one H atom becoming a radical that forms bonds with a dehydrogenated site on soot surface, so two H atoms are released during adsorption that is taken into account in Equation (2.95).

The formation of a dimer consumes two PAH molecules, and during adsorption one PAH molecule is removed from the gas mixture, so the total rate of removal of  $\text{PAH}_j$  by Irreversible Dimerization is obtained as:

$$\left( \frac{d[\text{PAH}_j]}{dt} \right)_{inc} = -2\omega_{dim_j}, \quad (2.96)$$

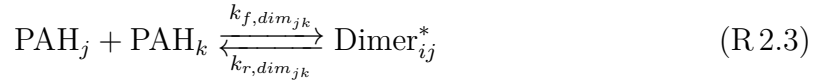
$$\left( \frac{d[\text{PAH}_j]}{dt} \right)_{inc} = - \sum_{i=1}^{n_{sec}} \omega_{ads_j}^i. \quad (2.97)$$

Moreover, one  $\text{H}_2$  is released to the gas mixture as a result of the adsorption process.

$$\left( \frac{d[\text{H}_2]}{dt} \right)_{ads} = \sum_{i=1}^{n_{sec}} \omega_{ads_j}^i. \quad (2.98)$$

### 2.4.2 Reactive Dimerization

This model was built on Irreversible Dimerization with a main difference: The first step of dimerization and adsorption is reversible forming physically bonded dimers followed by an irreversible carbonization that leads to chemical bond formation in dimers [56]. This approach allows the formation of homo- and hetero-dimers. The dimerization of  $\text{PAH}_j$  and  $\text{PAH}_k$  is described as:



where  $\text{Dimer}_{jk}^*$  and  $\text{Dimer}_{jk}$  are physically and chemically bonded dimers, respectively, from  $\text{PAH}_j$  and  $\text{PAH}_k$ . The forward rate of physical dimerization,  $k_{f,dim_{jk}}$ , is calculated as:

$$k_{f,dim_{jk}} = p'' \cdot \beta_{jk,PAH} \cdot Av, \quad (2.99)$$

where  $\beta_{jk,PAH}$  is calculated using Equation (2.78), and  $p'' = 0.1$  accounts for the probability of PAH-PAH collisions occurring in the "FACE" configuration that result in successful van der Waals (vdW) bond formation [149]. The reverse rate of physical dimerization,  $k_{r,dim_{jk}}$ , is obtained from the dimerization equilibrium constant [150] as:

$$k_{r,dim_{jk}} = \frac{k_{f,dim_{jk}}}{K_{eq}}, \quad (2.100)$$

$$\log_{10} K_{eq} = a \frac{\epsilon_{jk}}{RT} + b, \quad (2.101)$$

$$\epsilon_{jk} = cW_{jk} - d, \quad (2.102)$$

$$W_{jk} = \frac{W_j \cdot W_k}{W_j + W_k}, \quad (2.103)$$

where  $a = 0.115$  (obtained from pyrere dimerization data [48]) and  $b = 1.8$  [56],  $c = 933420 \text{ J/kg}$ , and  $d = 34053 \text{ J/mol}$  [56].

The rate constant of chemical bond formation,  $k_{reac}$ , is defined in the Arrhenius form [49] as

$$k_{reac} = 5 \times 10^6 \cdot e^{(-96232/RT)}. \quad (2.104)$$

Assuming a steady state condition for physical dimers, i.e.,  $\partial[\text{Dimer}_{jk}^*]/\partial t = 0$ , the rate of formation of chemically-bonded dimers can be obtained as:

$$\omega_{dim_{jk}} = k_{reac} \frac{k_{f,dim_{jk}} [\text{PAH}_j] [\text{PAH}_k]}{k_{r,dim_{jk}} + k_{reac}}. \quad (2.105)$$

The contribution of dimer formation to the partial source terms is evaluated by looping over all combinations of PAH precursors as:

$$I_{N,inc} = \frac{1}{\rho} \sum_{j=1}^{n_{PAH}} \sum_{k=j}^{n_{PAH}} \omega_{dim_{kj}} (n_{PAH_j,C} + n_{PAH_k,C}), \quad (2.106)$$

$$I_{C_{tot},inc} = \frac{1}{\rho} \sum_{j=1}^{n_{PAH}} \sum_{k=j}^{n_{PAH}} \omega_{dim_{kj}} (n_{PAH_j,C} + n_{PAH_k,C}), \quad (2.107)$$

$$I_{H_{tot},inc} = \frac{1}{\rho} \sum_{j=1}^{n_{PAH}} \sum_{k=j}^{n_{PAH}} \omega_{dim_{kj}} (n_{PAH_j,H} + n_{PAH_k,H}). \quad (2.108)$$

Similarly, PAH adsorption is described by a two-step process where the collision of  $\text{PAH}_j$  with soot agglomerates leads to a physically bonded  $\text{Soot-PAH}_j^*$  that is carbonized and forms a chemically bonded  $\text{Soot-PAH}_j$  on soot surface.



The forward and reverse rate of PAH-soot collision are calculated as:

$$k_{f,ads_j}^i = \beta_{j,ads}^i \cdot Av, \quad (2.109)$$

$$k_{r,ads_j}^i = k_{f,ads_j}^i \cdot 10^{-b} e^{-a\epsilon_{soot,j}^i \ln(10)/(RT)}, \quad (2.110)$$

$$\epsilon_{soot,j}^i = cW_{soot,j}^i - d, \quad (2.111)$$

where  $\beta_{j,ads}^i$  is calculated using Equation (2.84). The values of  $a$ ,  $b$ ,  $c$ , and  $d$  are the same as those explained in the inception part. Computing  $\epsilon_{soot,j}^i$  also requires the equivalent soot molecular weight,  $W_{soot}^i$ , which is estimated from carbon mass of each agglomerate as:

$$W_{soot}^i = \frac{C_{tot}^i W_{carbon}}{N_{agg}^i}. \quad (2.112)$$

The rate constant of carbonization of Soot-PAH<sub>j</sub><sup>\*</sup> is defined as in an Arrhenius form similar to the inception formulation (Equation (2.104)). The pre-exponential factor is adjusted by matching the numerical PSD [49] with measurements in the ethylene pyrolysis in a flow reactor [151].

$$k_{c,ads} = 2 \times 10^{10} \cdot e^{(-96232/RT)}. \quad (2.113)$$

The total adsorption rate can be calculated assuming a steady-state concentration for the physically adsorbed PAH on soot, i.e.,  $\partial[\text{Soot-PAH}_j^*]/\partial t = 0$ , calculated in a similar way to the inception flux (Equation (2.105)) as:

$$\omega_{ads_j}^i = k_{c,ads} \frac{k_{f,ads_j} [\text{soot}^i] [\text{PAH}_j]}{k_{r,ads_j} + k_{c,ads_j}}, \quad (2.114)$$

The contribution of PAH adsorption rate to the partial source terms can be expressed as:

$$I_{C_{tot},ads}^i = \frac{1}{\rho} \sum_{i=1}^{n_{PAH}} \omega_{ads_j}^i n_{C,PAH_j}, \quad (2.115)$$

$$I_{H_{tot},ads}^i = \frac{1}{\rho} \sum_{i=1}^{n_{PAH}} \omega_{ads_j}^i (n_{H,PAH_j} - 2). \quad (2.116)$$

The rate of removal of PAH from the gas mixture due to inception and PAH adsorption is given as:

$$\left( \frac{d [\text{PAH}_j]}{dt} \right)_{inc} = - \sum_{k=1}^{n_{PAH}} \omega_{dim_{jk}}, \quad (2.117)$$

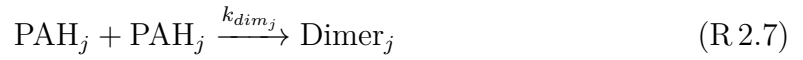
$$\left( \frac{d [\text{PAH}_j]}{dt} \right)_{ads} = - \sum_{i=1}^{n_{sec}} \omega_{ads_j}^i. \quad (2.118)$$

Additionally, during the PAH adsorption process one H<sub>2</sub> is released to the gas mixture changing the concentration of H<sub>2</sub> as:

$$\left( \frac{d [\text{H}_2]}{dt} \right)_{ads} = \sum_{i=1}^{n_{sec}} \omega_{ads_j}^i. \quad (2.119)$$

### 2.4.3 Dimer Coalescence

The Dimer Coalescence model is a multi-step irreversible model proposed by Blanquart and Pitsch [147] where self-collision of PAH molecules forms dimers, which are an intermediate state between gaseous PAH molecules and solid soot particles. The dimers can either form incipient soot particles through self-coalescence or adsorb on the surface of existing soot particles and contribute to their surface growth. The following equations describing the inception and surface growth in Dimer Coalescence adopted from the work of Sun et al. [152].



The rate constant of dimerization,  $k_{dim_j}$ , and inception,  $k_{inc_j}$ , are calculated from the collision rate of PAHs as:

$$k_{dim_j} = \gamma_{dim_j} \cdot \beta_{jj,PAH} \cdot Av, \quad (2.120)$$

$$k_{inc_j} = \beta_{jj,dimer} \cdot Av, \quad (2.121)$$

where  $\beta_{jj,PAH}$ ,  $\beta_{jj,dimer}$  are both calculated using Equation (2.78).  $\gamma_{dim_j}$  is the dimerization efficiency assumed to scale with the fourth power of the PAH molecular weight [53] as:

$$\gamma_{dim_j} = C_{N,j} \cdot W_{PAH_j}^4. \quad (2.122)$$

Blanquart and Pitsch [147] estimated the constant  $C_{N,j}$  in Equation (2.122) by comparing the profiles of several PAH species with the experimental measurements in a single premixed benzene flame [153], and provide  $C_{N,j}$  values for various PAHs, which are listed in Table 1 in [53]. The rate of dimer collision is expressed as:

$$\omega_{dim_j} = \eta_{inc} k_{inc_j} [\text{Dimer}_j] [\text{Dimer}_j]. \quad (2.123)$$

Similarly, the rate of adsorption of dimers on soot particles is obtained as:

$$\omega_{ads_j}^i = \eta_{ads} k_{ads_j}^i [\text{soot}^i] [\text{Dimer}_j], \quad (2.124)$$

$$k_{ads_j}^i = \beta_{ads_j}^i \cdot Av. \quad (2.125)$$

Assuming fast dimer consumption leads to the steady-state concentration of dimers, which can be determined by solving a quadratic equation [53] as:

$$a_{inc_j}[\text{Dimer}_j]^2 + b_{ads_j}[\text{Dimer}_j] = \omega_{dim,j}, \quad (2.126)$$

$$[\text{Dimer}_j] = \begin{cases} \frac{-b_{ads_j} + \sqrt{\Delta_j}}{2a_{inc_j}}, & \text{if } \Delta_j \geq 0, \\ 0 & \text{if } \Delta_j < 0 \end{cases}, \quad (2.127)$$

$$\Delta_j = b_{ads_j}^2 + 4a_{inc_j}\omega_{dim,j}, \quad (2.128)$$

where  $a_{inc_j} = k_{inc_j}$  and  $b_{ads_j}$  is calculated by summing the adsorption rate of dimers for all sections as:

$$b_{ads_j} = \sum_{i=1}^{n_{sec}} k_{ads_j}^i [\text{soot}^i] \quad (2.129)$$

After determining the concentration of each dimer, the contributions of inception and PAH adsorption to the source terms of the tracked soot variables can be calculated in a manner similar to previous inception models, by accounting for the number of carbon and hydrogen atoms involved in the process as:

$$I_{N,inc} = \frac{1}{\rho} \sum_{j=1}^{n_{PAH}} 4\omega_{inc_j} n_{PAH_j,C}, \quad (2.130)$$

$$I_{C_{tot},inc} = \frac{1}{\rho} \sum_{j=1}^{n_{PAH}} 4\omega_{inc_j} n_{PAH_j,C}, \quad (2.131)$$

$$I_{H_{tot},inc} = \frac{1}{\rho} \sum_{j=1}^{n_{PAH}} 4\omega_{inc_j} n_{PAH_j,H}, \quad (2.132)$$

$$I_{C_{tot},ads}^i = \frac{1}{\rho} \sum_{i=1}^{n_{PAH}} 2\omega_{ads_j}^i n_{C,PAH_j}, \quad (2.133)$$

$$I_{H_{tot},ads}^i = \frac{1}{\rho} \sum_{i=1}^{n_{PAH}} 2\omega_{ads_j}^i (n_{H,PAH_j} - 1). \quad (2.134)$$

The rate of removal of PAHs and release of H<sub>2</sub> molecule due to PAH adsorption is calculated as:

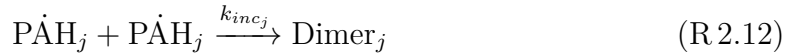
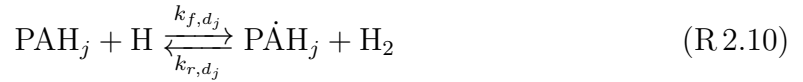
$$\left(\frac{d[\text{PAH}_j]}{dt}\right)_{inc} = -4 \sum_{k=1}^{n_{PAH}} \omega_{inc_j}, \quad (2.135)$$

$$\left(\frac{d[\text{PAH}_j]}{dt}\right)_{ads} = -2 \sum_{i=1}^{n_{sec}} \omega_{ads_j}^i, \quad (2.136)$$

$$\left(\frac{d[\text{H}_2]}{dt}\right)_{ads} = \sum_{i=1}^{n_{sec}} \omega_{ads_j}^i. \quad (2.137)$$

#### 2.4.4 E-Bridge Modified

The E-Bridge model was originally proposed by Frenklach and Mebel [25] to describe soot inception using a HACA-like scheme that starts with the dehydrogenation of PAH monomers, often pyrene, which forms the monomer radicals and continues with the sequential addition of the radicals that form dimers, trimers and larger polymers until the PAH structure reaches a mass threshold and the clustering process becomes irreversible [25]. Here, a modified version of this model, called E-Bridge Modified, is used where dimers are considered as incipient soot, and monomer radicals are adsorbed on soot agglomerates. This PAH growth model is described using the following set of pathways:



The rate constants of Reactions (R 2.10) and (R 2.11) are listed in Table 2.2.  $k_{inc_j}$  and  $k_{ads_j}$  are the rate constants of dimer production and PAH adsorption, respectively, which are calculated as:

$$k_{inc_j} = \beta_{jj,PAH} \cdot Av, \quad (2.138)$$

$$k_{ads_j}^i = \beta_{ads_j}^i \cdot Av, \quad (2.139)$$

Table 2.2 Rate coefficients for the monomer de-/hydrogenation reaction of E-bridge formation in Arrhenius form  $k = AT^n \cdot e^{-E/RT}$  [25].

| Reaction |   | A [m <sup>3</sup> /mol · s] | n    | E/R [K]  |
|----------|---|-----------------------------|------|----------|
| (R 2.10) | f | $98 \times n_{C,PAH_j}$     | 1.8  | 7563.519 |
|          | r | $1.6 \times 10^{-2}$        | 2.63 | 2145.346 |
| (R 2.11) | f | $4.8658 \times 10^7$        | 0.13 | 0.0      |

where  $\beta_{jj,PAH}$  and  $\beta_{ads_j}^i$  are obtained using Equations (2.78) and (2.84), respectively. The rate of dimer formation and adsorption is calculated as:

$$\omega_{dim_j} = k_{inc_j} [\cdot PAH_j]^2, \quad (2.140)$$

$$\omega_{ads_j}^i = k_{ads_j}^i [soot^i] [P\dot{A}H_j]. \quad (2.141)$$

The calculation of rate of inception and PAH adsorption from  $PAH_j$  requires the concentration of  $P\dot{A}H_j$ , which can be determined by applying the steady-state assumption for  $P\dot{A}H_j$ , i.e.,  $d[P\dot{A}H_j]/dt = 0$ , resulting in a quadratic equation as:

$$a_{inc_j} [P\dot{A}H_j]^2 + b_{ads_j} [P\dot{A}H_j] + c_j = 0, \quad (2.142)$$

$$a_{inc_j} = k_{inc_j} \quad (2.143)$$

$$b_{ads_j} = k_{r,d_j} [H_2] + k_{f,h_j} [H] + \sum_{i=1}^{n_{sec}} k_{ads_j}^i [Soot]^i \quad (2.144)$$

$$c_{inc_j} = k_{f,d_j} [PAH_j] [H] \quad (2.145)$$

Solving the quadratic equation for each PAH gives the concentration of  $P\dot{A}H_j$  as:

$$[P\dot{A}H_j] = \begin{cases} \frac{-b_{ads_j} + \sqrt{\Delta_j}}{2a_{inc_j}}, & \text{if } \Delta_j \geq 0 \\ 0 & \text{if } \Delta_j < 0 \end{cases} \quad (2.146)$$

$$\Delta_j = b_{ads_j}^2 - 4a_{inc_j} c_j \quad (2.147)$$

The partial source terms of inception,  $I_{\varphi,inc}$ , are calculated in the E-Bridge Modified model as:



$$I_{N,inc} = \frac{1}{\rho} \sum_{j=1}^{n_{PAH}} 2\omega_{inc_j} n_{PAH_j,C}, \quad (2.148)$$

$$I_{C_{tot},inc} = \frac{1}{\rho} \sum_{j=1}^{n_{PAH}} 2\omega_{inc_j} n_{PAH_j,C}, \quad (2.149)$$

$$I_{H_{tot},inc} = \frac{1}{\rho} \sum_{j=1}^{n_{PAH}} \omega_{inc_j} (n_{PAH_j,H} - 2), \quad (2.150)$$

The partial source terms of PAH adsorption,  $I_{\varphi,ads}^i$ , are calculated for each section in this PAH growth model as:

$$I_{C_{tot},ads}^i = \frac{1}{\rho} \sum_{i=1}^{n_{PAH}} \omega_{ads_j}^i n_{C,PAH_j}, \quad (2.151)$$

$$I_{H_{tot},ads}^i = \frac{1}{\rho} \sum_{i=1}^{n_{PAH}} \omega_{ads_j}^i (n_{H,PAH_j} - 2). \quad (2.152)$$

The rate of removal of each PAH involved in soot inception and PAH adsorption, and release of H<sub>2</sub> to the gas mixture can be expressed as:

$$\left( \frac{d[PAH_j]}{dt} \right)_{inc} = -2 \sum_{k=1}^{n_{sec}} \omega_{inc_j}, \quad (2.153)$$

$$\left( \frac{d[PAH_j]}{dt} \right)_{ads} = - \sum_{i=1}^{n_{sec}} \omega_{ads_j}^i, \quad (2.154)$$

$$\left( \frac{d[H_2]}{dt} \right)_{inc} = \sum_{i=1}^{n_{sec}} \omega_{ads_j}^i. \quad (2.155)$$

### 2.4.5 Summary of features

The comparison of key features of the implemented PAH growth models is provided in Table 2.3. As shown in Fig. 2.6 the inception flux predicted by the Reactive Dimerization and E-Bridge Modified models increases exponentially with temperature (that is, decreases with its inverse), whereas the Irreversible Dimerization and Dimer Coalescence models show only about a factor-of-two increase over the range 500-2500 K.

Table 2.3 The summary of key features of PAH growth models.

| Name            | Reversibility | Temperature dependence           | The sequence of steps in inception mechanism                                                                                    |
|-----------------|---------------|----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Irrev.Dim. [40] | Irreversible  | Weak,<br>$\propto \sqrt{T}$      | $[\text{PAH}] \xrightarrow{\text{collision}} [\text{Dim.}]$                                                                     |
| Reac.Dim. [56]  | Reversible    | Strong,<br>$\propto e^{-E/(RT)}$ | $[\text{PAH}] \xrightleftharpoons{\text{collision}} [\text{Phy.Dim.}] \xrightarrow{\text{carbonization}} [\text{Chem.Dim}]$     |
| Dim.Coal. [53]  | Irreversible  | Weak,<br>$\propto \sqrt{T}$      | $[\text{PAH}] \xrightarrow{\text{collision}} [\text{Dim.}] \xrightarrow{\text{collision}} [\text{Tetra.}]$                      |
| EBri.Mod. [25]  | Reversible    | Strong,<br>$\propto e^{-E/(RT)}$ | $[\text{PAH}] \xrightleftharpoons{\text{dehydrogenation}} [\text{Rad.}]$<br>$\xrightarrow{\text{collision}} [\text{Chem.Dim.}]$ |

Dim. denotes PAH dimers.

Phy.Dim. and Chem.Dim. represent physically- and chemically-bonded dimers, respectively.

Rad. and Tetra. refer to a PAH radical and a tetramer, respectively.

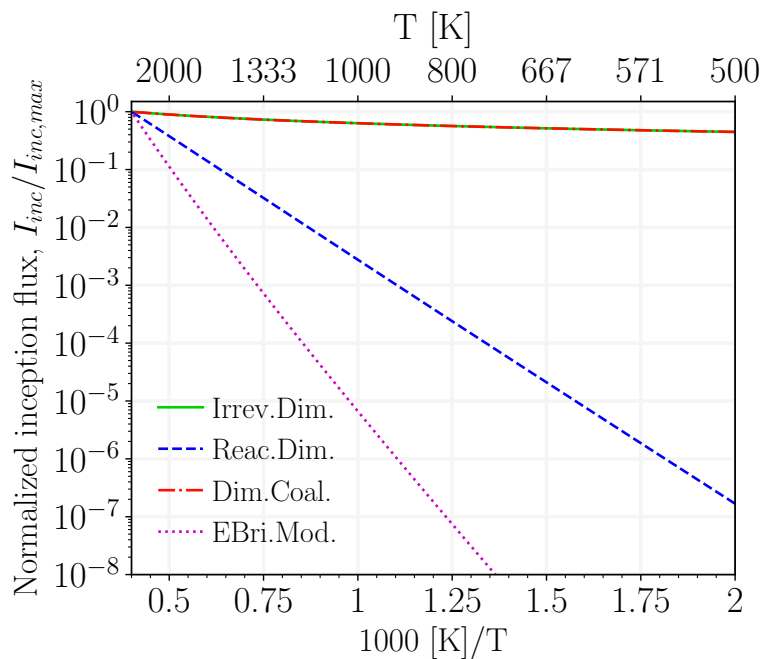


Fig. 2.6 The temperature dependence of inception flux,  $I_{inc}$ , predicted using various PAH growth models.  $I_{inc}$  of each model is normalized with its maximum to facilitate the comparison.

## 2.5 Surface reactions model

Heterogeneous surface reactions are described by HACA. The soot growth in HACA scheme is based on a sequential process similar to PAH growth. The hydrogenated armchair sites ( $C_{\text{soot}} - H$ ) on the edge of aromatic rings are dehydrogenated by H abstraction forming  $C_{\text{soot}}^\circ$  that bonds with  $C_2H_2$  resulting in an additional aromatic ring with hydrogenated sites. These sites can also be attacked by  $O_2$  or  $OH$  leading to removal of carbon from soot particles by oxidation. The elementary reactions that describe this sequential process are listed in Table 2.4. The rate of mass growth by HACA is obtained from the reaction of  $C_2H_2$  with dehydrogenated sites as:

$$\omega_{gr}^i = \alpha^i k_{f4} [C_2H_2] [C_{\text{soot}}^\circ]^i, \quad (2.156)$$

where  $k_{f4}$  denotes the forward rate of Reaction (R2.17) in Table 2.4, and  $[C_{\text{soot}}^\circ]^i$  is obtained by multiplying the surface density of dehydrogenated sites,  $C_{\text{soot}}^\circ$  by the total surface area of soot (per unit of mass of gas mixture) of each section as:

$$[C_{\text{soot}}^\circ]^i = \frac{\rho}{A_v} A_{tot}^i \cdot \chi_{\text{soot}^\circ}, \quad (2.157)$$

where  $\chi_{\text{soot}^\circ}$  is the surface density of dehydrogenated sites, and is calculated by assuming the steady-state for  $[C_{\text{soot}}^\circ]$  in the system of reactions in Table 2.4 as:

$$\chi_{\text{soot}^\circ} = \frac{k_{f1}[H] + k_{f2}[OH]}{k_{r1}[H_2] + k_{r2}[H_2O] + k_{f3}[H] + k_{f4}[C_2H_2] + k_{f5}[O_2]} \chi_{\text{soot}-H}, \quad (2.158)$$

where  $\chi_{\text{soot}-H}$  is the surface density of hydrogenated sites estimated based on the assumption that soot "surface is assumed to be composed of outwardlooking PAH edges with PAH molecular moieties assembled into turbostratic structures" [154]. Considering the layer spacing of  $3.15\text{\AA}$  and two C-H bonds per benzene ring length,  $\chi_{\text{soot}-H}$  is calculated to be  $0.23\text{ site}/\text{\AA}^2 = 2.3 \times 10^{19} \text{ site}/\text{m}^2$ , which gives the maximum theoretical limit of the reaction sites.

In Equation (2.156),  $\alpha^i$  is the surface reactivity factor between 0 and 1 that represents the decline of reaction sites from the theoretical limit due to PAH layer orientation, particle aging, growth and maturity [155, 156], and it has been observed to depend on temperature-time history [157, 59]. The value of  $\alpha$  has been described using constant target-specific values as well as empirical equations based on particle size and flame temperature. A detailed review of these can be found in Chapter 4 of [158]. Here, the empirical equation proposed by Appel et al. [57] is used to calculate

$\alpha^i$  as:

$$\alpha^i = \tanh \left( \frac{12.56 - 0.00563T}{\log_{10} \left( \frac{\rho_{soot} \cdot Av}{W_{carbon}} \frac{\pi}{6} d_p^3 \right)} - 1.38 + 0.00068T \right). \quad (2.159)$$

Alternatively,  $\alpha^i$  can be related to the H/C ratio of soot particles by assuming that all hydrogen atoms reside on the particle surface [147] as:

$$\alpha^i = \frac{H_{tot}^i}{C_{tot}^i}. \quad (2.160)$$

The contribution of HACA to growth source terms can be computed from HACA rates considering the number of carbon atoms in  $C_2H_2$  and number of arm-chair and zig-zag hydrogenated sites on soot particle [53] using

$$I_{C_{tot},haca}^i = 2\omega_{gr}^i/\rho, \quad (2.161)$$

$$I_{H_{tot},haca}^i = 0.25\omega_{gr}^i/\rho. \quad (2.162)$$

The rates of concentration change of  $C_2H_2$  and H radical due to HACA are written as:

$$\left( \frac{d[C_2H_2]}{dt} \right)_{gr} = - \sum_{i=1}^{n_{sec}} \omega_{gr}^i, \quad (2.163)$$

$$\left( \frac{d[H]}{dt} \right)_{gr} = 1.75 \sum_{i=1}^{n_{sec}} \omega_{gr}^i. \quad (2.164)$$

The carbons on the surface of soot are oxidized via reaction with  $O_2$  (Reaction (R 2.18)) and OH (Reaction (R 2.19)). As a result, oxidation decreases the total carbon of soot and releases CO and  $H_2$  to the gas mixture. The  $O_2$  and OH oxidation rates are calculated as:

$$\omega_{ox,O_2}^i = \alpha^i k_{f5} [O_2] [C_{soot}^i], \quad (2.165)$$

$$\omega_{ox,OH}^i = \gamma_{OH} \beta_{OH}^i Av [OH] [soot^i], \quad (2.166)$$

where  $\gamma_{OH} = 0.13$  is the reaction probability of OH radicals with soot particles [57].  $\beta_{OH}$  is the collision frequency of OH and soot particles calculated based on the kinetic theory of gases as:

Table 2.4 Arrhenius rate coefficients of the surface reactions in HACA [57],  $k = AT^n \cdot e^{-E/RT}$ .

| No.      | Reaction                                                                                    |   | A [m <sup>3</sup> /mol · s] | n     | E/R [K] |
|----------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---|-----------------------------|-------|---------|
| (R 2.14) | $C_{\text{soot-H}} + H \xrightleftharpoons[k_{r,1}]{k_{f,1}} C_{\text{soot}^\circ} + H_2$   | f | $4.17 \times 10^7$          | 0     | 6542.52 |
|          |                                                                                             | r | $3.9 \times 10^6$           | 0     | 5535.98 |
| (R 2.15) | $C_{\text{soot-H}} + OH \xrightleftharpoons[k_{r,2}]{k_{f,2}} C_{\text{soot}^\circ} + H_2O$ | f | $10^4$                      | 0.734 | 719.68  |
|          |                                                                                             | r | $3.68 \times 10^2$          | 1.139 | 8605.94 |
| (R 2.16) | $C_{\text{soot}^\circ} + H \xrightarrow{k_{f,3}} C_{\text{soot-H}}$                         | f | $10^4$                      | 0.734 | 719.68  |
| (R 2.17) | $C_{\text{soot}^\circ} + C_2H_2 \xrightarrow{k_{f,4}} C_{\text{soot-H}} + H$                | f | 80                          | 1.56  | 1912.43 |
| (R 2.18) | $C_{\text{soot}^\circ} + O_2 \xrightarrow{k_{f,5}} 2 CO + \text{product}$                   | f | $2.2 \times 10^6$           | 0     | 3774.53 |
| (R 2.19) | $C_{\text{soot-H}} + OH \xrightarrow{k_{f,6}} CO + \text{product}$                          | f | $\gamma_{OH} = 0.13$        |       |         |

$$\beta_{OH}^i = \sqrt{\frac{\pi k_B T}{2} \left( \frac{1}{m_{agg}^i} + \frac{1}{m_{OH}} \right) (d_c^i + d_{OH})^2}, \quad (2.167)$$

where  $m_{OH} = 2.824 \times 10^{-26}$  kg, and  $d_{OH} = 0.3$  nm [159] are the mass and equivalent diameter of a OH radical, respectively. Then, the oxidation source term is calculated considering the number of carbon atoms removed from soot through each oxidation pathway as:

$$I_{C_{tot},ox}^i = (2\omega_{ox,O_2}^i + \omega_{ox,OH}^i)/\rho. \quad (2.168)$$

The rate of change of concentration of CO, O<sub>2</sub> and OH by oxidation is calculates as:

$$\left( \frac{d[CO]}{dt} \right)_{ox} = 2 \sum_{i=1}^{n_{sec}} \omega_{ox,O_2}^i, \quad (2.169)$$

$$\left( \frac{d[O_2]}{dt} \right)_{ox} = - \sum_{i=1}^{n_{sec}} \omega_{ox,O_2}^i, \quad (2.170)$$

$$\left( \frac{d[OH]}{dt} \right)_{ox} = - \sum_{i=1}^{n_{sec}} \omega_{ox,OH}^i, \quad (2.171)$$

$$\left(\frac{d[H]}{dt}\right)_{ox} = \sum_{i=1}^{n_{sec}} \omega_{ox,OH}^i. \quad (2.172)$$

## 2.6 Gas scrubbing rates

The rate of production/destruction of species involved in soot formation must be taken into account to preserve the mass and energy balance in reactive systems. In order to do that, the production rate of gaseous species calculated by Cantera must be corrected for the rate of release/consumption due to PAH growth and surface reaction models.

$$\left(\frac{d[PAH_j]}{dt}\right)_{tot} = \left(\frac{d[PAH_j]}{dt}\right)_{gas} + \left(\frac{d[PAH_j]}{dt}\right)_{inc} + \left(\frac{d[PAH_j]}{dt}\right)_{ads}. \quad (2.173)$$

H<sub>2</sub> is released to the gas mixture due to inception, PAH adsorption as well as oxidation.

$$\left(\frac{d[H_2]}{dt}\right)_{tot} = \left(\frac{d[H_2]}{dt}\right)_{gas} + \left(\frac{d[H_2]}{dt}\right)_{inc} + \left(\frac{d[H_2]}{dt}\right)_{ads} + \left(\frac{d[H_2]}{dt}\right)_{ox}. \quad (2.174)$$

Surface growth consumes C<sub>2</sub>H<sub>2</sub> and adds H<sub>2</sub> to the gas mixture.

$$\left(\frac{d[C_2H_2]}{dt}\right)_{tot} = \left(\frac{d[C_2H_2]}{dt}\right)_{gas} + \left(\frac{d[C_2H_2]}{dt}\right)_{gr}. \quad (2.175)$$

$$\left(\frac{d[H]}{dt}\right)_{tot} = \left(\frac{d[H]}{dt}\right)_{gas} + \left(\frac{d[H]}{dt}\right)_{gr}. \quad (2.176)$$

Oxidation uses O<sub>2</sub> and OH to remove carbon from soot particles and generates H<sub>2</sub> and CO.

$$\left(\frac{d[CO]}{dt}\right)_{tot} = \left(\frac{d[CO]}{dt}\right)_{gas} + \left(\frac{d[CO]}{dt}\right)_{ox}. \quad (2.177)$$

$$\left(\frac{d[O_2]}{dt}\right)_{tot} = \left(\frac{d[O_2]}{dt}\right)_{gas} + \left(\frac{d[O_2]}{dt}\right)_{ox}. \quad (2.178)$$

$$\left(\frac{d[OH]}{dt}\right)_{tot} = \left(\frac{d[OH]}{dt}\right)_{gas} + \left(\frac{d[OH]}{dt}\right)_{ox}. \quad (2.179)$$

# Chapter 3

## Code Validation

A set of simulations was performed to evaluate the accuracy and reliability of Omnisoot in predicting soot formation. The aerosol dynamics models were validated by comparing the results of the population balance models implemented in Omnisoot with DEM simulations reported in the literature. In addition, carbon and hydrogen mass and energy balances were rigorously assessed to ensure that residuals remain within the bounds of acceptable numerical error.

### 3.1 Collision Frequency

The collision frequency function determines the rate at which two particles collide, which results in the reduction of the total number of agglomerates and the increase in particle size. In the absence of strong flow shear or external forces, Brownian motion is the main driving force for particle coagulation. Omnisoot employs harmonic mean and Fuchs interpolations to calculate collision frequency of agglomerates from free-molecular to continuum regimes based on the gas mean free path and the particle size.

The test case for validation of collision frequency is based on the DEM simulation of 2000 monodisperse spherical particles with the density of  $2200 \text{ kg/m}^3$  in a cubic cell with the constant temperature of 298 K and pressure of 1 atm [160]. Figure 3.1 depicts the collision frequency plotted against Knudsen number ( $\text{Kn} = 2\lambda/d_m$ ) obtained by Omnisoot using harmonic mean (red solid line) and Fuchs interpolation (blue dashed line) and the DEM results of Goudeli et al. [160]. The Fuchs interpretation perfectly matches DEM data over the free-molecular regime to the continuum regime. Harmonic mean is also in good agreement with the DEM results in the free-molecular and continuum regimes, but slightly underpredicts the collision frequency in the transition regime with relative errors less than 16%.

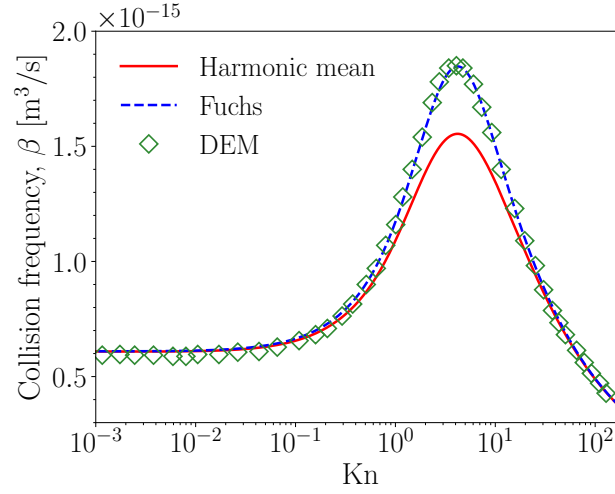


Fig. 3.1 The comparison of collision frequency,  $\beta$ , obtained by Omnisoot using harmonic mean (red solid line) and Fuchs interpolations (blue dashed line) with DEM results (symbols) [160].

## 3.2 Coagulation

Two test cases were set up to validate the coagulation sub-model of MPBM and SPBM in the free-molecular<sup>1</sup> and continuum<sup>2</sup> regimes. An adiabatic CVR with a volume of  $1 \text{ m}^3$  was populated with  $2.6261 \times 10^{18}$  spherical particles with the initial diameters of 2 nm and 668 nm for the free-molecular and continuum cases, respectively. The initial temperature in the free-molecular and continuum simulations are 1800 K and 300 K, respectively.

Figure 3.2 illustrate the schematics of the designed test in which the particles collide and grow in size through coagulation in both simulations, without inception, surface growth, or oxidation. Figure 3.3 demonstrates the evolution of  $N_{agg}$ ,  $N_{pri}$ ,  $d_m$ , and  $d_g$  as predicted by MPBM and SPBM in the free-molecular regime, which are in good agreement with DEM results [145].  $N_{pri}$  is conserved during coagulation, resulting in identical flat trends for both models. In contrast,  $N_{agg}$  decreases over time, with a faster decay observed in SPBM due to its treatment of agglomerate polydispersity, which leads to a higher collision frequency compared to MPBM. Therefore,  $d_m$  and  $d_g$  predicted by SPBM, shown in Figure 3.3b, are slightly larger than those predicted by MPBM.

<sup>1</sup>[https://github.com/mohammadadib-cu/omnisoot-cv/tree/main/validations/coagulation/free\\_molecular](https://github.com/mohammadadib-cu/omnisoot-cv/tree/main/validations/coagulation/free_molecular)

<sup>2</sup><https://github.com/mohammadadib-cu/omnisoot-cv/tree/main/validations/coagulation/continuum>



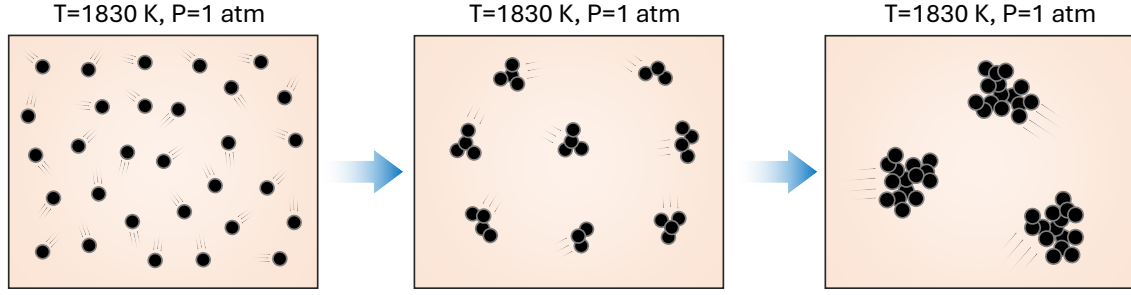


Fig. 3.2 The schematic of the agglomeration process in the coagulation test case where initially spherical particles collide and form agglomerates

The MPBM model cannot resolve the PSD due to the monodispersity assumption. In contrast, the SPBM tracks the number concentration of particles in discrete sections, which allows the construction of an evolving PSD, and the assessment of the size distribution spread. Figure 3.4 shows the evolution of the non-dimensional PSD from  $t = 1$  ms to 500 ms for the free-molecular and continuum simulations. The PSD is plotted as a function of the normalized concentration,  $\Psi = \bar{v}n_{agg}(v, t)/N_{agg, \infty}$  and dimensionless volume,  $\eta = v/\bar{v}$ , where  $n_{agg}(v, t)$  is the size distribution function of agglomerate,  $v$  is the particle volume,  $\bar{v}$  is the mean particle volume,  $N_{agg, \infty}$  is the total number concentration of agglomerates. After the initial transient ( $t > 22$  ms), the PSD rapidly evolves into a full bell curve and remains unchanged, indicating the attainment of a SPSPD. This behavior is in good agreement with DEM results and confirms the capability of the SPBM implemented in Omnisoot to capture the SPSPD for soot agglomerates in the free-molecular and continuum regimes, a characteristic outcome of Brownian-driven particle coagulation.

Figure 3.4a shows the standard deviation of the mobility diameter,  $\sigma_g$ , predicted by SPBM in the free-molecular regime, which is in close agreement with DEM results. Initially,  $\sigma_g = 1$ , indicating a monodisperse population, and it gradually increases, reaching a final value of 2.03, which corresponds to the characteristic standard deviation for the free-molecular regime [161].

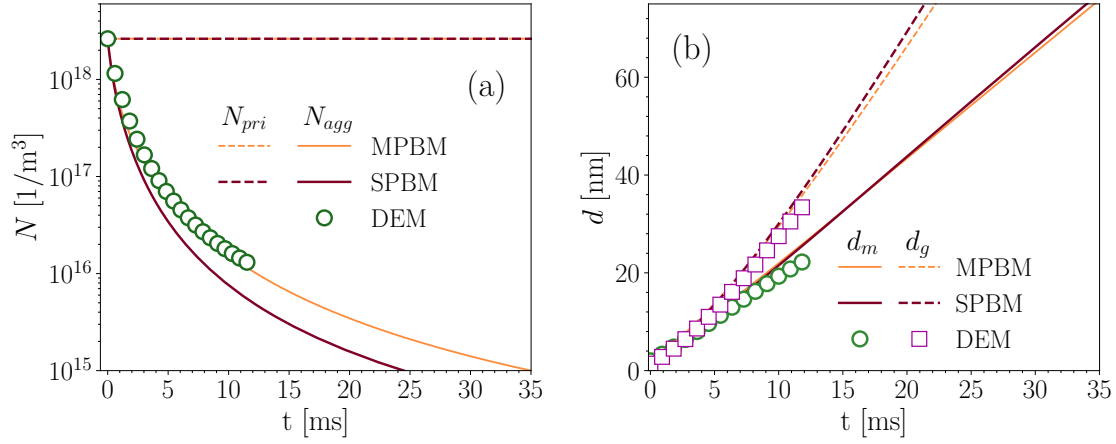


Fig. 3.3 (a) The number concentration of agglomerates and primary particles, and (b) mobility and gyration diameters obtained by Omnisoot using MPBM and SPBM in the free-molecular regime, which are in close agreement with the DEM results [145] indicating the validity of the coagulation sub-models.

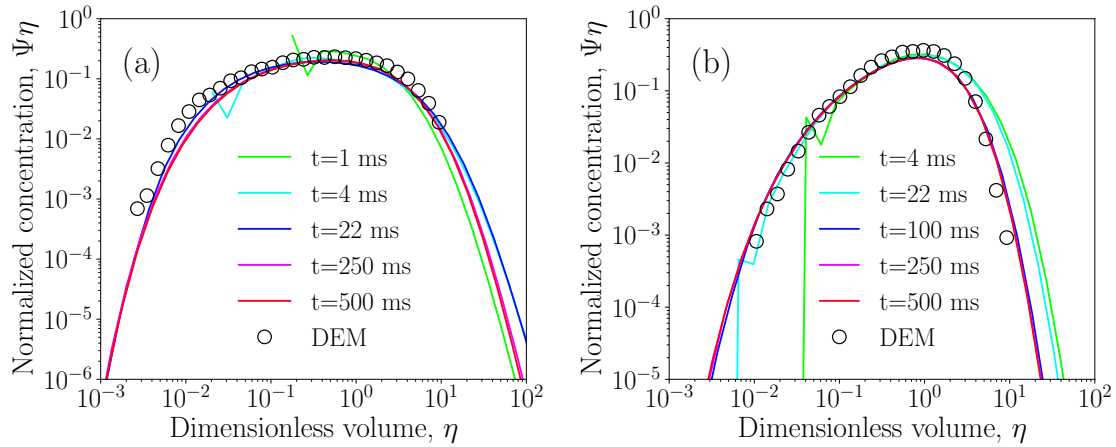


Fig. 3.4 The non-dimensional particle size distribution at different residence times in (a) the free-molecular and (b) continuum regimes overlaps after the initial transient phase, indicating the attainment of a self-preserving size distribution, which is also in good agreement with DEM results [160].

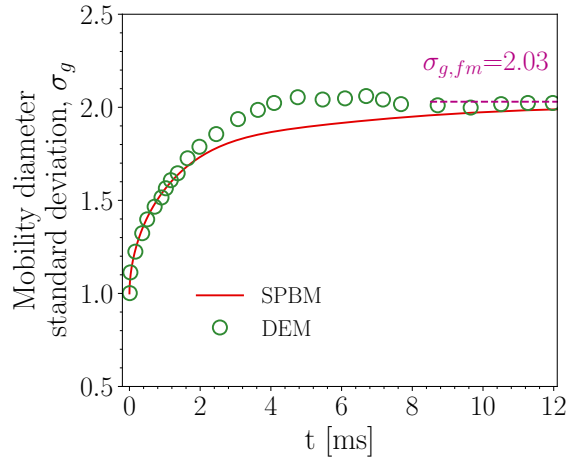


Fig. 3.5 Standard deviation of the mobility diameter,  $\sigma_g$ , in the free-molecular regime obtained by SPBM is in close agreement with DEM results [145].

### 3.3 Elemental and Energy Balance

To ensure the accuracy and reliability of the simulations, the conservation of elemental mass and energy was assessed across all reactor models implemented in Omnisoot. The elemental balances of carbon, hydrogen, and the total energy (internal or enthalpy depending on the reactor type) of the gas-particle system were evaluated during soot formation processes under various pyrolysis and combustion conditions. A set of simulations<sup>3</sup> was performed using different combinations of PAH growth and particle dynamics models, and the relative errors in elemental and energy balances were monitored over time or reactor length. The relative error of total carbon, hydrogen and energy are calculated for CVR, CPR, PSR, and PFR using different combinations of particle dynamics and inception models. The residuals for all reactor configurations remained within acceptable limits (typically below  $10^{-10}$ ), confirming that Omnisoot accurately preserves mass and energy during the coupled evolution of gas-phase and soot particles.

The pyrolysis of 30%  $\text{CH}_4$  diluted in  $\text{N}_2$  with the initial temperature and pressure of 2455 K and 3.47 atm, respectively, was simulated using CVR with a residence time of 40 ms. The combination of available PAH growth and particle dynamics models results in eight different cases, which were simulated to verify conservation of mass and energy. Here, we focus on the total elemental balance of carbon and hydrogen, as they are key elements involved in soot formation. Figure 3.6 shows the relative errors in

<sup>3</sup>[https://github.com/mohammadadib-cu/omnisoot-cv/tree/main/validations/mass\\_energy](https://github.com/mohammadadib-cu/omnisoot-cv/tree/main/validations/mass_energy)

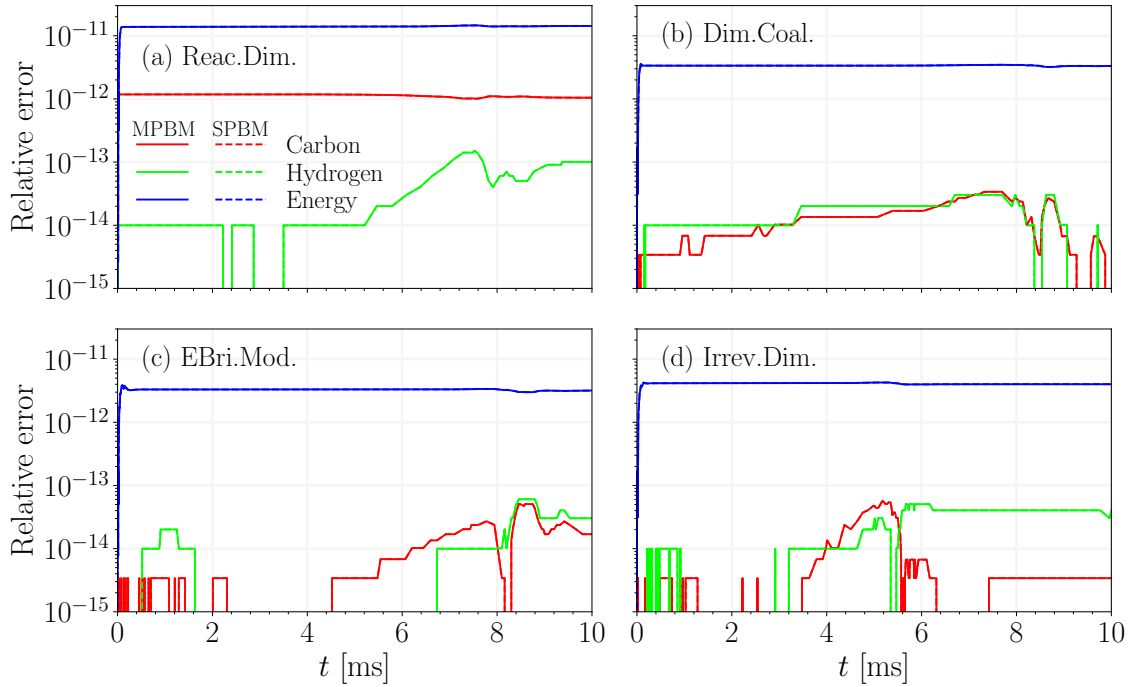


Fig. 3.6 The relative error of total carbon (red line) and hydrogen (green line) mass, and total internal energy residual of gas and soot (blue line) plotted against residence time during pyrolysis of 30%  $\text{CH}_4\text{-N}_2$  at 2455 K and 3.47 atm in the constant volume reactor simulated using four PAH growth models, and MPBM (solid line) and SPBM (dashed line).

total carbon, hydrogen, and energy for the different PAH growth and particle dynamics models. In all cases, the errors fall below  $10^{-10}$ , confirming that CVR satisfies mass and energy conservation.

The pyrolysis of 5% $\text{CH}_4$  in a shock-tube at post-reflected-shock temperature and pressure of  $T_5 = 2355$  K and  $P_5 = 4.64$  atm was simulated using IPR model. The pressure time history was measured using an end-wall sensor by the Hanson Research Group at Stanford University. The measured pressure signal was smoothed using the Savitzky–Golay filter in SciPy[162] to reduce fluctuations in the raw signal and make it suitable for the numerical solver. The measured and filtered pressure trace is shown in Fig. A.1. The residual of carbon and hydrogen mass are less than  $10^{-12}$ , while the energy residual reaches up to  $10^{-6}$  for energy by the end of the simulation. The relatively higher energy residual is attributed to pressure work.

The mass and energy balance are investigated for soot formation during ethylene-air oxidation at equivalence ratio of  $\phi = 2$  in a perfectly stirred reactor. The simulation conditions were chosen based on the combustor implemented and utilized by Stouffer

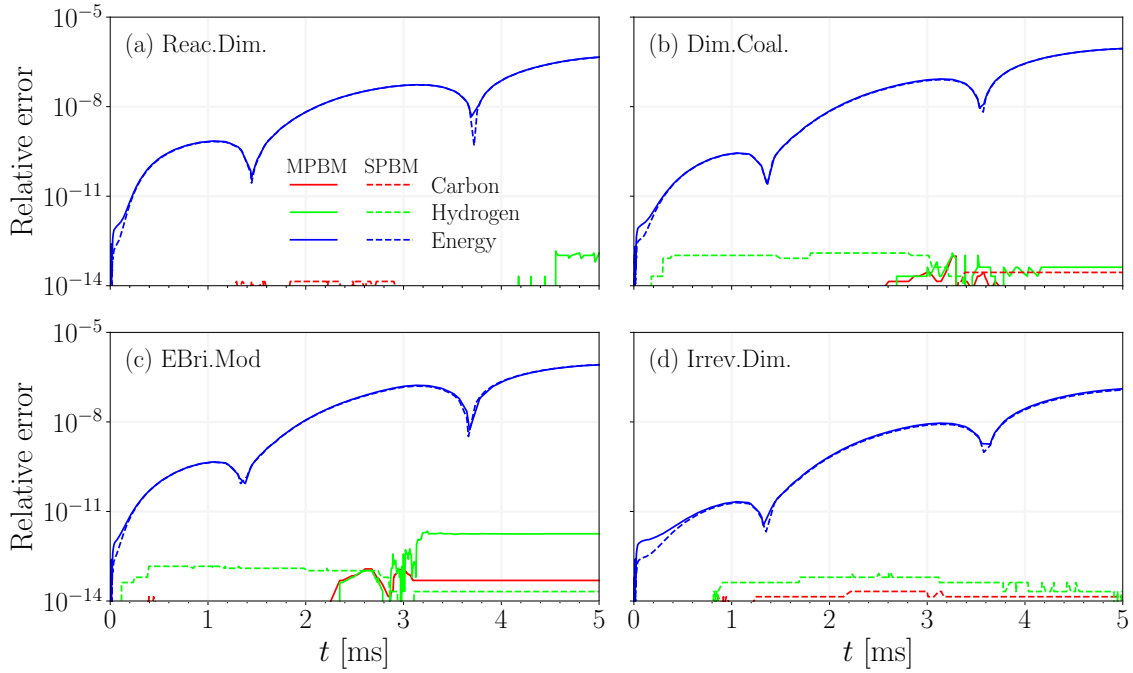


Fig. 3.7 The relative error of total carbon (red line) and hydrogen (green line) mass, and total internal energy residual of gas and soot (blue line) plotted against residence time during pyrolysis of 5%  $\text{CH}_4$ -Ar at post-reflected-shock temperature and pressure of  $T_5 = 2355$  K and  $P_5 = 4.64$  atm with an imposed pressure profile simulated using various PAH growth models, and MPBM (solid line) and SPBM (dashed line).

et al. [163]. The reactants enter the reactor with the volume of 250 ml at 300 K and atmospheric pressure. The simulation is initialized from a high temperature ( $\approx 2000$  K) to avoid trivial solution (cold reactant leaving the reactor with no chemical reactions) and to ensure the model captures a sustained combustion. The residence time of products in the reactor is 8.5 ms. Figure 3.8 shows the relative error of total elemental carbon and hydrogen mass and total enthalpy of gas and soot, which is less than  $10^{-6}$  for all combinations of particle dynamics and PAH growth models.

Methane pyrolysis in an adiabatic PFR was used to assess the conservation of elemental carbon, hydrogen, and energy. The inlet stream 30%  $\text{CH}_4$  diluted in  $\text{N}_2$  with an initial temperature of 2100 K and pressure of 1 atm. Figure 3.9 shows the residuals of total elemental carbon, hydrogen, and energy along the reactor length, up to 40 cm, for all combinations of PAH growth and particle dynamics models. The residuals remain below  $10^{-11}$ , confirming that the PFR model in Omnisoot satisfies mass and energy conservation.

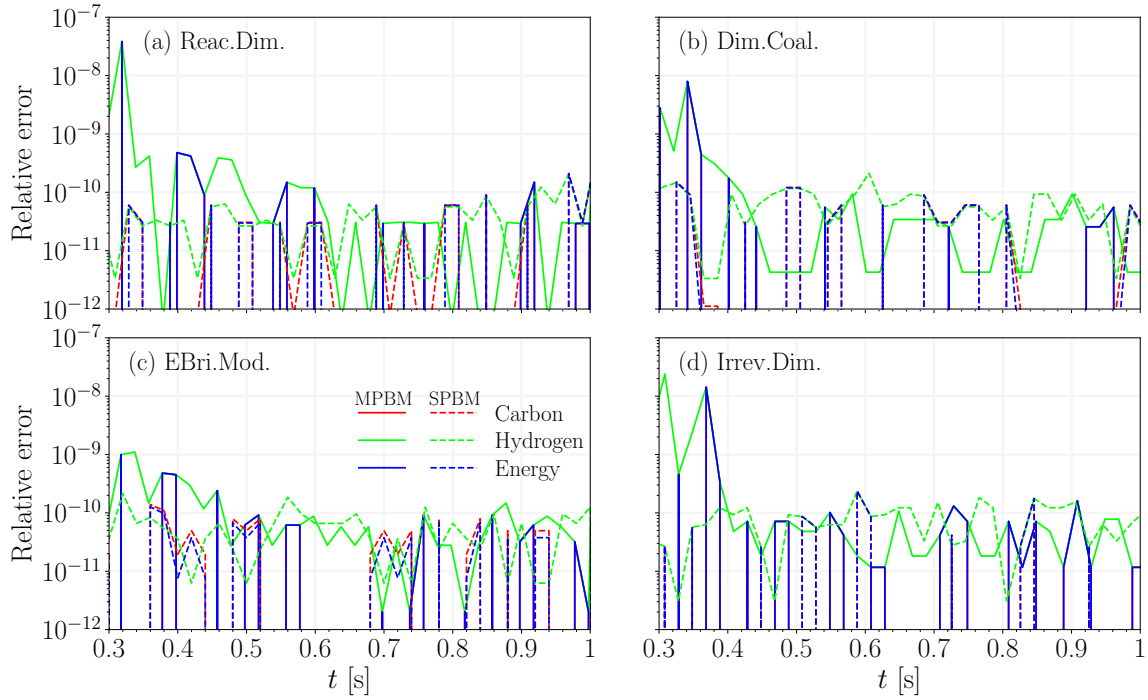


Fig. 3.8 The relative error of total carbon (red line) and hydrogen (green line) mass, and total internal energy residual of gas and soot (blue line) plotted in simulation time during adiabatic combustion of  $C_2H_4$ -air with  $\phi = 2$  at 1 atm simulated using various PAH growth models, and MPBM (solid line) and SPBM (dashed line).

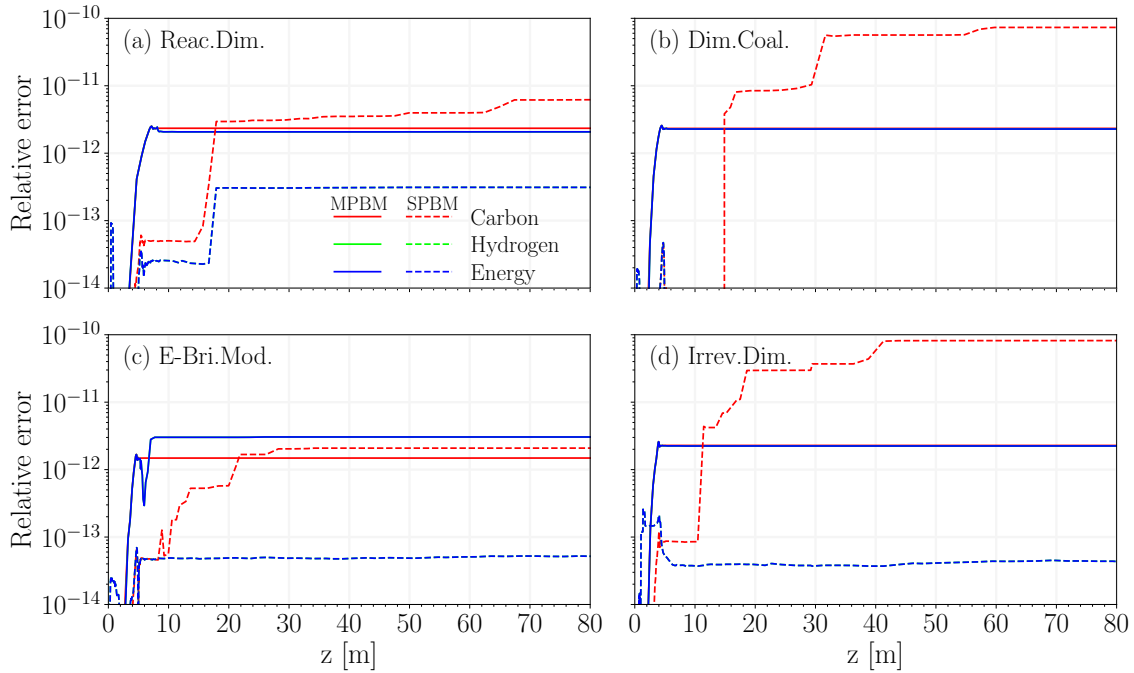


Fig. 3.9 The relative error of total carbon (red line) and hydrogen (green line) mass, and total internal energy residual of gas and soot (blue line) plotted against reactor length (cm) in the adiabatic flow reactor during pyrolysis of 30%  $CH_4$ - $N_2$  at 2100 K and 1 atm simulated using various PAH growth models, and MPBM (solid line) and SPBM (dashed line).

# Chapter 4

## Results and Discussion

This chapter demonstrates the application of Omnisoot in various use-cases. Each section of the chapter represents a paper, in which Omnisoot was used for predicting soot yield, morphology and size distribution. The uncertainties from gas-phase chemistry and empirically-derived inception pathways were highlighted and discussed. The carbon flux from gas to solid via inception, HACA and PAH adsorption were investigated to understand their effect on soot properties. A special attention was paid to methane pyrolysis in shock-tubes with different compositions, and temperatures, and pressures because temperature and pressure ranges achieved in shock-tube experiments can reach 2300 K and 5 atm that are relevant to CB synthesis in industrial plasma reactors [9], which is a major motivations for developing Omnisoot. Additionally, a unique experimental data-set were compiled and processed in a joint program between Carleton-Monolith-Stanford. The shock-tube experimental campaign cover a wide range of high methane loadings (5%, 10%, and 30%) and temperature sweep of 1800 K-2500 K, and it provides simultaneous species and particulate measurements.

### 4.1 Fundamental analysis of PAH growth models

This section presents an extended version of the paper titled “*Omnisoot: a process design package for gas-phase synthesis of carbonaceous nanoparticles*” published in *Combustion and Flame*<sup>1</sup>. In the paper, we introduced Omnisoot as an integrated platform for modeling soot formation using 0D reactors. Theoretical foundation and governing equations were discussed in Chapter 2. The results and discussion in the paper focused on (i) understanding the uncertainties in predicted soot properties due to

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<sup>1</sup><https://doi.org/10.1016/j.combustflame.2025.114758>

gas-phase chemistry caused by the variability of reaction pathways and rate constants implemented in kinetic mechanisms (ii) the physio-chemical differences in PAH growth models when inception and PAH adsorption rates were adjusted by varying  $\eta_{inc}$  and  $\eta_{ads}$  to closely reproduce the experimental results.

### 4.1.1 Uncertainties in gas chemistry

Prior studies have shown that the predicted concentrations of large PAHs can vary by orders of magnitude depending on the reaction mechanism used [164]. This variation introduces substantial uncertainty in the predicted rates of soot inception and surface growth. As a result, the reliability of soot simulations depends more on the accuracy of upstream chemical kinetics than on the rate constants of the inception models.

To illustrate the impact of chemical mechanism selection on predict soot properties, a series of simulations<sup>2</sup> were performed using the CPR model of Omnisoot (with soot formation disabled) for the pyrolysis of 5% CH<sub>4</sub>-Ar mixture at  $T_5 = 2203$  K and  $P_5 = 4.9$  atm [165]. Six widely used chemical mechanisms were evaluated: ABF [57], Caltech [166], KAUST [167], CRECK [168], ITV [169], and FFCM2 [170].

Fig. 4.1 shows the large variability in the predicted mole fraction of CH<sub>4</sub>, C<sub>2</sub>H<sub>4</sub>, and C<sub>2</sub>H<sub>2</sub> across different reaction mechanisms. The mole fraction of CH<sub>4</sub> serves as a useful indicator of carbon flux from the fuel to small and large intermediates. The CRECK and KAUST mechanisms significantly underpredict methane mole fraction compared to the measurements, but ABF and FFCM2 provide more accurate prediction considering the uncertainty of the experimental data. The carbon flux analysis by Wang et al. [164] highlighted the major role of C<sub>2</sub>H<sub>4</sub> in the production of C<sub>2</sub>H<sub>2</sub> via vinyl radical (C<sub>2</sub>H<sub>3</sub>). The overall trend of C<sub>2</sub>H<sub>4</sub> mole fraction is captured by all mechanisms. After the rapid initial jump, C<sub>2</sub>H<sub>4</sub> reaches its peak, which is underpredicted by ITV and overpredicted by KAUST. The subsequent decline was overestimated by all mechanisms that predict the final value of  $\simeq 10^{-4}$  below the measurements. A similar variability is observed in the prediction of C<sub>2</sub>H<sub>2</sub> mole fraction: it is best captured by FFCM2, overpredicted by CRECK, and slightly underpredicted by the ITV and Caltech mechanisms. Among all, FFCM2 shows the best overall agreement with the measurements; however, this mechanism only includes C<sub>1</sub>-C<sub>4</sub> species and excludes benzene and larger PAHs, so it cannot be coupled with the soot models considered in this study.

Next, we examine the maximum possible soot yield predicted by the selected mechanisms (excluding FFCM2) during 5% CH<sub>4</sub> pyrolysis at  $T_5 = 2203$  K and

<sup>2</sup>[https://github.com/mohammadadib-cu/omnisoot-cv/tree/main/examples/pressure/mechanism\\_comparison](https://github.com/mohammadadib-cu/omnisoot-cv/tree/main/examples/pressure/mechanism_comparison)



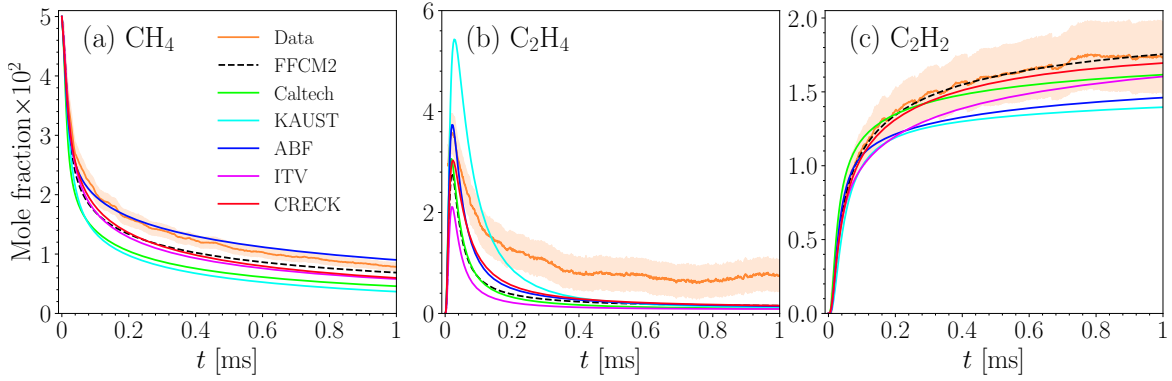


Fig. 4.1 The mole fraction of (a)  $\text{CH}_4$ , (b)  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_4$  and (c)  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_2$  during pyrolysis of 5%  $\text{CH}_4$ -Ar predicted using different reaction mechanisms and compared with measurements [165].

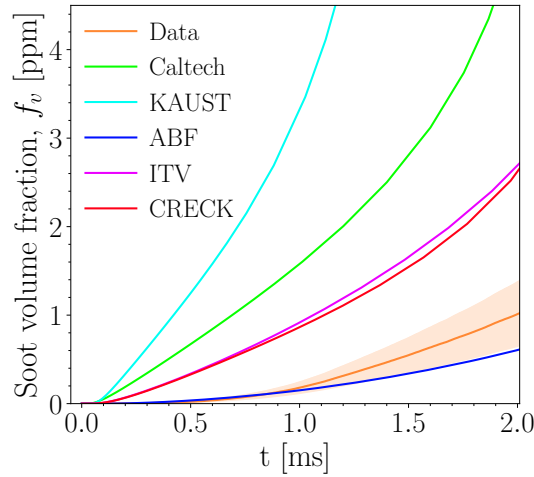


Fig. 4.2 The maximum soot volume fraction predicted using Irreversible Dimerization and different reaction mechanisms during pyrolysis of 5%  $\text{CH}_4$ -Ar was compared with measurements [165]. The shaded area represents the uncertainty in the reported experimental data.

$P_5 = 4.9$  atm. To do so, the Irreversible Dimerization model is employed with 100% efficiency for both inception and PAH adsorption (i.e., all collisions lead to inception or surface growth). As shown in Fig. 4.2, the maximum possible  $f_v$  predicted by the mechanisms shows greater relative variation than that observed for  $\text{CH}_4$  and  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_2$ . Furthermore, the  $f_v$  predicted by the ABF mechanism is lower than the measured value, even when accounting for the reported uncertainty. The same analysis was performed for other data points with a different  $T_5$  in [165], and similar results were observed indicating that ABF mechanism cannot provide enough precursors under pyrolysis conditions in these simulations. In contrast, the maximum possible  $f_v$  predicted by

other mechanisms is significantly larger than the measurements, which presents the possibility of predicting  $f_v$  close to the measurements using more realistic assumptions (i.e., lower dimerization efficiencies). Caltech and KAUST mechanisms are used in the simulations of this study for description of gas chemistry as they provide the highest carbon flux to soot precursors, and they are still computationally more affordable than ITV and CRECK mechanisms for parametric studies.

In the rest of the results, the inception and PAH adsorption rates of PAH growth models are adjusted by calibrating  $\eta_{inc}$  and  $\eta_{ads}$  to match predict soot properties with available measurements. Note that, this approach does not resolve the mechanistic uncertainties of soot formation. Instead, it allows the model to calculate effective carbon fluxes from the gas phase into the particle phase that are consistent with measured soot properties. Our analysis showed that all PAH growth models require different sets of  $\eta_{inc}$  and  $\eta_{ads}$  to capture the measured soot properties in the studied conditions. The lack of universal factors highlights the uncertainties in concentration of gaseous species, potential missing inception and surface growth pathways, and unknown sensitivities to temperature and fuel composition.

#### 4.1.2 Methane pyrolysis in shock tube

The pyrolysis of a 5% CH<sub>4</sub>-Ar mixture was studied using the CPR model over a post-shock temperature range of  $T_5 = 1800\text{-}3000$  K and a pressure range of  $P_5 = 4.7\text{-}7.1$  bar. Since  $P_5$  was not specified for individual experiments (each defined by a given  $T_5$ ), a linear dependence of  $P_5$  on  $T_5$  was assumed within the stated range [171]. The simulations were performed using the KAUST and Caltech mechanisms, and the model predictions were compared with the CY measurements. The bell-shaped profile of CY was captured using both mechanisms; however, the  $T_5$  corresponding to the peak CY was overpredicted by all inception models using KAUST by more than 100 K, in contrast to the Caltech mechanism, which shows closer agreement with the measurements. Therefore, the gas-phase chemistry was described using the Caltech mechanism for the rest of simulations in for the shock-tube pyrolysis of methane. Inception and PAH adsorption rates were adjusted using  $\eta_{inc}$  and  $\eta_{ads}$ , respectively, to match the predicted Carbon Yield (CY) at  $t = 1.5$  ms with light extinction measurements at  $\lambda = 632$  nm across the studied  $T_5$  and  $P_5$  ranges [171]. The experimental CY was extracted from the reported product of CY and the absorption function,  $E(m)$ . However, this approach introduces uncertainty due to variability in  $E(m)$ . It is common to assume the  $E(m)$  of mature soot, which may not be valid in shock tube experiments with short residence times ( $\approx 2$  ms) that involve initial stages of soot formation, as  $E(m)$  increases

with particle size, composition, and maturity. For instance, during acetylene pyrolysis,  $E(m)$  can vary from 0.05 to 0.25 as  $d_p$  reaches 20 nm within 1.6 ms. We considered the reported variability of  $E(m)$  in the literature, ranging from 0.174 [172] to 0.37 [173].

A parametric study was conducted on  $\eta_{inc}$  and  $\eta_{ads}$  using a grid search approach. Each factor was varied across 11 logarithmically spaced values from  $10^{-4}$  to 1, resulting in 121 simulation cases per data point and 847 simulations in total. Each  $\eta_{inc}$  and  $\eta_{ads}$  pair was ranked based on the average relative error of CY across all data points in the studied  $T_5$  range, in order to identify the set of adjustment factors that minimized the CY prediction error.

To reduce the computational load of the parametric study, simulations were performed using MPBM for all inception models. The comparison of results obtained using SPBM and MPBM in Fig. A.2 shows that CY and  $d_p$  are not sensitive to the choice of particle dynamics model, indicating that MPBM results can be reliably used for CY error analysis. However,  $N_{agg}$  and  $n_p$ , shown in Fig. A.3, differ significantly between SPBM and MPBM because the central assumption of the monodisperse model is the rapid attainment of SPSD, which is not valid at short residence times near 1.5 ms. For example, the non-dimensional PSD at  $T_5 = 2200$  K, shown in Fig. A.4, significantly changes from 1.0 ms to 2.5 ms for all inception models.

Fig. 4.3 shows a heat map of the mean relative error, normalized by the maximum value, for all inception models. The largest error occurs for the combination of maximum inception ( $\eta_{inc} = 1$  or  $\log_{10}(\eta_{inc}) = 0$ ) and minimum adsorption ( $\eta_{ads} = 10^{-4}$  or  $\log_{10}(\eta_{ads}) = -4$ ). The region of lowest normalized error (less than 5%), outlined in blue in Fig. 4.3, includes a broad set of adjustment factor combinations that enable the model to accurately predict CY. However, accurate prediction of CY does not necessarily imply accurate prediction of other properties, such as primary particle diameter or mobility diameter. The availability of data on other soot parameters or intermediate gaseous species, and including them as optimization targets, could help narrow down the range of optimal adjustment factors.

To highlight the variability in soot morphology across the low-error region of the heat map, we focus on three representative combinations of  $\eta_{inc}$  and  $\eta_{ads}$ : (i) minimum inception flux ( $\eta_{inc} = 10^{-4}$ ), (ii) minimum PAH adsorption rate ( $\eta_{ads} = 10^{-4}$ ), and (iii) equally scaled inception flux and PAH adsorption rate ( $\eta_{inc} = \eta_{ads}$ ). It is important to note that soot CY and morphology are closely coupled to gas-phase chemistry under the short residence times studied. Therefore, a set of simulations was performed without soot to isolate gas-phase chemistry and examine the temperature dependence of soot precursors and  $C_2H_2$ . Subsequently, inception models were optimized using equal

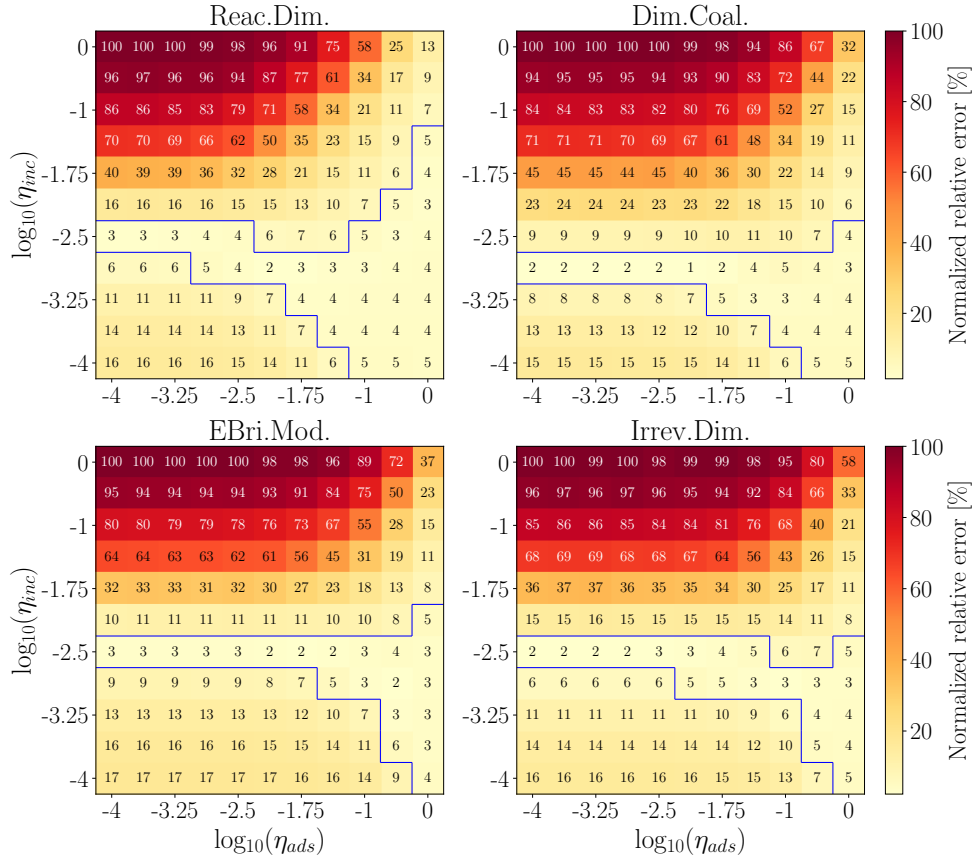


Fig. 4.3 The relative error of CY normalized by the maximum value at  $t = 1.5$  ms for 5%  $\text{CH}_4$ -Ar obtained using Caltech mechanism and all PAH growth models. Each cell is annotated with its corresponding normalized relative error expressed in percent.

adjustment factors<sup>3</sup> ( $\eta_{inc} = \eta_{ads}$ ), and separate optimizations were carried out for the minimum adsorption case ( $\eta_{ads} = 10^{-4}$ ) and the minimum inception case ( $\eta_{inc} = 10^{-4}$ ), denoted as *Min-Ads* and *Min-Inc*, respectively.

Fig. 4.4a shows the CMF of soot precursors (individual PAHs and total) and  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_2$  at 1.5 ms across the studied temperature range, with the soot model deactivated. The CMF is defined as the ratio of the carbon mass contained in a given species to the total carbon mass in the system. While PAH precursors exhibit a bell-shaped profile, the CMF of  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_2$  increases linearly with temperature and plateaus near 85% at  $T_5 \approx 2400$  K. Among the considered PAHs, A2, A2R5, and A4R5 account for most of the carbon and are likely major contributors to soot inception and surface growth. The strong variation in PAH CMF highlights the impact of precursor selection on inception flux, surface growth rates, and their temperature dependence. Fig. 4.5 illustrates the

<sup>3</sup>[https://github.com/mohammadadib-cu/omnisoot-cv/tree/main/examples/pressure/methane\\_pyrolysis](https://github.com/mohammadadib-cu/omnisoot-cv/tree/main/examples/pressure/methane_pyrolysis)

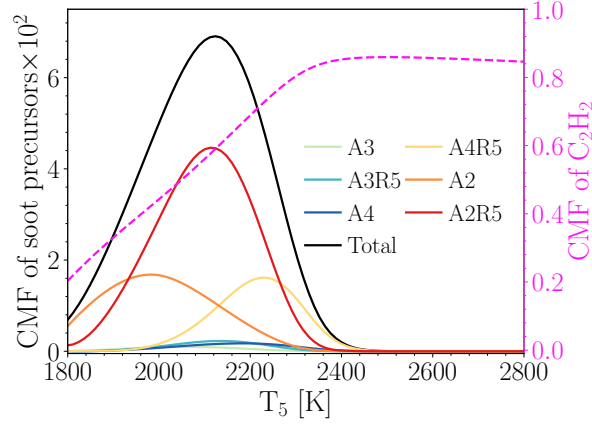


Fig. 4.4 The bell-shaped temperature profile of carbon mass fraction of soot precursors (A2 and larger) combined and  $C_2H_2$  at  $t = 1.5$  ms during pyrolysis of 5%  $CH_4$ -Ar obtained using Caltech mechanism without considering soot.

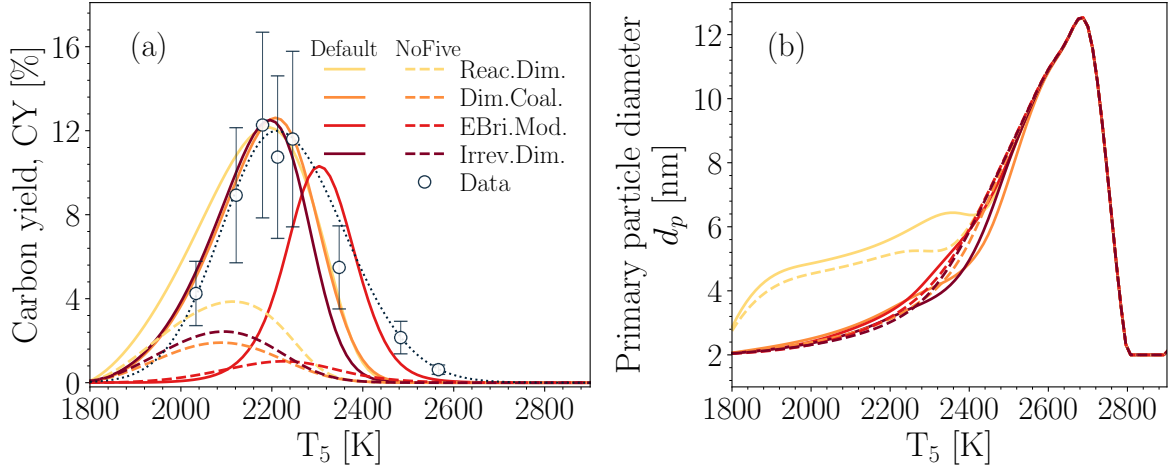


Fig. 4.5 (a) The soot carbon yield, CY, at  $t = 1.5$  ms and (b) primary particle diameter,  $d_p$  (b) obtained using the default soot precursors (denoted by solid line and labeled as “Default”) compared with the same results when five-membered ring PAHs excluded from soot precursors (denoted by dashed line and labeled as “NoFive”). Both cases were obtained using Caltech mechanism and the same equal adjustment factors. The black dashed line was added to show the trend in the measurements [171].

effect of excluding five-membered ring PAHs (A2R5, A3R5, and A4R5) from the soot precursors on the CY and  $d_p$ . As expected, excluding these species reduces CY for all inception models, potentially highlighting the significant contribution of five-membered rings PAHs.

Next set of simulations were conducted by using equal adjustment factors ( $\eta_{inc} = \eta_{ads}$ ) to minimize the prediction error of CY. Table 4.1 lists the adjustment factors used for each inception model. Note that the efficiencies of inception ( $\gamma_{inc}$  in Equation (2.87))

Table 4.1 The value of adjustment factors used in the simulation of 5% CH<sub>4</sub>-Ar pyrolysis.

|              | Reac.Dim. | Dim.Coal. | EBri.Mod. | Irrev.Dim. |
|--------------|-----------|-----------|-----------|------------|
| $\eta_{inc}$ | 0.17      | 0.21      | 0.36      | 2.3        |
| $\eta_{ads}$ | 0.17      | 0.21      | 0.36      | 2.3        |

and PAH adsorption ( $\gamma_{ads}$  in Equation (2.88)) for Irreversible Dimerization were set to  $10^{-4}$  and  $10^{-3}$ , respectively [49], so  $\eta_{inc}$  and  $\eta_{ads}$  values greater than unity do not result in collision rates exceeding the theoretical limit of kinetic theory. Fig. 4.6a compares CY from various inception models with experimental data [171]. A skew exponential curve (black dotted line) was fitted to the data to highlight the CY trend and its peak near 12%. Soot CY follows a bell-shaped profile similar to that of soot precursors, as inception flux and PAH adsorption rate directly depend on precursor concentrations. Reactive Dimerization model predicts a higher CY at lower temperatures due to stronger PAH adsorption rates, while E-Bridge Modified model shifts the peak to higher temperatures compared to the other models because in this model, inception is initiated and controlled by the dehydrogenation rate of PAH molecules, which is strongly depends on temperature and the concentration of H radicals. In contrast, the other models begin with physical PAH collision, which is primarily a function of PAH concentration.

As shown in Fig. 4.6b, the predicted  $d_p$  increases with  $T_5$ , reaching a maximum of 11 nm at 2700 K, where yield is very low ( $\approx 10^{-7}$ ), and then drops to the model's minimum allowed value of 2 nm. The differences between inception models in predicting  $d_p$  is overall negligible except for Reactive Dimerization model, which predicts a larger  $d_p$  in  $T_5 < 2500$  K. The  $d_p$  trends can be better understood by examining Equation (4.7) indicating that  $d_p$  is proportional to the third-root of  $C_{tot}/N_{pri}$ .  $C_{tot}$  describes total carbon mass converted to soot through inception and surface growth while  $N_{pri}$  is only determined by inception flux. As a result,  $d_p$  is controlled by the ratio of total surface growth rate (via HACA and PAH adsorption) to inception flux. Here, we define the parameter  $\theta$  as the ratio of carbon mass gained via each pathway to the total soot carbon mass. As shown in Fig. 4.7, PAH adsorption is the dominant soot mass growth pathway for Reactive Dimerization model in  $T_5 < 2000$  K (Fig. 4.7a), which results in larger  $C_{tot}/N_{pri}$  and  $d_p$  values, but inception is dominant for the other inception models. The contribution of inception decreases with temperature for all inception models while the contribution of HACA becomes dominant up to 2700 K leading to higher  $d_p$  (Fig. 4.6b). This is due to the decrease of precursor concentration and the

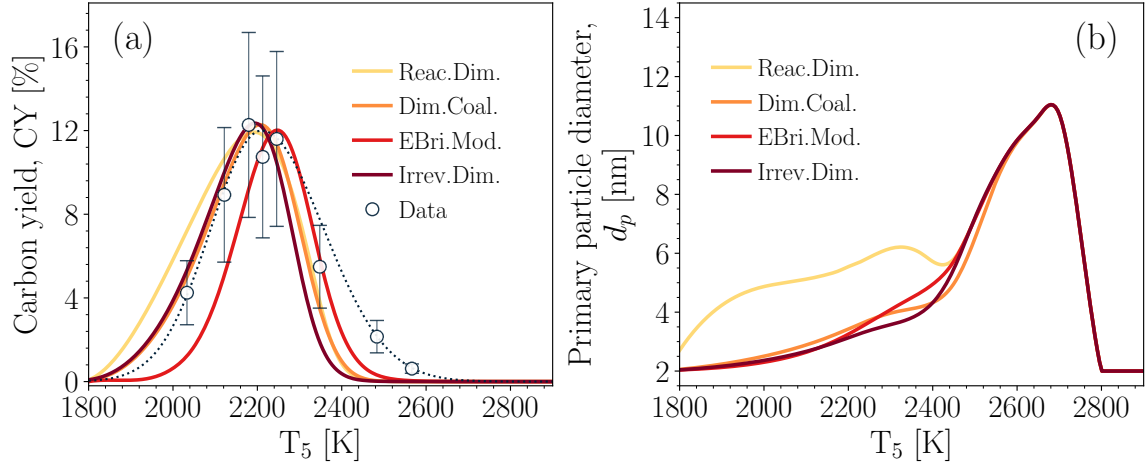


Fig. 4.6 (a) The CY and (b)  $d_p$  at  $t = 1.5$  ms during the pyrolysis of 5%  $\text{CH}_4$ -Ar obtained using equal adjustment factors to minimize the prediction error with extinction measurements [171]. The dashed line was added to show the trend in the measurements.

increase of  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_2$  CMF. Beyond 2700 K, the contribution of inception rapidly increases with temperature leading to the decrease of  $d_p$  (Fig. 4.6b).

Fig. 4.8a shows that  $N_{pri}$  peaks near 2200 K, aligning with the peak in CY. This is expected because  $N_{pri}$  depends solely on the inception flux, which is the highest when PAH concentrations peak. Increased coagulation rates reduce  $N_{agg}$  in the 2000-2500 K range. Reactive Dimerization model yields the fewest particles ( $N_{pri}$  and  $N_{agg}$ ) because more precursors are directed toward PAH adsorption. Consequently,  $n_p$  is lowest for Reactive Dimerization model. Differences between inception models are more evident in  $n_p$  than in  $d_p$ , influencing predicted particle morphology.

Fig. 4.9a and Fig. 4.9b shows that the optimized models with minimum  $\eta_{inc}$  and  $\eta_{ads}$  yield similar CY across inception models, except E-Bridge Modified model, which shifts slightly toward higher temperatures. The Min-Ads case has a higher peak and narrower profile compared with the Min-Inc case. As shown in Fig. 4.9c,  $d_p$  predicted in Min-Ads mode is smaller and less sensitive to the selection of inception model compared with Min-Inc mode. Two peaks can be seen in Min-Inc mode for all inception models: The first peak occurs due to high PAH adsorption rates at the temperature range close to the peak of CMF of soot precursors (Fig. 4.4a); the second peak which occurs around  $T_5 = 2700$  K and  $d_p = 12$  nm, which is very similar to  $d_p$  trends predicted using equal adjustment factors (Fig. 4.6b). Reactive Dimerization model has the largest variation at the peak from 2 to 19 nm between Min-Ads and Min-Inc modes. The existence of such a variation highlights the need for characterizing primary particle size

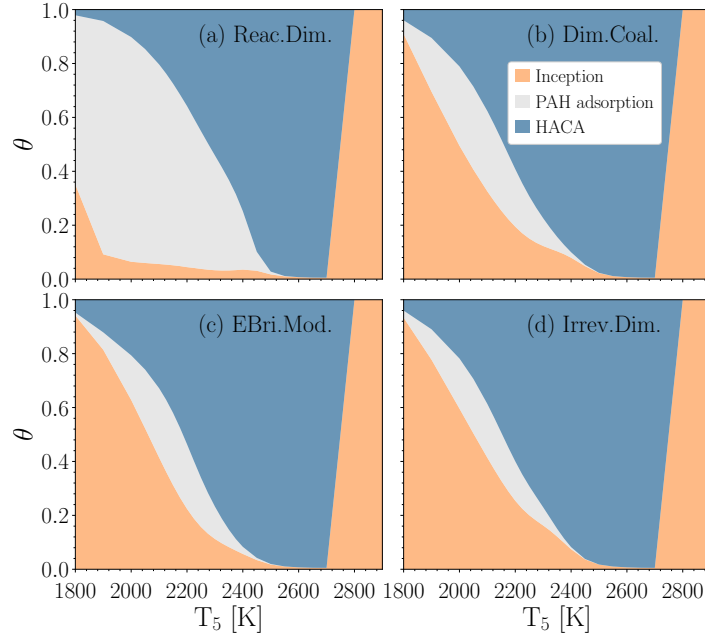


Fig. 4.7 The variation of  $\theta$ , defined as soot carbon mass from inception, PAH adsorption and HACA normalized by total soot carbon mass at  $t = 1.5$  ms during the pyrolysis of 5%  $\text{CH}_4$ -Ar.

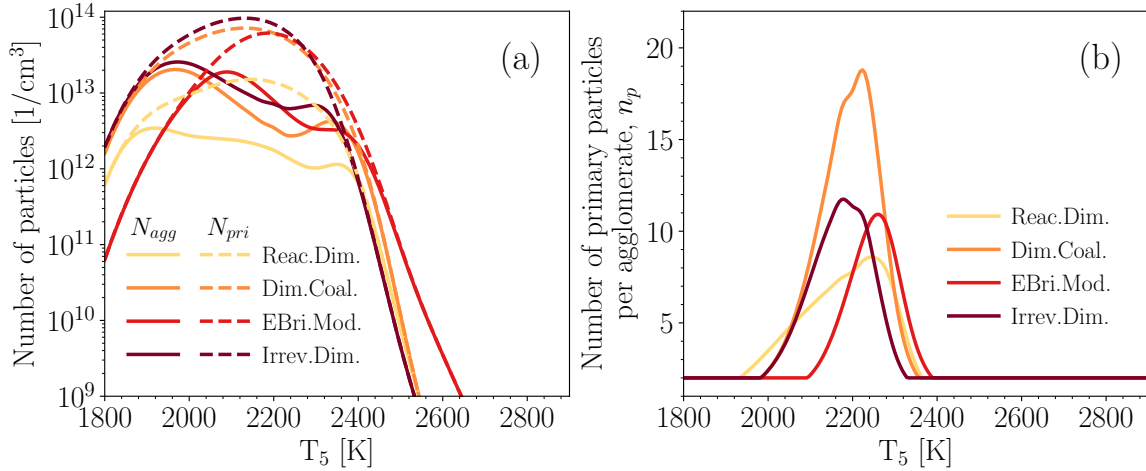


Fig. 4.8 The temperature dependence of (a)  $N_{agg}$ , (b)  $n_p$  (b) at  $t = 1.5$  ms during the pyrolysis of 5%  $\text{CH}_4$ -Ar.

in the experiment to reduce the uncertainty in the soot model and restrict the range of expected inception and surface growth rates required to accurately predict soot yield and morphology.



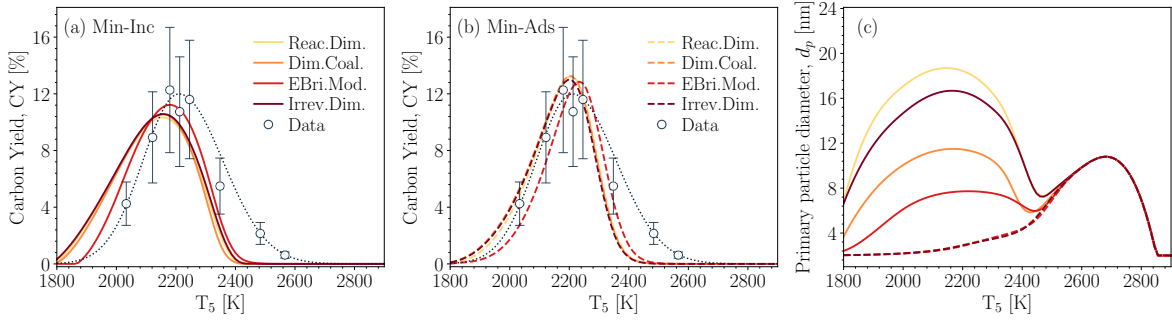


Fig. 4.9 The comparison of CY and  $d_p$  at  $t = 1.5$  ms for 5%  $\text{CH}_4$ -Ar when the minimum inception (solid lines) and the minimum PAH adsorption adjustment factors were applied to minimize the prediction error. The dashed line was added to show the trend in the measurements [171].

### 4.1.3 Ethylene pyrolysis in a flow reactor

The PFR model was used to simulate<sup>4</sup> the pyrolysis of 0.6%  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_4$ - $\text{N}_2$  in a 1.4 m long, and 16 mm diameter flow reactor. Fig. 4.10 shows the axial temperature profile used in the simulations. The maximum temperature,  $T_{\text{max}} = 1673$  K, was imposed on the model based on thermocouple measurements reported in [174] for various flow rates along the reactor centerline. The temperature increases from 300 K at the reactor inlet to the hot zone, where it reaches a value within 10% of  $T_{\text{max}}$ . The length of the hot zone varies with flow rate due to advection, ranging from 0.71 m at  $Q = 8$  L/min to 0.76 m at  $Q = 12$  L/min. Near the reactor outlet, the temperature drops to approximately 650 K.

The inception and PAH adsorption adjustment factors were varied to match the predicted PSD with Scanning Mobility Particle Sizer (SMPS) measurements conducted on centerline at the reactor exit for the flow rates of 8, 11, and 12 L/min [174], as shown in Fig. 4.11. The parametric analysis revealed that each inception model requires a unique set of adjustment factors to minimize the PSD prediction error across different flow rates. The KAUST mechanism [167] was used to describe gas-phase chemistry because it provided better agreement with the measured PSDs than the Caltech mechanism, shown in Fig. A.5. Nevertheless, the choice of reaction mechanism does not change the findings about the differences between the inception models because they are primarily due to their reversibility and sensitivity to temperature, which is not affected by the base kinetic mechanism. Table 4.2 indicates the adjustment factors used with the KAUST mechanism for simulations of ethylene pyrolysis in the studied flow reactor.

<sup>4</sup>[https://github.com/mohammadadib-cu/omnisoot-cv/tree/main/examples/plug\\_flow/sectional](https://github.com/mohammadadib-cu/omnisoot-cv/tree/main/examples/plug_flow/sectional)

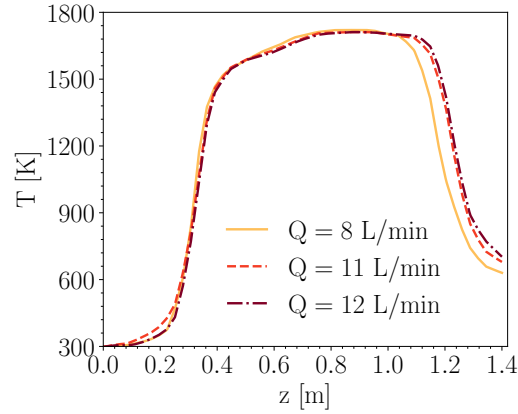


Fig. 4.10 The centerline temperature along the reactor for  $Q = 8, 11$ , and  $12$  L/min interpolated from the thermocouple measurements [174].

Table 4.2 The value of adjustment factors used in the simulation of ethylene pyrolysis in the flow reactor.

|              | Reac.Dim. | Dim.Coal. | EBri.Mod. | Irrev.Dim. |
|--------------|-----------|-----------|-----------|------------|
| $\eta_{inc}$ | 0.01      | 0.004     | 0.01      | 0.08       |
| $\eta_{ads}$ | 0.001     | 0.01      | 0.1       | 1          |

A bimodal size distribution can be observed for  $Q = 8$  L/min (Fig. 4.11a) that was attributed to the continuous inception [27]. The comparison of simulations with measurements reveals different temperature dependence of inception models. Irreversible Dimerization and Dimer Coalescence models capture the bimodality of PSD in good agreement with the measurements, but the other two models predict a nearly unimodal PSD. Specifically, the number concentration of the first section is lower by more than three orders of magnitude for the Reactive Dimerization and E-Bridge Modified models indicating the lack of active inception at the sampling location due to the temperature drop near the end of reactor that suppresses soot inception.

All inception models capture the disappearance of the PSD shoulder at flow rates of 11 and 12 L/min. In these cases, the shorter particle residence time limits coagulation, preventing formation of a second peak. However, Reactive Dimerization and E-Bridge Modified models still underpredict the number concentration of nascent particles by approximately one order of magnitude compared to the irreversible models (Irreversible Dimerization and Dimer Coalescence).

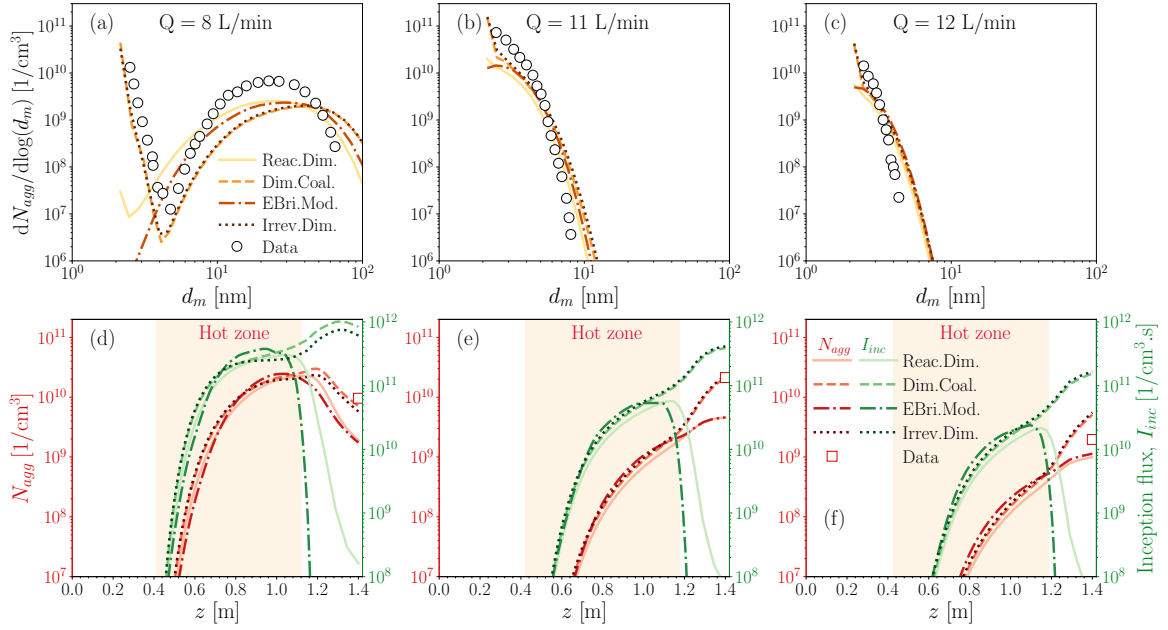


Fig. 4.11 The particle size distribution at the end of PFR, and the total number of agglomerates,  $N_{agg}$ , and inception flux,  $I_{inc}$  along the PFR for (a, d)  $Q = 8$  L/min, (b, e) 11 L/min, and (c, f) 12 L/min obtained using KAUST mechanism, SPBM and different inception models calibrated to match the predictions with measurements [174].

As shown in Fig. 4.11d-f, all inception models predict nearly the same  $N_{agg}$  up to  $z \approx 1.1$  m, corresponding to the end of the hot zone. Beyond this point,  $N_{agg}$  continues to increase for the Irreversible Dimerization and Dimer Coalescence models, which allows soot inception to proceed in cooler downstream regions. These models agree well with experimental data at 8 and 11 L/min but tend to overpredict  $N_{agg}$  at 12 L/min.

Soot inception flux rises sharply as the gas enters the hot zone. The axial location where the flux exceeds  $10^7$  cm<sup>-3</sup> s<sup>-1</sup> is similar across all inception models, as it is primarily determined by PAH chemistry. However, this location shifts downstream with increasing flow rate due to reduced residence time. Within the hot zone, differences among the inception models are minimal. Outside the hot zone, Irreversible Dimerization and Dimer Coalescence models maintain high inception flux, while Reactive Dimerization and E-Bridge Modified models predict a rapid decrease of more than three orders of magnitude due to cooling. The difference between the models is primarily due to their temperature dependence as indicated in Table. 2.3 and illustrated in Fig. 2.6. The Arrhenius rates embedded in the carbonization step in Reactive Dimerization and the dehydrogenation in E-Bridge cause an exponential decay in these models with the temperature drops for  $z > 1.1$  m. Fig. 4.12 demonstrates the contribution of each

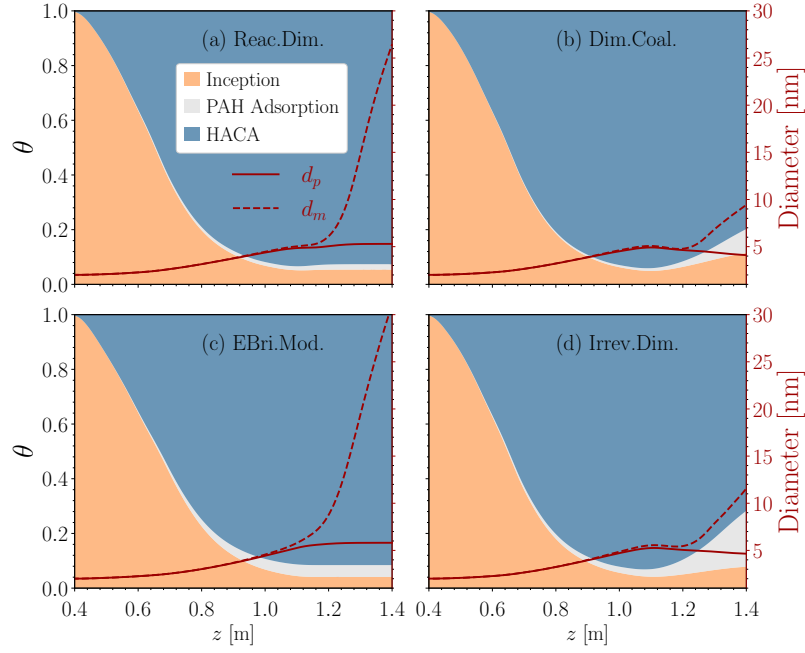


Fig. 4.12 The variation of  $\theta$ , defined as soot carbon mass from inception, PAH adsorption and HACA normalized by total soot carbon mass for  $Q = 8$  L/min along with  $d_p$  and  $d_m$  obtained using KAUST mechanism, SPBM and different inception models.

pathway to total carbon mass of soot along the reactor, which elucidates the link between particle morphology and the balance of inception and surface growth. The relative contribution of inception decreases from 100% to less than 5% by  $z = 1.1$  m for all inception models leading to a gradual increase in  $d_p$  and  $d_m$ . Irreversible Dimerization and Dimer Coalescence models predict an increase in the contribution of inception beyond  $z > 1.1$  m resulting in the decline of  $d_p$  while Reactive Dimerization and E-Bridge Modified models predict a nearly constant  $d_p$  close to 5 nm. The final increase in  $d_m$  beyond the end of the hot zone near  $z = 1.1$  m is more pronounced for the Reactive Dimerization and E-Bridge Modified models. This is because the inception rate and surface growth rate (Fig. A.6) rapidly decrease in these models, and soot morphology becomes primarily governed by coagulation, which conserves  $d_p$  and increases  $d_m$ .

#### 4.1.4 Ethylene combustion in a perfectly stirred reactor

The PSR model of Omnisoot<sup>5</sup> was used to simulate ethylene combustion at different equivalence ratios,  $\phi = 1.9, 2.0$ , and  $2.1$  in a perfectly stirred reactor connected

<sup>5</sup>[https://github.com/mohammadadib-cu/omnisoot-cv/tree/main/examples/psr\\_pfr](https://github.com/mohammadadib-cu/omnisoot-cv/tree/main/examples/psr_pfr)

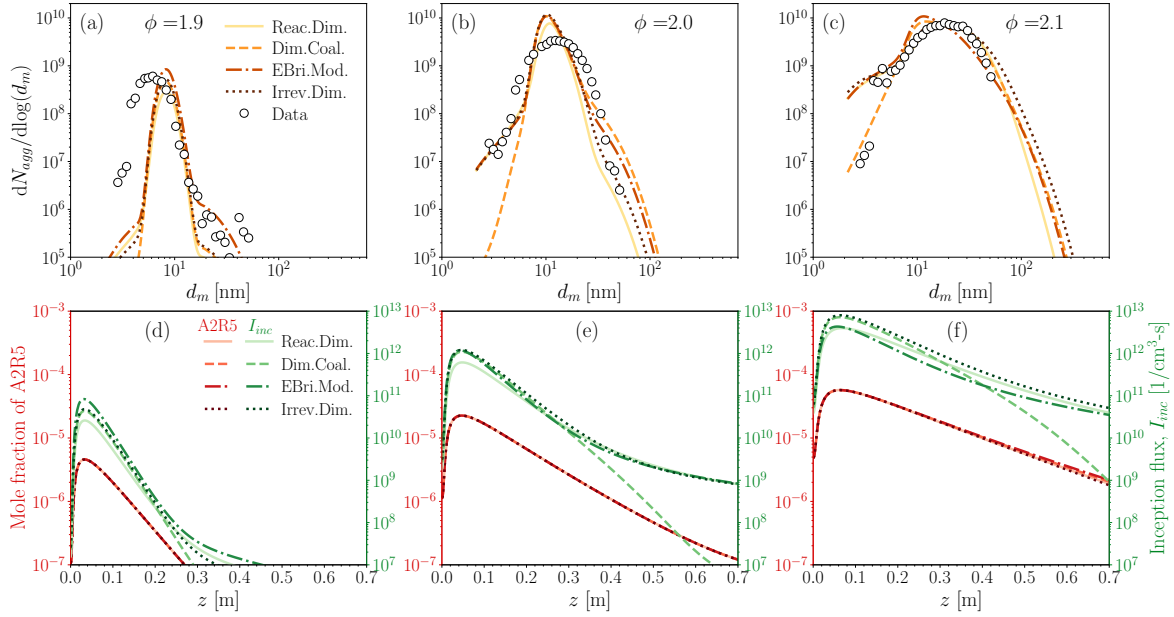


Fig. 4.13 The particle size distribution at the end of PFR, and the mole fraction of A2R5, and inception flux,  $I_{inc}$  along the PFR for (a, d)  $\phi = 1.9$ , (b, e) 2.0, and (c, f) 2.1 obtained using KAUST mechanism, SPBM and different inception models calibrated to match the predictions with the PSD measurements [175].

to a flow reactor [175]. PSD measurements were conducted at the end of the flow reactor using a Nano-Differential Mobility Analyzer (Nano-DMA). The volume ( $V$ ) and nominal residence time ( $\tau_{psr}$ ) of the PSR are 250 ml and 11 ms, respectively [175]. The flow reactor is 70 cm long with an inner diameter of 5.1 cm. The reactants enter the adiabatic PSR at 300 K with an inlet mass flow rate of  $\dot{m}_{in} = \rho V / \tau_{psr}$ , where  $\rho$  was calculated at the reactor temperature of 1723 K [176]. The PSR simulation was continued until a steady-state condition was reached for all the solution variables. The final gas composition, temperature, and soot properties from the PSR were used as inlet conditions for the PFR simulations, yielding an average axial velocity of 14.5 m/s in the PFR, which is consistent with the values reported in [175].

The KAUST mechanism was used to describe the gas-phase chemistry. The inception and PAH adsorption adjustment factors were varied for each PAH growth model to match the predicted PSD with the measurements as closely as possible for all three equivalence ratios. A similar match could not be reached using the Caltech mechanism because the number concentration of particles was underestimated by at least four orders of magnitude even with  $\eta_{inc} = \eta_{ads} = 1$ . Table 4.3 lists the adjustment factors used with the KAUST mechanism for simulations of ethylene oxidation in the studied perfectly stirred reactor.

Table 4.3 The value of adjustment factors used in the simulation of ethylene oxidation in the perfectly stirred reactor.

|              | Reac.Dim. | Dim.Coal. | EBri.Mod. | Irrev.Dim. |
|--------------|-----------|-----------|-----------|------------|
| $\eta_{inc}$ | 0.0005    | 0.001     | 0.0002    | 0.01       |
| $\eta_{ads}$ | 0.01      | 0.01      | 0.01      | 1          |

Table 4.4 The geometric mean mobility diameter,  $d_{m,g}$ , and the geometric mobility standard deviation,  $\sigma_{m,g}$ , obtained using different inception models compared with the value calculated from the measured PSD [175].

|                           | $\phi = 1.9$   |                | $\phi = 2.0$   |                | $\phi = 2.1$   |                |
|---------------------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|
|                           | $d_{m,g}$ [nm] | $\sigma_{m,g}$ | $d_{m,g}$ [nm] | $\sigma_{m,g}$ | $d_{m,g}$ [nm] | $\sigma_{m,g}$ |
| <b>Data [175]</b>         | <b>6.04</b>    | <b>1.25</b>    | <b>12.40</b>   | <b>1.49</b>    | <b>17.66</b>   | <b>1.64</b>    |
| Reactive Dimerization     | 8.27           | 1.14           | 11.10          | 1.21           | 16.88          | 1.58           |
| Dimer Coalescence         | 8.18           | 1.14           | 10.76          | 1.24           | 16.99          | 1.68           |
| E-Bridge Modified         | 8.27           | 1.15           | 11.02          | 1.27           | 14.56          | 1.58           |
| Irreversible Dimerization | 8.19           | 1.14           | 10.96          | 1.25           | 18.44          | 1.78           |

As shown in Fig. 4.13, all inception models capture the peak number concentration and the unimodal shape of the PSD, indicating that particle inception has ceased and coagulation is the dominant mechanism for agglomerate size growth. As reported in Table 4.4, the geometric mean mobility diameter,  $d_{m,g}$ , and the geometric mobility standard deviation,  $\sigma_{m,g}$ , obtained using all inception models are in good agreement with the values calculated from the measured PSD [175]. As shown in Fig. 4.13a-b, the spread of the predicted PSD is narrower than that of the measurements for  $\phi = 1.9$  and 2.0, corresponding to an underprediction of  $\sigma_{m,g}$  for these equivalence ratios.

All inception models underpredict the number concentration of small particles ( $d_m < 6$  nm) at  $\phi = 1.9$ . The discrepancy decreases at  $\phi = 2.0$ , and the model predictions align well with the measurements except for Dimer Coalescence model that underpredicts the number concentration of small particles ( $d_m < 5$  nm). In the simulation results, the number concentration of the smallest particles with a diameter of 2 nm is strongly affected by the equivalence ratio, as the precursor production rate increases with  $\phi$ . This behavior can be better understood by comparing the acenaphthylene (A2R5) mole fraction at different  $\phi$  values, as shown in Fig. 4.13d-f.

The inlet mole fraction of A2R5 at  $z = 0$  m corresponds to the value obtained from the PSR, which increases by factors of 10 and 4 when  $\phi$  is increased incrementally from 1.9 to 2.0, and from 2.0 to 2.1, respectively. This relative increase is nearly the same across all inception models. The jump in A2R5 mole fraction leads to a substantial increase in the inception flux, which explains the sensitivity of the smallest particle concentrations to the equivalence ratio. The strong similarity between the A2R5 mole fraction profiles and the soot inception profiles along the reactor highlights the dominant role of A2R5 in soot inception. Another important observation is that the A2R5 mole fraction is not affected by the choice of inception model.

As shown in Fig. 4.14a-c,  $d_p$  along the PFR is nearly identical for all inception models at  $\phi = 1.9$ , but the differences become more noticeable at higher  $\phi$  values. The Reactive Dimerization model predicts the largest final  $d_p$  because it channels more PAH mass into PAH adsorption rather than inception, which is consistent with the lower peak number concentration observed in Fig. 4.13. The value of  $d_p$  decreases rapidly at the beginning of the reactor due to a surge in the production of incipient particles (spherical particles with a diameter of 2 nm), which lowers the mean  $d_p$ . It then increases toward the end of the reactor as surface growth becomes dominant. Although the final  $d_p$  increases slightly with  $\phi$ , the overall range remains similar across  $\phi$  values, indicating a comparable balance between inception and surface growth.

As shown in Fig. 4.14, the surface growth rate (HACA and PAH adsorption combined) and the soot volume fraction, however, are highly sensitive to  $\phi$ , which can be attributed to the strong influence of  $\phi$  on precursor production, inception flux, and the number of particles. An analysis of surface growth rates at the end of the PFR revealed that more than 95% of the soot mass is acquired through the HACA mechanism. The apparent difference in  $f_v$  between the inception models originates from the different PAH adsorption rate predicted by the inception models. For example, at  $\phi = 1.9$ , the E-Bridge Modified model predicts the highest surface growth rate and soot volume fraction due to a higher number of agglomerates (as shown in Fig. 4.13a), which leads to a larger total surface area, which is the key factor in calculating the HACA growth rate.

## 4.2 Soot formation at high fuel loadings

This section presents the paper titled “*Gas-phase chemistry and soot formation during shock-tube pyrolysis of methane at high fuel loadings*” and accepted in the 41st International Symposium on Combustion, where Omnisoot was utilized to extend the

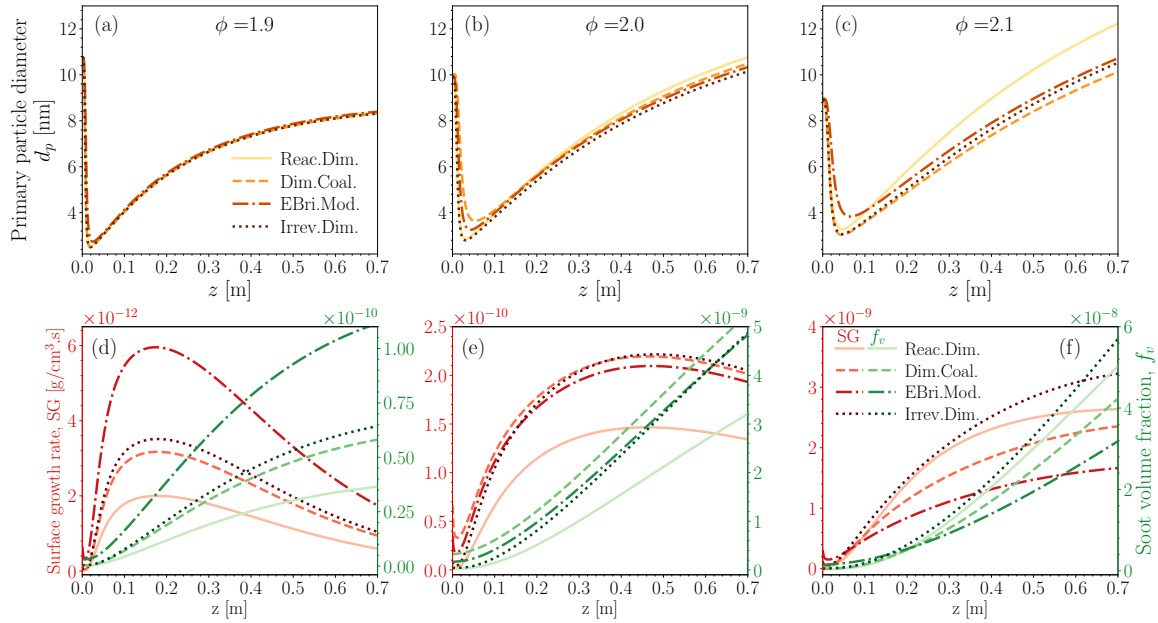


Fig. 4.14 The primary particle diameter,  $d_p$ , the total surface growth rate by HACA and PAH adsorption, and the soot volume fraction,  $f_v$  along the PFR for (a, d)  $\phi = 1.9$ , (b, e)  $2.0$ , and (c, f)  $2.1$  obtained using KAUST mechanism, SPBM and different inception models calibrated to match the predictions with the PSD measurements [175].

application of kinetic mechanisms from dilute to high-fuel-loading regime typical in cogeneration of carbon black and hydrogen. The paper provides the first simultaneous investigation of methane pyrolysis chemistry and particulate formation under high fuel concentrations accompanied with numerical simulations that accounts for the evolution of gas chemistry and formation of particulate. Detailed measurement-model comparisons enabled the assessment of several kinetic mechanisms to elucidate the combined effect of temperature and fuel loading on methane carbon flux to intermediates that determine the yield of carbonaceous particles.

Direct decomposition of methane offers a low-emission route for large-scale co-production of carbon black (CB) and hydrogen [177]. Achieving CB with desired specific surface area, morphology, and internal structure requires precise control of gas-phase chemistry as well as CB inception and surface growth [178]. This remains challenging due to the complex reaction pathways [24] and short time scales [35] involved in methane-to-CB conversion. Although kinetic mechanisms coupled with particle dynamics have been developed to describe polycyclic aromatic hydrocarbon (PAH) formation and particle inception [25], most were developed for dilute conditions to facilitate the inference of rate constants [179], and to minimize spectral interference in laser diagnostics [180]. However, high fuel loadings (local mole fractions  $\sim 1$ ) are



typical in industrial CB synthesis [9], highlighting the need for data to benchmark kinetic mechanisms across low- to high-fuel regimes.

Prior studies on soot formation from methane at high fuel loadings in flames [181] and flow reactors [182] lack time- or space-resolved species data due to diagnostic challenges such as strong radiation, interference from intermediates, and limited optical access [183]. Time-resolved  $\text{CH}_4$  measurements during 10%  $\text{CH}_4$  pyrolysis were initially conducted to refine decomposition reaction rates [184]. Later, simultaneous measurements of  $\text{CH}_4$ ,  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_4$ , and  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_2$  were performed for 10–40%  $\text{CH}_4$  pyrolysis with a focus on maximizing  $\text{H}_2$  yield without soot characterization [185].

In this work, we investigate the shock-tube pyrolysis of 5%, 10%, and 30%  $\text{CH}_4$ -Ar mixtures at  $P_5=4\pm0.9$  atm and  $1800<T_5<2500$  K, providing simultaneous measurements of key intermediates and soot volume fraction via optical diagnostics. Simulations were conducted using detailed kinetic mechanisms coupled with a sectional population balance model that accounts for inception, surface growth, and agglomeration. Comparison between measurements and model predictions enables (i) evaluation of kinetic mechanism performance for  $\text{CH}_4$  conversion and the resulting carbon flux governing  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_4$  and  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_2$  formation and (ii) assessment of soot volume fraction evolution over extended times to examine their dependence on temperature and fuel loading.

### 4.2.1 Experimental method & numerical model

Methane pyrolysis experiments were conducted using the Stanford Flexible Applications Shock Tube (FAST) facility with a 3.35 m driver, 9.70 m driven section, and a 14.12 cm inner diameter. Fig. 4.15 depicts a schematic of the diagnostic suite viewed from the end wall. More details about the FAST facility can be found in [186]. The post-reflected shock pressure ( $P_5$ ) was measured using an endwall pressure transducer (Kistler 603B1). Time histories of key intermediates were quantified using laser absorption spectroscopy (LAS).  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_4$  was measured at 10532 nm using an updated diagnostic technique originally developed by Ren et al. [187] and later refined by Pinkowski et al. [188]. To reduce  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_2$  interference with  $\text{CH}_4$  absorption near 2998 nm [189], a NanoPlus distributed feedback laser was employed to detect C-H stretch vibrations of  $\text{CH}_4$  at 3366 nm, with temperature-dependent absorption coefficients ( $\sigma_v$ ) determined over 1500–2450 K and 1–5 atm.  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_2$  was detected at 2998 nm using absorption cross-sections reported by Stranic et al. [190]. To address  $\text{CH}_4$  interference at 2998 nm, the absorption coefficient of  $\text{CH}_4$  at this wavelength was also characterized for the range of experimental temperatures and pressures, allowing correction of the  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_2$  measurements.

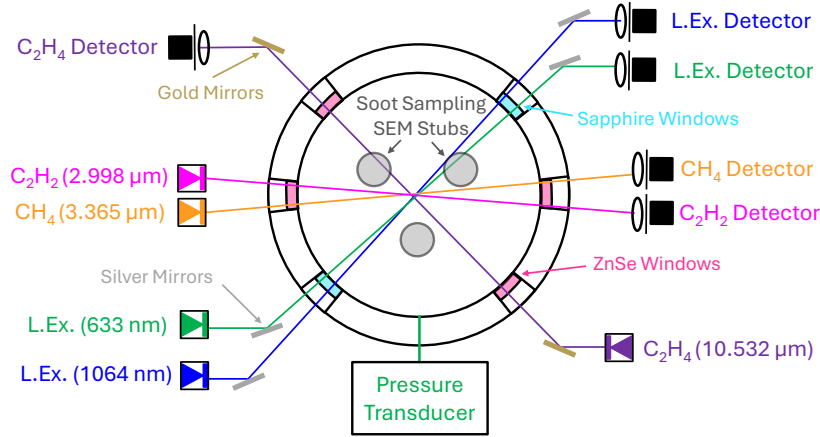


Fig. 4.15 Schematics of the laser diagnostics and shock-tube setup. Spatial and spectral filtering is employed to ensure high-quality absorbance measurements to infer species mole fractions and soot volume fraction. All lasers are aligned in a plane 1 cm from the endwall.

Light extinction at  $\lambda=633$  nm (Coherent Inc. 70 mW OBIS 633 nm LX laser) was employed to measure time-resolved volume fraction of soot particles with optical properties in the Rayleigh limit [191] as:

$$f_v = \ln \left( \frac{I_0}{I_t} \right) \frac{\lambda}{6\pi \cdot L \cdot E(m)}, \quad (4.1)$$

where  $L=14.12$  cm is the optical path length, and  $E(m)=[0.17, 0.26]$  [172, 105] is the soot absorption function at 633 nm.

The measured pressure trace was filtered to reduce noise and fluctuations, then applied to the pressure-reactor model in Omnisoot [192] to simulate methane pyrolysis in the shock tube. Four kinetic mechanisms were used to describe the gas-phase chemistry: ABF [57], KAUST [167], CRECK [193], and FFCM2 [170]. All mechanisms except FFCM2 include PAH chemistry required for soot modeling and can therefore be coupled with a sectional population balance model. The *BIN* species representing solid particles were removed from CRECK to avoid double-counting soot mass. Soot inception was modeled using a modified E-bridge formation based on the inception model proposed by Frenklach and Mebel [25] with some modifications detailed in [192]. Surface growth was described by H-abstraction–C<sub>2</sub>H<sub>2</sub>/carbon-addition (HACA) [57] and PAH adsorption. Soot precursors include naphthalene, phenanthrene, pyrene, acenaphthylene, acephenanthrylene, and cyclopentapyrene. An Arrhenius equation is used to account for the loss of hydrogen by the carbonization of soot particles as [194]:

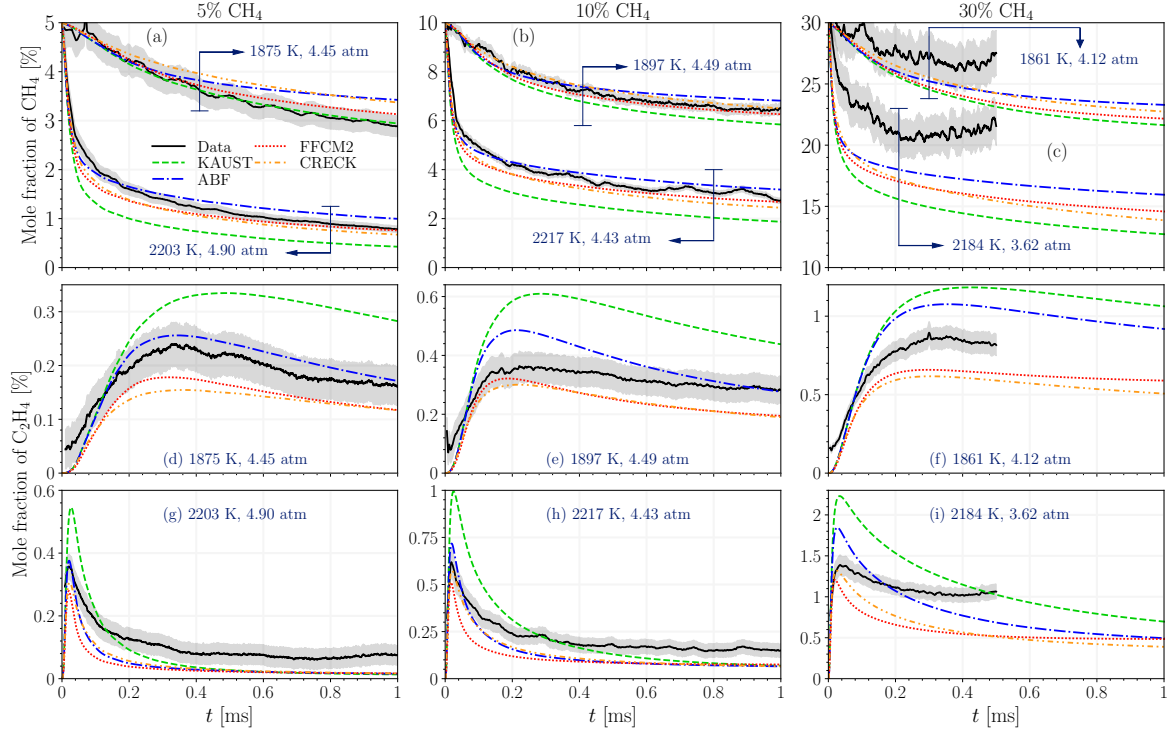


Fig. 4.16 The mole fraction time-history of (a-c)  $\text{CH}_4$  and (d-i)  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_4$  for 5%, 10%, and 30%  $\text{CH}_4$  pyrolysis for  $T_5 \approx 1900$  K and 2200 K.

$$\left( \frac{dH_{tot}}{dt} \right)_{carb} = -A_{carb} \cdot \exp\left( \frac{-E_{carb}}{RT} \right), \quad (4.2)$$

where  $A_{carb} = 6 \times 10^6$  [1/s] and  $E_{carb} = 2 \times 10^5$  [J/mol] are the exponential prefactor and activation energy for carbonization, respectively.

### 4.2.2 Gaseous species

Fig. 4.16a-c presents the time-histories of  $\text{CH}_4$  mole fraction at two representative conditions,  $T_5 \approx 1900$  K and 2200 K, for 5%, 10%, and 30%  $\text{CH}_4$ . Absorption cross-sections ( $\sigma_v$ ) were calculated using simulated temperatures with FFCM2 and shown in Fig. A.15. Overall, model predictions agree more closely with measurements at 5% and 10%  $\text{CH}_4$  than at 30%  $\text{CH}_4$ .

Methane conversion, defined as the fractional reduction in mole fraction, is  $\approx 29\%$  for both 5% and 10%  $\text{CH}_4$  at  $T_5 \approx 1900$  K by 1 ms, but decreases from 78% to 66% at  $T_5 \approx 2200$  K as fuel loading increases from 5% to 10%. These changes arise from variations in  $T_5$ ,  $P_5$ , and coupled chemical-thermal effects. To isolate these effects, two additional sets of simulations were performed for 5%, 10%, and 30% fuel loadings at

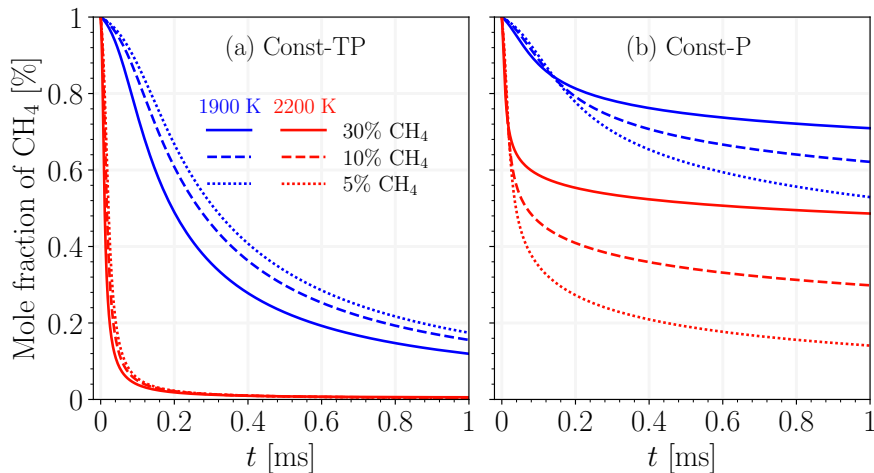


Fig. 4.17 The  $\text{CH}_4$  conversion predicted using FFCM2 in (a) Const-TP and (b) Const-P simulations.

$T_5=1900$  K and  $2200$  K and  $P_5=4.5$  atm. These cases are referred to as “Const-TP” and “Const-P”. In the Const-P simulations, a constant pressure of  $4.5$  atm was imposed instead of the measured pressure trace. In the Const-TP simulations, the temperature was also held constant at  $T_5$  and the energy equation was not solved. Fig. 4.17 shows representative Const-TP and Const-P results using FFCM2, while the complete set of results is provided in Fig. A.17.

At  $T_5=1900$  K, Const-TP simulations indicate that  $\text{CH}_4$  conversion by  $1$  ms increases by approximately  $2\%$  and  $7\%$  at  $10\%$  and  $30\%$  loadings, respectively, relative to  $5\%$  loading. Similar relative trends were observed for the other kinetic mechanisms. At  $T_5=2200$  K, FFCM2 predicts full conversion ( $>99\%$ ) by  $1$  ms, with the time to reach full conversion decreasing as fuel loading increases. In contrast, Const-P simulations show a much stronger reduction in  $\text{CH}_4$  conversion with increasing fuel loading. At  $T_5=1900$  K, the conversion at  $1$  ms decreases by nearly  $20\%$  and  $38\%$  for  $10\%$  and  $30\%$  loadings, respectively, compared to  $5\%$  loading. These results indicate that the observed reduction in  $\text{CH}_4$  conversion at higher fuel loadings is primarily driven by the endothermicity of pyrolysis, which causes faster and deeper temperature drops and consequently slows the decomposition reactions. The range of predicted temperature at  $0.5$  ms,  $T_{(0.5 \text{ ms})}$ , is compared for various loadings in Fig. 4.18, which demonstrates that  $T_{(0.5 \text{ ms})}$  decreases with fuel loading. Moreover, the spread in the predicted temperature from kinetic mechanisms is  $\approx 60$  K for  $30\%$  loading, larger than  $\approx 47$  K and  $\approx 30$  K for  $10\%$  and  $5\%$ , respectively.

As discussed previously, methane conversion is defined here as the fractional reduction in  $\text{CH}_4$  mole fraction, normalized by its initial value,  $1 - X_{\text{CH}_4}/X_{\text{CH}_4,0}$ . This

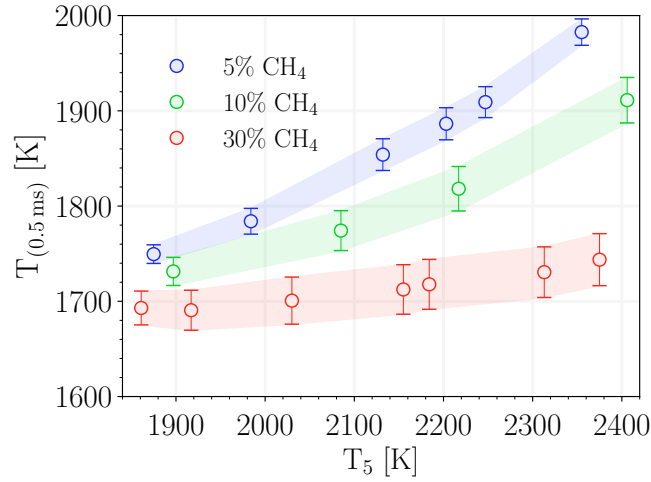


Fig. 4.18 Variation in predicted temperature at 0.5 ms for 5%, 10% and 30% loadings over the studied  $T_5$  range. Error bars and shaded regions represent the spread in predictions from four employed kinetic mechanisms.

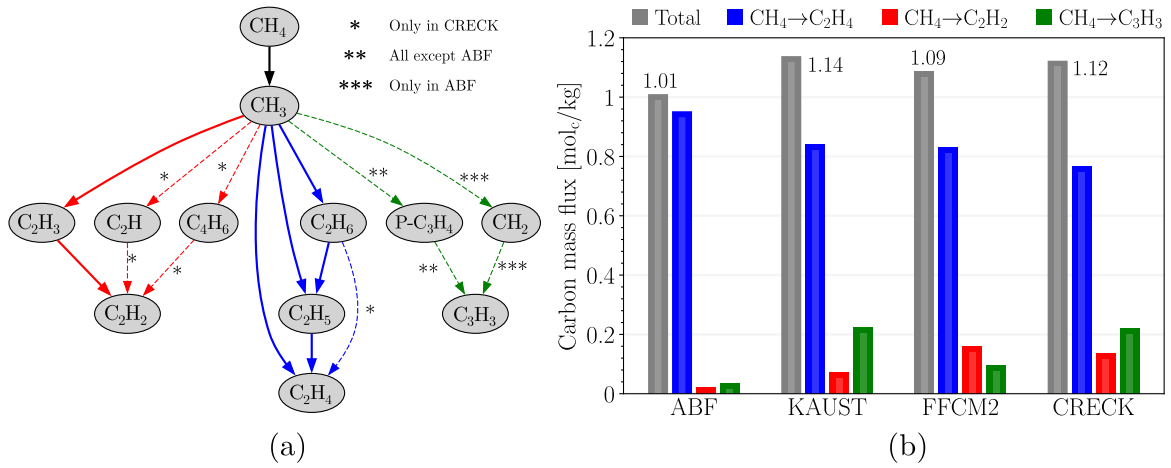


Fig. 4.19 (a) The common pathways for  $\text{CH}_4$  conversion predicted using various kinetic mechanisms, and (b) the comparison of total flux from  $\text{CH}_4$  to  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_4$ ,  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_2$ , and  $\text{C}_3\text{H}_3$  through exclusive pathways for 5% loading at  $\approx 2200$  K.

definition is widely used in shock-tube studies [195, 185, 196] to compute conversion from experimental measurements. However, it can deviate from the actual conversion defined based on the reduction in the carbon mass fraction of  $\text{CH}_4$ ,  $M_{\text{c,CH}_4}/M_{\text{c,CH}_4,0}$ , because the total number of moles is not conserved during pyrolysis, whereas total carbon mass is conserved. Evaluation of all kinetic mechanisms shows that the mole-based definition systematically overpredicts methane conversion. The difference between mole- and mass-based conversion at 1 ms increases from an average of 1.1% at 5%

loading to 5.8% at 30% loading. A comparison of conversion calculated using both definitions for all kinetic mechanisms is shown in Fig. A.18.

The comparison of predicted and measured  $\text{CH}_4$  mole fraction (Fig. 4.16a, b) indicates that among the kinetic mechanisms, FFCM2 provides the best agreement with the 5% and 10% data based on the root mean square error over 1 ms. At 30%  $\text{CH}_4$  (Fig. 4.16c), all mechanisms overpredict conversion, with discrepancies increasing at higher  $T_5$ . Additionally, the measured  $\text{CH}_4$  mole fraction rises at 0.2 ms for  $T_5=1861$  K and at 0.4 ms for  $T_5=2184$  K, which is not observed in simulations. The apparent increase is likely caused by interference from overlapping C–H absorption bands of intermediate species formed more abundantly at high fuel loadings [185].

The ABF and KAUST mechanisms form the upper and lower bounds of the predicted  $\text{CH}_4$  mole fraction across both conditions and the full  $T_5$  range. Methane conversion predicted by CRECK is comparable to ABF at  $T_5 \approx 1900$  K but increases with temperature, approaching FFCM2 predictions at  $T_5 \approx 2200$  K. Differences among mechanisms in the prediction of  $\text{CH}_4$  conversion are not primarily due to variations in the rate constants of the dominant methane decomposition reactions,  $\text{CH}_4 + (\text{M}) \leftrightarrow \text{CH}_3 + \text{H}$  and  $\text{CH}_4 + \text{H} \leftrightarrow \text{CH}_3 + \text{H}_2$ . A series of simulations were conducted using modified ABF, KAUST, and CRECK mechanisms, where the forward and reverse rate constants of both reactions were taken from FFCM2. As shown in Fig. A.20, the modification of dominant  $\text{CH}_4$  decomposition reactions only alters temperature by  $<1\%$  and  $\text{CH}_4$  mole fraction by  $<7\%$  over 1 ms of simulation.

Thus, modeling suggests the variation between the four kinetic mechanisms does not arise from the variability in the rate constants of methane decomposition reactions. Instead, we focus on the carbon flux through the reaction network and the carbon mass fraction (CMF) of species. The net progress rates of reactions were integrated to construct a directed graph [197], where species are represented as nodes, and an edge connects species involved in a reaction. The direction of each edge indicates the net transfer of carbon from reactant to product, and its weight corresponds to the moles of carbon transferred along that reaction pathway over a given time interval, normalized by the total gas mass.

The exclusive carbon pathways from  $\text{CH}_4$  to  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_2$ ,  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_4$ , and  $\text{C}_3\text{H}_3$  were identified, and the corresponding carbon fluxes were compared for the kinetic mechanisms. Fig. 4.19a illustrates major identified pathways of  $\text{CH}_4$  consumption. Fig. 4.19b shows the representative results of carbon flux analysis for 5% loading at 2200 K, suggesting that the persistent underprediction of  $\text{CH}_4$  conversion by ABF is primarily due to lower carbon flux from  $\text{CH}_4$  to  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_2$  and  $\text{C}_3\text{H}_3$  compared with the other mechanisms. While

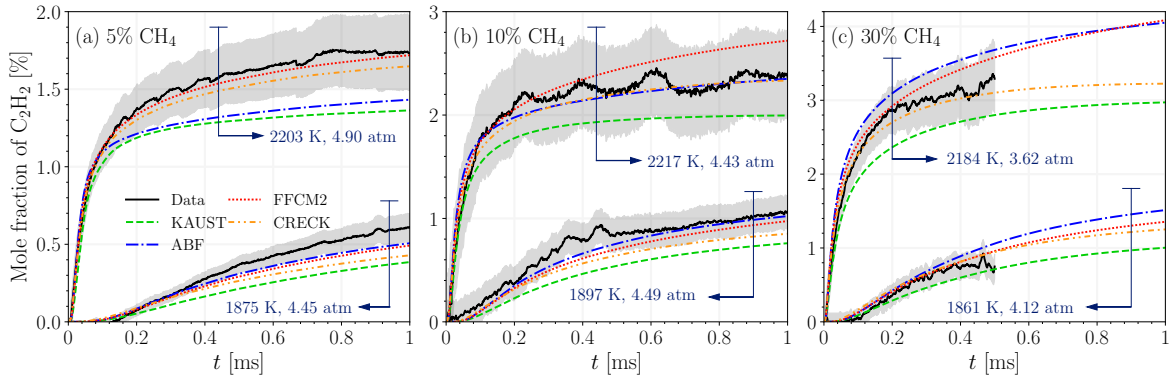


Fig. 4.20 The time history of  $C_2H_2$  mole fraction for (a) 5%, (b) 10% and (c) 30%  $CH_4$  pyrolysis for  $T_5 \approx 1900$  K and 2200 K

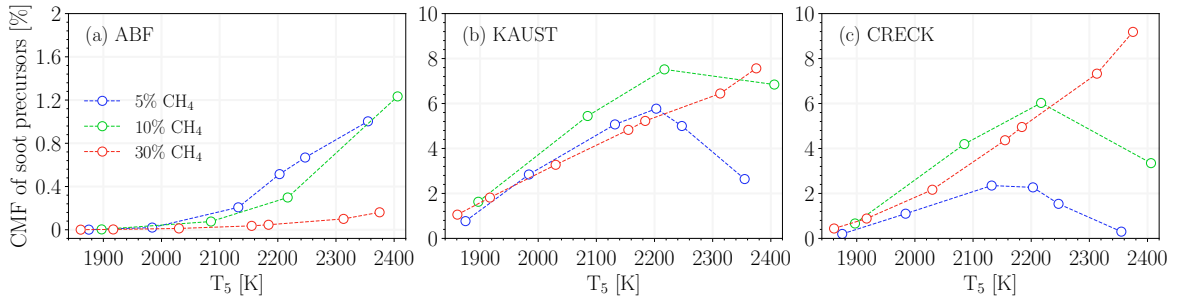


Fig. 4.21 The CMF of soot precursors combined at 1 ms over the studied  $T_5$  range predicted using (a) ABF, (b) KAUST, and (c) CRECK for 5%, 10%, and 30% loadings.

in ABF,  $C_3H_3$  is predominantly produced via  $C_2H_2 + CH_2 \leftrightarrow C_3H_3 + H$ , in the other mechanisms propyne (P- $C_3H_4$ ) dehydrogenation ( $P-C_3H_4 \leftrightarrow C_3H_3 + H$ ) is responsible for  $C_3H_3$  production. As shown in Fig. A.21, CMF of P- $C_3H_4$  predicted by ABF remains below 0.03% by 1 ms for all loadings and temperatures, which is nearly 60 times lower than the predictions of other kinetic mechanisms. Analysis of the reaction fluxes indicates that propyne (P- $C_3H_4$ ) is produced primarily via  $C_2H_2 + CH_3 \leftrightarrow P-C_3H_4 + H$ . The forward rate constant of the reaction in ABF is nearly two orders of magnitude lower than the other mechanisms (Fig. A.19), leading to underprediction of P- $C_3H_4$ . FFCM2 predicts a larger CMF of P- $C_3H_4$  compared to KAUST and CRECK due to the lower subsequent consumption of  $C_3H_3$  leading to carbon accumulation in P- $C_3H_4$ .

The lower consumption of  $C_3H_3$  in FFCM2 is due to the lack of propargyl recombination reaction,  $2C_3H_3 \leftrightarrow A1$ , which is dominant in ABF and KAUST, and a major consumption reaction in CRECK. On other hand,  $C_3H_3 + CH_3 \leftrightarrow C_4H_6$  is the dominant  $C_3H_3$  consumption reaction in CRECK and FFCM2. The peak CMF of  $C_3H_3$  consistently decreases in all kinetic mechanisms is primarily due to lower  $CH_4$  conversion at higher loadings. KAUST exhibits the highest carbon flux from  $C_3H_3$  to

A1, which rapidly propagates to larger PAHs. At 5% and 10% loadings, nearly 23% of the total carbon mass resides in  $C_6$  and larger species ( $C_{\geq 6}$ ) in KAUST, whereas the CMF of  $C_{\geq 6}$  remains below 12% for CRECK and ABF.

More than 55% of the carbon flux from  $CH_4$  is directed to  $C_2H_4$  across all mechanisms and conditions through two dominant pathways:  $CH_4 \rightarrow CH_3 \rightarrow C_2H_5 \rightarrow C_2H_4$  and  $CH_4 \rightarrow CH_3 \rightarrow C_2H_6 \rightarrow C_2H_5 \rightarrow C_2H_4$ . As shown in Fig. 4.16d-i, ABF and KAUST overpredict the  $C_2H_4$  peak at 10% and 30% loadings. FFCM2 and CRECK yield similar  $C_2H_4$  profiles and reproduce the peak more accurately. The subsequent decline in  $C_2H_4$  results from carbon transfer to  $C_2H_2$  through the dominant pathway  $C_2H_4 \rightarrow C_2H_3 \rightarrow C_2H_2$  except for CRECK, which includes an additional direct pathway from  $C_2H_4$  to  $C_2H_2$  via the third-body reaction  $C_2H_4 + M \leftrightarrow C_2H_2 + H_2 + M$ .

Time-resolved mole fraction of  $C_2H_2$  is shown in Fig. 4.20. At 30% loading,  $C_2H_2$  measurements are better captured by the kinetic mechanisms compared to  $CH_4$  because the selected transitions near 2998 nm targeting the asymmetric C-H stretch of acetylene are spectrally isolated from other hydrocarbons [198]. At 5% loading, a noticeable drop is observed in ABF's prediction of  $C_2H_2$  relative to the other mechanisms from 1875 K to 2203 K due to the rapid accumulation of carbon in A1. The CMF of  $C_{\geq 6}$  changes from 0.7% to 10.7% for ABF and from 3.3% to 6% for CRECK. FFCM2 best captures  $C_2H_2$  yield at 5% over the entire  $T_5$  range. At 10% loading and 2217 K, all model predictions fall within the measurement uncertainty, but their trends differ slightly. FFCM2 predicts a faster rise after 0.4 ms in  $C_2H_2$  compared to ABF and CRECK, which better reproduce the trends in the measurements. At 30% loading, ABF and KAUST closely predict the upper and lower uncertainty range of  $C_2H_2$  mole fraction at both temperatures, respectively. The high  $C_2H_2$  predictions by ABF, despite its low  $CH_4$  conversion values, are the compound effect of having the highest carbon flux from  $C_2H_4$  to  $C_2H_2$  and the lowest carbon flux from  $C_2H_2$  to  $C_3H_3$ .

Fig. 4.21 shows the dependence of the carbon mass fraction (CMF) of soot precursors on  $T_5$  and fuel loading at 1 ms. Results for FFCM2 are not included because it does not contain PAH chemistry. ABF predicts the lowest CMF ( $\leq 1.2\%$ ) among the kinetic mechanisms, with a monotonic increase with  $T_5$  and a decrease with fuel loading. In contrast, KAUST and CRECK exhibit a bell-shaped temperature dependence at 5% and 10% loadings, while the CMF increases monotonically with  $T_5$  at 30% loading.

These trends arise from the combined effects of endothermic cooling during pyrolysis and the intrinsic temperature dependence of precursor formation in each kinetic mechanism. The Const-TP results (Fig. A.22) show that all mechanisms predict a bell-shaped CMF profile with temperature. The peak CMF occurs near 2075 K for



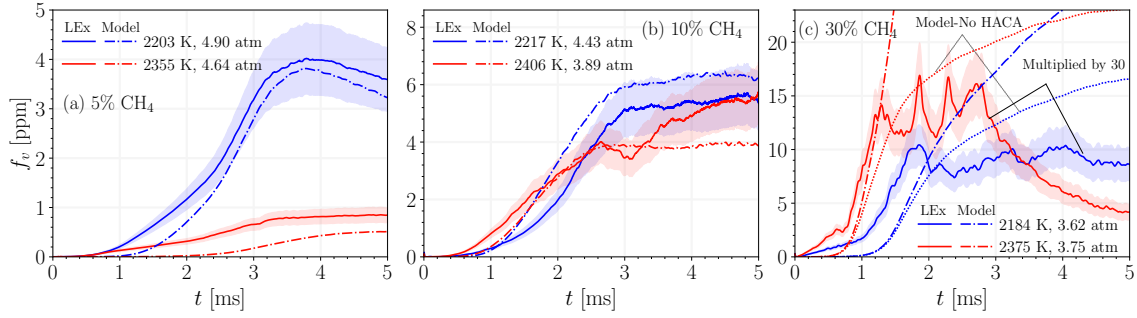


Fig. 4.22 The time history of soot volume fraction,  $f_v$ , for (a) 5%, (b) 10%, and (c) 30%  $\text{CH}_4$  pyrolysis from laser extinction (LEx) and model prediction using CRECK at  $T_5 \approx 2200$  K and 2400 K.

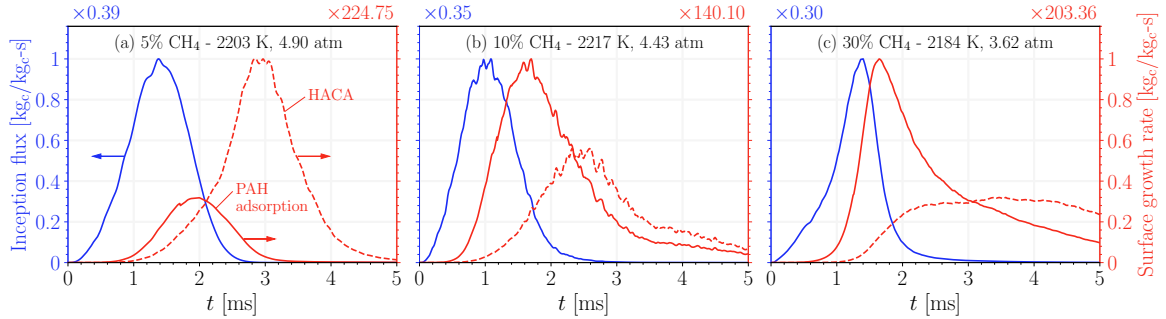


Fig. 4.23 The soot inception flux and surface growth rates via PAH adsorption and HACA (a) 5%, (b) 10%, and (c) 30%  $\text{CH}_4$  pyrolysis predicted using CRECK at  $T_5 \approx 2200$  K.

ABF, but around 1875 K for KAUST and CRECK. As shown in Fig. 4.18, the predicted gas temperature at 0.5 ms never exceeds 2075 K under the studied conditions, so all ABF cases remain on the rising side of the bell-shaped curve, yielding a persistently increasing trend with  $T_5$ . For KAUST and CRECK, the predicted temperature exceeds 1875 K at 5% and 10% loadings when  $T_5 > 2200$  K, causing the CMF of soot precursors to decrease beyond this point. At 30% loading, stronger endothermic cooling limits the temperature rise, preventing the system from reaching the descending branch of the bell-shaped curve and resulting in a monotonic increase in CMF with  $T_5$ .

### 4.2.3 Soot particles

As previously discussed, the time histories of species mole fraction predicted using CRECK are in overall closer agreement with the measurements, so it can provide a more accurate description of carbon flux from  $\text{C}_{1,2}$  species to  $\text{C}_{6\geq}$  chemistry including PAHs, necessary for description of soot inception and surface growth. Soot model

is coupled to CRECK, and it affects the gas chemistry mainly by consumption of precursors (Section 4.2.1) and  $C_2H_2$ . Additional simulations were performed without considering soot, and the analysis of results suggests that soot formation has negligible effect on the mole fraction of  $CH_4$ ,  $C_2H_4$ , and  $C_2H_2$  in 1 ms of simulation.

Fig. 4.22 compares the predicted soot volume fraction,  $f_v$ , using CRECK with the measurements of 633 nm laser extinction recorded for 5 ms. The shaded area represents the uncertainty in  $f_v$  due to the variability of the soot absorption function,  $E(m)$ , discussed in Section 4.2.1. The  $f_v$  at  $T_5 \approx 1900$  K were below the signal noise level, thus not shown here.

The model successfully captures the time trend of  $f_v$  at 5% and 10% loadings, but a noticeable underprediction at 5% is observed. The predicted primary particle and mobility diameters are below 20 nm and 100 nm, respectively, supporting the assumption of negligible contribution of scattering (less than 7%) to total extinction [199]. The late-time ( $t \geq 3.5$  ms) decrease in the predicted and measured  $f_v$  at 5% loading (Fig. 4.22a) is due to the pressure drop by nearly 2 atm between 3-5 ms that expands the gas, fictitiously reducing  $f_v = V_{\text{soot}}/V_{\text{gas}}$ . In fact, as shown in Fig. A.23a, the soot yield ( $M_{c,\text{soot}}/M_{c,CH_4,0}$ ) from predictions at 2203 K and 2322 K asymptotically approaches 39% and 6.2%, respectively. The model captures the reduction of  $f_v$  with temperature from  $\approx 2200$  K to  $\approx 2400$  K observed at 5% and 10% loadings, consistent with the bell-shaped temperature dependence of  $f_v$  [171], which closely follows that of soot precursors shown in Fig. 4.21.

At 30% loading (Fig. 4.22c), there is a large discrepancy between the model and the measurements that were multiplied by 30 to better illustrate the trends. The measured  $f_v$  remains below 0.6 ppm until 5 ms, which is even lower than the  $f_v$  of 5% and 10% loadings. Despite overprediction, model captures the overall early-time behavior of the measurements that begins with a slow rise ( $< 1$  ms for  $T_5 = 2184$  K) followed by a faster increase (1-1.8 ms). However, the subsequent decrease in the measurements at nearly 1.8 ms for  $T_5 = 2184$  K and 1.2 ms for  $T_5 = 2375$  K differs from the model predictions that continue to grow. Interestingly, the time of decrease of measured  $f_v$  at both  $T_5$  is close to the inflection point of the predicted  $f_v$ , which represents the transition of the dominant surface growth mechanism from PAH adsorption to HACA. The simulation results without HACA (dotted line in Fig. 4.22c) highlights the significant contribution of HACA to  $f_v$  growth beyond the inflection point, and reveals remarkable similarity in their time history and the measurement. Such similarity could indicate potential missing pathways or mechanisms that limit HACA surface growth. Nevertheless, experimental uncertainties inherent at high fuel loadings, especially non-idealities such

as bifurcation [200] and shock-boundary layer interaction [201] can influence the optical path, potentially introducing artifacts that the 0D model does not capture.

Figure 4.23 presents the inception flux and surface growth rates for all fuel loadings at  $\approx 2200$  K, expressed as the rate at which each mechanism converts a fraction of the total carbon mass into soot. Inception and PAH adsorption reach their maxima before 2 ms and subsequently decline due to the depletion of soot precursors. The transition in the dominant surface growth mechanism is observed for all fuel loadings at  $\approx 2200$  K, with the peak of HACA occurring later than that of PAH adsorption. In addition, the relative contribution of PAH adsorption increases with fuel loading compared to HACA. At 30% loading (Fig. 4.23c), HACA does not exhibit a pronounced peak, but instead maintains a relatively uniform rate between 2 and 5 ms. This trend in the relative strength of HACA and PAH adsorption is not observed at  $\approx 2400$  K (Fig. A.24), highlighting the strong dependence of inception and surface growth rates on the temperature history, which is governed by the post-reflected-shock pressure trace and the endothermicity of methane pyrolysis.

### 4.3 Identifying stages of soot formation

This section presents the paper titled “*Yield, morphology and maturity of carbon black made by methane pyrolysis in a shock tube*” and submitted to *Carbon journal*, and it is focused on using Omnisoot to identify different stages of soot formation during methane pyrolysis in a shock-tube.

Despite extensive studies on the chemical kinetics of methane pyrolysis (Refs. in [202]), the mechanisms governing soot formation remain poorly understood. This limitation arises from incomplete knowledge of the pathways leading to soot inception and from uncertainties in existing kinetic mechanisms [171]. These uncertainties originate with methane dissociation reactions [203] and propagate through key intermediates such as methyl ( $\text{CH}_3$ ) [179], ethylene ( $\text{C}_2\text{H}_4$ ), and acetylene ( $\text{C}_2\text{H}_2$ ) [204]. The uncertainty is further amplified for polycyclic aromatic hydrocarbons (PAHs) [184], which are widely accepted as the primary precursors to soot [19]. Previous studies have shown that predicted concentrations of large PAHs can vary by orders of magnitude depending on the kinetic mechanism employed [164]. This variability underscores the need for time-resolved measurements of gas-phase species and particulate properties under well-controlled conditions to improve quantitative understanding of methane conversion, intermediate formation, and carbon flux to soot through inception and surface growth.

Shock tubes are powerful tools for this purpose because a wide range of temperatures (1700-3000 K [171]) and pressures (1-100 atm [205]) can be achieved by adjusting the pre-shock pressure ratio; the instant heating of the mixture behind the reflected shock creates a nearly isothermal and isobaric condition over a short test time (1-3 ms) with minimal diffusion and mixing [191], which is an ideal setting for kinetic studies of pyrolysis pathways and soot inception and surface growth.

Capturing the rapid decomposition of methane and the subsequent formation of intermediates can be achieved with the high temporal resolution offered by continuous-wave (CW) laser absorption spectroscopy [188]. In this technique, the attenuation of light in an absorbing medium is related to the gas density through the Beer–Lambert law, provided that the absorption cross-section is known. Accurate application, however, is complicated by the strong dependence of the absorption cross-section on temperature, pressure, and gas composition. soot yield and volume fraction can also be quantified with good accuracy from light extinction measurements based on the same principle, as long as the particles remain in the Rayleigh limit and the particle volume fraction is below 10 ppm [191]. This approach requires prior knowledge of the optical properties of soot, represented by the absorption function  $E(m)$ .

While a constant  $E(m)$  value of mature soot is commonly used to retrieve volume fractions from extinction data [206, 171, 207], the optical properties are noticeably different for incipient and mature soot [129]. During maturation, soot particles undergo structural and chemical changes that result in the reduction of hydrogen-to-carbon ratio (H/C) due to carbonization [45] that increases the density and specific heat [129]. The maturity level of soot is linked to the spectral dependence of absorption [208] quantified by the ratio of  $E(m)$  at two different wavelengths [209] that approaches unity for mature soot; therefore, performing extinction measurements at multiple wavelengths can reduce the uncertainties of  $E(m)$  and provide a good measure of soot maturity.

This section deals with simultaneous measurements of gaseous species and soot during the pyrolysis of 5% CH<sub>4</sub> at post-reflected-shock pressures near 5 atm and temperatures between 1800 and 2500 K. In that work, a computational framework coupling detailed gas-phase chemistry with soot inception, surface growth, and coagulation is developed to describe methane-to-soot conversion, successfully reproducing the measured time histories of key gas-phase species and soot volume fraction, as well as the final primary particle diameter. A detailed analysis of the simulation results, complemented by experimental measurements, is conducted to delineate distinct stages of soot formation based on the time evolution of  $f_v$  and carbon yield. Within each

stage, the evolution of inception flux and surface growth mechanisms is examined to elucidate their influence on  $f_v$ , yield, and morphology, as well as their coupling with gas-phase chemistry. The deviation of model predictions from  $f_v$ ,  $d_p$ , and induction time measurements are discussed in detail. Particular emphasis is placed on the role of carbonization in describing soot maturity, its effect in limiting surface growth rates, and its connection to the spectral dependence of soot particles characterized through multi-wavelength light extinction.

### 4.3.1 Experimental methods

A brief overview of the employed experimental techniques is presented here. Mole fraction time histories of methane ( $\text{CH}_4$ ), acetylene ( $\text{C}_2\text{H}_2$ ), and ethylene ( $\text{C}_2\text{H}_4$ ) were captured using CW laser absorption at 3.365  $\mu\text{m}$ , 2.998  $\mu\text{m}$ , and 10.532  $\mu\text{m}$ , respectively [190, 188, 189]. soot volume fraction was measured using laser light extinction at  $\lambda=633$  nm and 1064 nm:

$$f_v = \frac{1}{L} \frac{\ln(I_0/I_t)\lambda}{6\pi E(m)}, \quad (4.3)$$

where  $L=14.12$  cm is the absorption path length, equal to the inner diameter of the shock tube.  $\lambda$  is the absorption wavelength, and  $I_0$  and  $I_t$  are the incident and transmitted intensities, respectively. Table 4.5 indicates the conditions of the shock-tube tests with  $1800 \text{ K} < T_5 < 2400 \text{ K}$  and  $P_5=4.5 \pm 0.5$  atm.  $f_v$  was determined from the measured extinction at 633 nm and 1064 nm, considering the reported variability of  $E(m)$  in the literature, ranging from 0.174 [172] to 0.26 [105] for 633 nm and from 0.2 to 0.3 for 1064 nm [210].

Additionally, soot samples were collected onto imaging stubs mounted in the shock-tube endwall. Samples were extracted from the interior surface of the shock tube endwall after each experiment to allow for imaging and analysis of the particulates. TEM images were recorded with a FEI Tecnai G2 F20 X-TWIN microscope and Gatan SC200 camera for all test cases. Primary particle diameter,  $d_p$ , was obtained by visually identifying the smallest circumscribed circle enclosing each primary particle in the TEM images and calculating the arithmetic and geometric means. A minimum of 200 primary particles were measured for each condition. Fig. 4.24 depicts representative TEM images collected for the test at  $T_5=2203$  K, with identified primary particles shown as superimposed red circles.

Table 4.5 The post-reflected-shock pressure ( $P_5$ ) and temperature ( $T_5$ ) of the executed shock-tube tests.

|             | (1)  | (2)  | (3)  | (4)  | (5)  | (6)  | (7)  |
|-------------|------|------|------|------|------|------|------|
| $T_5$ [K]   | 1875 | 1984 | 2132 | 2203 | 2247 | 2322 | 2355 |
| $P_5$ [atm] | 4.45 | 4.30 | 4.17 | 4.90 | 4.51 | 4.55 | 4.64 |

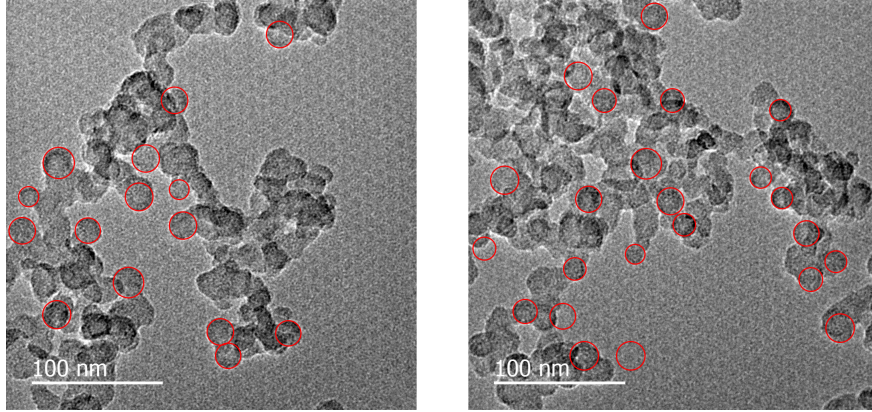


Fig. 4.24 Samples of TEM images collected for  $T_5=2203$  K. Red circles represent the identified primary particles used to measure  $d_p$ .

### 4.3.2 Numerical model

The 0-D imposed-pressure reactor (IPR) model of Omnisoot [192] was used to simulate soot formation coupled with chemical kinetics during the pyrolysis process under post-reflected-shock conditions in the shock tube. IPR incorporates a sectional population balance model (SPBM) to describe the evolving size distribution of soot agglomerates by tracking the number of agglomerates,  $N_{agg}$ , primary particles,  $N_{pri}$ , total carbon,  $C_{tot}$ , and hydrogen content,  $H_{tot}$ .

The measured pressure trace was filtered to reduce noise and fluctuations, and then imposed on the model. The measured pressure remains within 10% of the initial value until 2 ms for all tests. Fig. 4.25a highlights the deviation of the (filtered) pressure time history from the initial pressure of  $P_5=4.30$  atm at  $T_5=1984$  K. The pressure starts to rise at  $\approx 2.2$  ms, reaches its peak at  $\approx 3.1$  ms, and drops towards the end of the test time due to the arrival of the expansion wave. Fig. 4.25b shows a similar deviation in the predicted temperature. The analysis of species mole fractions showed that the imposed pressure results in lower  $\text{CH}_4$  conversion and  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_2$  yield, thereby reducing PAH formation and soot inception flux. As shown in Fig. 4.25c,  $f_v$  values predicted using constant and imposed pressure are close until 3.9 ms, but the

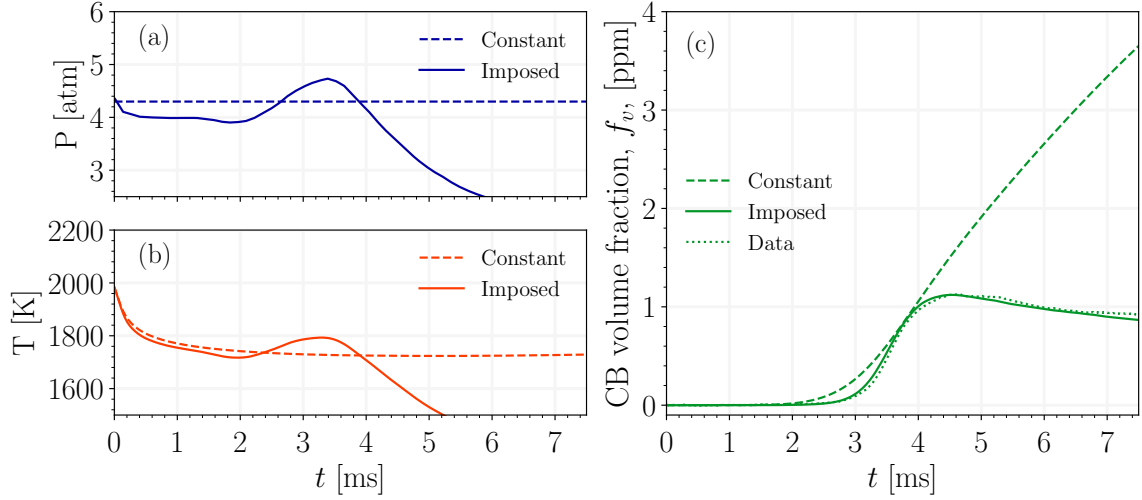


Fig. 4.25 The comparison of (a) pressure (b) temperature (c) soot volume fraction for simulations with constant and imposed pressure trace at  $T_5=1984$  K.

discrepancy grows after that, where only the simulation with the imposed pressure captures the experimental time trends.

Soot precursors considered in this study include naphthalene (A2), phenanthrene (A3), pyrene (A4), acenaphthylene (A2R5), acephenanthrylene (A3R5), and cyclopentapyrene (A4R5), due to extensive support in the literature for their role in the initial steps of soot formation [211, 212]. The E-Bridge Modified model is used to describe the dimerization and adsorption of precursors that contribute to soot inception and surface growth, respectively. The general formulation of the model is based on the inception model proposed by Frenklach and Mebel [25], with some modifications detailed in [192]. Two scaling factors,  $\eta_{inc}$  and  $\eta_{ads}$ , between 0 and 1 are used to adjust the inception and PAH adsorption rates, respectively [192].

The surface growth is described by the H-abstraction- $C_2H_2$ /Carbon-addition (HACA) scheme [57], but the surface density of hydrogenated sites,  $\chi_{soot-H}$ , is dynamically calculated as the ratio of hydrogen content to the surface area of agglomerates, i.e.,  $\chi_{soot-H} = H_{tot}/A_{tot}$  [53]. An Arrhenius equation is used to account for the loss of hydrogen by the carbonization of soot particles as [194]:

$$k_{carb} = A_{carb} \cdot \exp\left(\frac{-E_{carb}}{RT}\right), \quad (4.4)$$

$$\left(\frac{dH_{tot}}{dt}\right)_{carb} = -k_{carb} \cdot H_{tot}, \quad (4.5)$$

where  $A_{carb}$  and  $E_{carb}$  are the exponential prefactor and activation energy for carbonization, respectively.  $H_{tot}/A_{tot}$  depends on the relative contributions of PAH adsorption and HACA, and the carbonization rate. The comparison of  $\chi_{soot-H}$  with its nominal value of  $2.3 \times 10^{19}$  sites/ $m^2$  used in the original HACA formulation [40] shows that the dynamic method strongly depends on the temperature time history, and it predicts an overall larger number of reaction sites for  $T_5 < 2300$  K (Fig. A.8).

### 4.3.3 Precursor chemistry

A detailed discussion of the time histories of measured species was presented in our previous work [165]. The performance analysis of six kinetic mechanisms indicated that FFCM2 [170] provides the best agreement across the entire temperature range, especially for  $CH_4$  conversion and  $C_2H_2$  yield, but it does not include PAH chemistry necessary for inception and surface growth, so it cannot be used for soot modeling. As shown in Fig. 4.26a and b, the CRECK mechanism predicts  $CH_4$  and  $C_2H_2$  mole fractions in close agreement with the measurements, considering their uncertainty range. CRECK includes the PAH chemistry necessary for soot inception and surface growth. Fig. 4.26c and d depict the mole fractions of A2 and A2R5, which similarly increase with time. For  $T_5 > 2200$  K, the mole fraction of PAHs reaches its peak and gradually decreases within 1 ms, primarily due to conversion to  $C_2H_2$  rather than soot inception. The mole fraction of A2 and A2R5 sampled at 1 ms follows the well-known bell-shaped behavior with the peak near 2200 K. The analysis of the carbon mass fraction (CMF) of precursors over the studied  $T_5$  range indicated that A2 and A2R5 are the major contributors to soot inception due to their larger CMFs compared to the other precursors. The initial composition of soot is dictated by the H/C ratio of constituent precursors, which changes within a narrow range, slightly decreasing from 0.8 at 1875 K to 0.67 at 2355 K.

### 4.3.4 Stages of soot formation

As shown in Fig. 4.27a, the optimized model reproduces the time evolution of  $f_v$  measured using 1064 nm light extinction at 1984 K. The reported  $f_v$  measurements are the average of values calculated using the min and max  $E(m)$  of each wavelength. The predicted  $f_v$  profile exhibits four distinct stages: (I) an initial period with negligible soot mass due to low inception and surface growth, known as the soot induction time, which is slightly overestimated by the model ( $\approx 2.3$  ms) compared to the measurements ( $\approx 1.9$  ms). A detailed discussion of induction time over the entire  $T_5$  range is provided



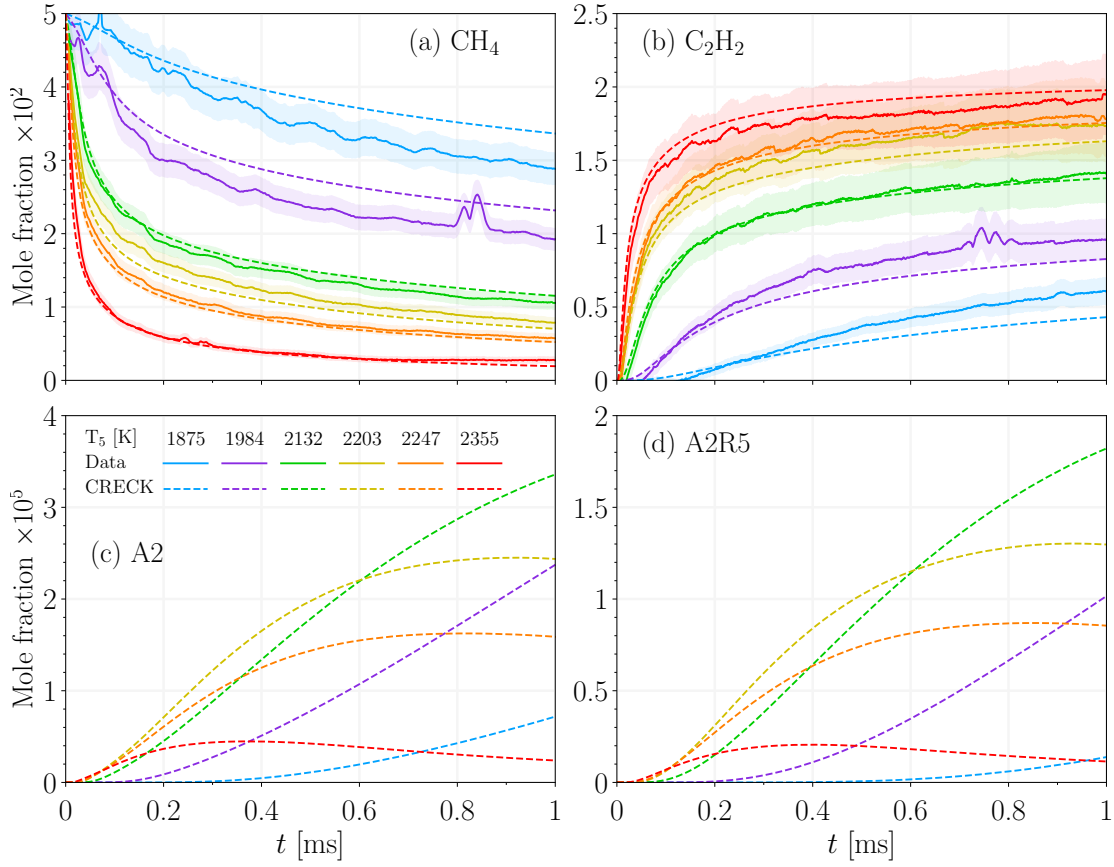


Fig. 4.26 The time history of (a)  $\text{CH}_4$  and (b)  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_2$  predicted using CRECK mechanisms in close agreement with the laser absorption measurements. The shaded area represents the uncertainty in the measurements.

in Section 4.3.5. In stage (II), rapid growth occurs in  $f_v$ , driven by increasing PAH adsorption and HACA. The end of stage (II) signifies the inflection point in  $f_v$ , where both surface growth mechanisms reach their peak, as shown in Fig. 4.27b. At 1984 K, PAH adsorption is the dominant surface growth, accounting for nearly 79% of total soot mass by 7.5 ms, and the rest ( $\approx 21\%$ ) originates from HACA. Inception is mainly active in stages (I) and (II), and its contribution to total soot mass remains less than 0.3%. In stage (III), the increase of  $f_v$  slows down due to the decline in both surface growth mechanisms. The time histories of  $f_v$  and carbon yield, CY, are similar in the first two stages, but  $f_v$  deviates from CY in stage (III). While  $f_v$  gradually decreases at  $t \approx 4.6$  ms, CY gradually increases to reach 14.3%. The decline of  $f_v = V_{\text{soot}}/V_{\text{gas}}$  at  $\approx 4.56$  ms is attributed to gas-phase expansion caused by the arrival of the expansion wave at the endwall, reducing pressure (Fig. 4.25a) and increasing  $V_{\text{gas}}$  while  $V_{\text{soot}}$  remains constant.

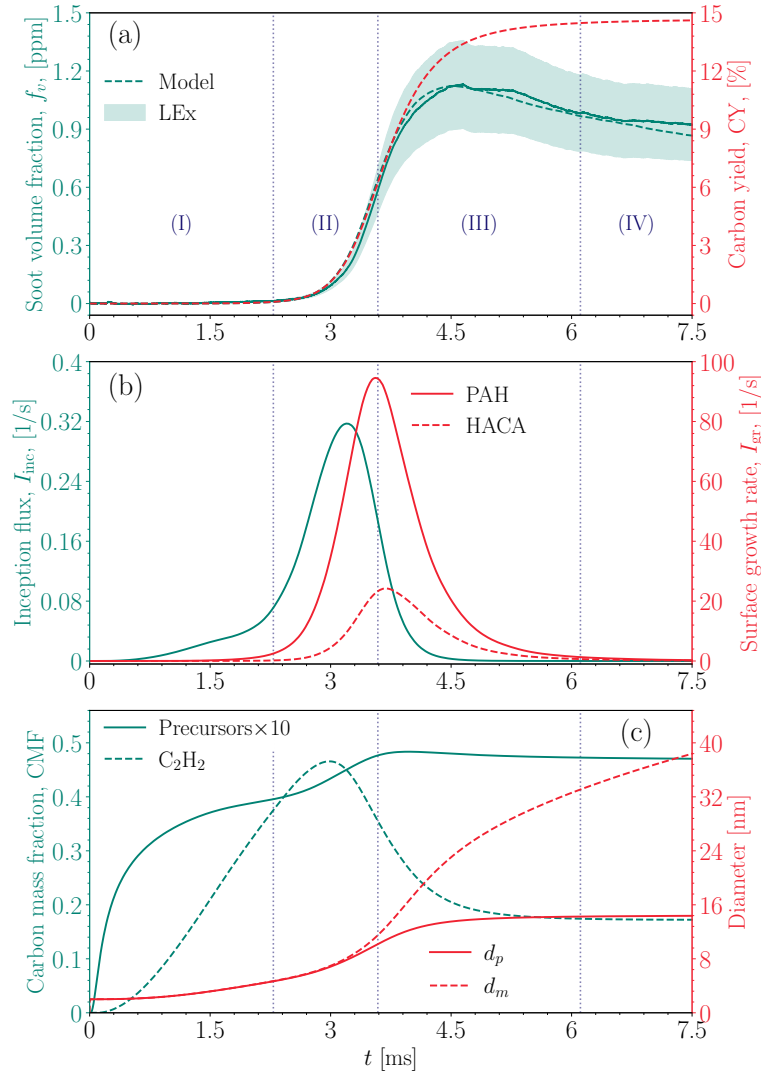


Fig. 4.27 The four stages of soot formation demonstrated at  $T_5=1984$  K for (a) soot volume fraction,  $f_v$ , and carbon yield, CY (b) surface growth rate,  $I_{gr}$ , via HACA and PAH adsorption, and inception flux; (c) the carbon mass fraction, CMF, of  $C_2H_2$  and soot precursors combined, and primary particle diameter,  $d_p$ , and mobility diameter  $d_m$ , of soot agglomerates. Panel (a) depicts the light extinction measurements at  $\lambda = 1064$  nm with the shaded area representing the uncertainty from the variability in  $E(m)$ .

In stage (IV), surface growth rates become negligible, and soot agglomerates are chemically frozen, growing primarily through Brownian coagulation. As shown in Fig. 4.27c, soot morphology undergoes a corresponding transition. Here,  $d_p$  and  $d_m$  denote the average primary particle diameter and mobility diameter, respectively. These diameters remain identical until approximately 3 ms, near the peak of inception

in stage (II), when most soot particles are spherical. Beyond 3 ms, the growth of  $d_p$  slows and reaches 99% of its terminal value of 14.4 nm before the end of stage (II) at approximately 5.89 ms, while  $d_m$  continues to increase due to ongoing coagulation.

The rapid decline in inception rates (Fig. 4.27b) is primarily driven by the consumption of precursors through PAH adsorption, as evidenced by a factor of 2.3 decrease in their CMF between approximately 3 ms and 4.5 ms (Fig. 4.27c). Beyond 4.5 ms, PAH adsorption decreases as the temperature falls below 1600 K, which suppresses PAH dehydrogenation in the E-Bridge Modified model [192] and reduces the availability of PAH radicals for adsorption onto soot particles. Consequently, the CMF of precursors continues to decline after 4.5 ms and approaches 0.172 by the end of stage (III).

The reduction in HACA rates during stage (III) is mainly caused by a temperature-driven decrease in H radical concentration, which lowers the number of dehydrogenated surface sites,  $\chi_{soot^o}$ , in the HACA formulation [57]. In addition, depletion of hydrogenated surface sites due to soot carbonization suppresses HACA rates throughout the simulation. Simulations performed without carbonization indicate an overprediction of the peak HACA rate by a factor of 2.4 and an overestimation of the final carbon yield by 46%. While carbonization reduces the magnitude of the HACA rate, it does not affect the timing of its peak. Accordingly, the four stages identified in Fig. 4.27 remain unchanged by carbonization.

Fig. 4.28 depicts the normalized soot volume fraction,  $f_v/f_{v,m}$ , and surface growth rate  $I_{gr}/I_{gr,m}$  for the entire studied  $T_5$  range. The time history of  $f_v$  is predicted by the model for the entire  $T_5$  range in good agreement with light extinction measurements, considering the sensitivity of  $f_v$  to the pressure trace. The measured  $f_v$  demonstrates that the onset of soot formation occurs earlier for higher  $T_5$ . In other words, stage (I) becomes shorter with increasing  $T_5$ . The model captures this shift from 1984 K to 2203 K, but noticeably predicts longer soot induction times at 2247 K and 2355 K compared to the measurements. The behavior of the model is dictated by precursor chemistry. PAH concentration has a bell-shaped temperature dependence with the peak at  $T_5=2203$  K. Therefore, the inception and PAH adsorption rates decrease when  $T_5$  increases to 2247 K and 2355 K.

HACA becomes the dominant surface growth mechanism for  $T_5 > 1984$  K, as indicated by its higher peak compared to PAH adsorption. The analysis of integrated surface growth rates indicates that the contribution of HACA to the total carbon mass of soot increases from 21% at 1984 K to 64% at 2132 K and 77% at 2203 K due to the increase in the inception flux producing more particles (active growth sites) and higher  $C_2H_2$  concentration (Fig. 4.26b). However, the contribution of HACA slightly

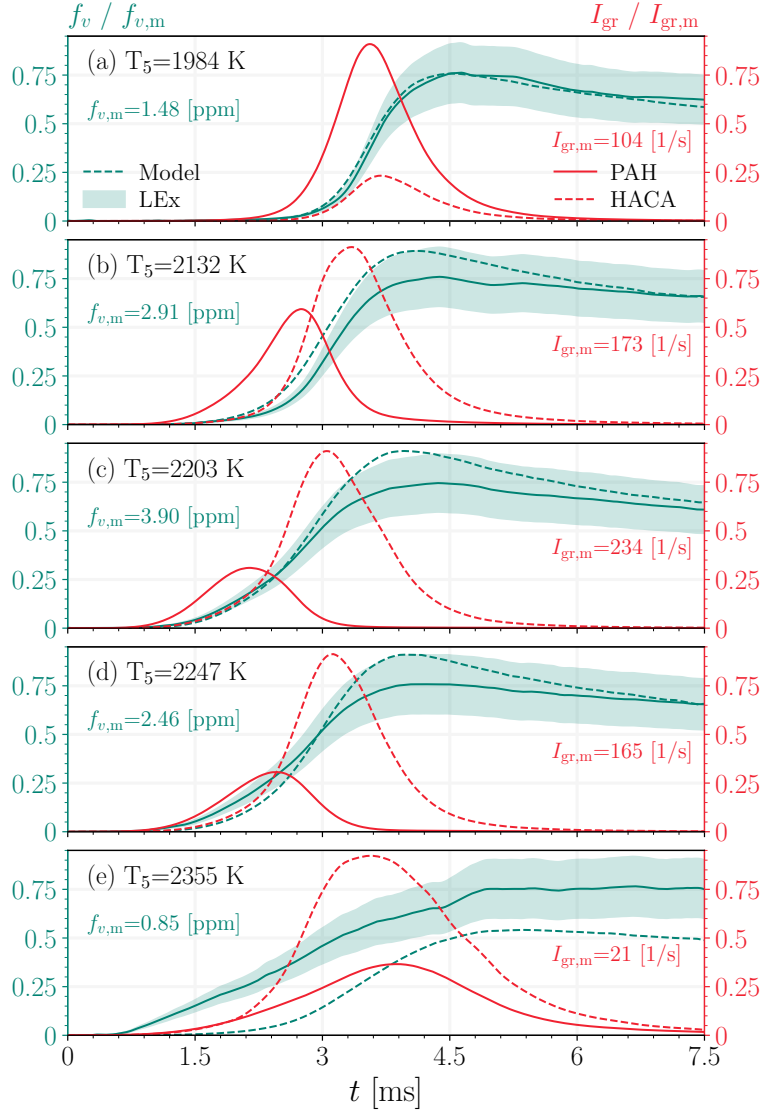


Fig. 4.28 The time histories of normalized soot volume fraction,  $f_v/f_{v,m}$  and normalized surface growth,  $I_{gr}/I_{gr,m}$  at various temperatures. The measurements are from light extinction at  $\lambda = 1064$  nm with the shaded area representing the uncertainty from the variability in  $E(m)$ .

decreases to 75% and 69% for 2247 K and 2355 K, respectively, because the suppression of HACA by carbonization increases with temperature. Without carbonization, carbon yield reaches  $\approx 100\%$  for  $T_5 \geq 2132$  K with HACA accounting for more than 90% of carbon mass.

As shown in Fig. 4.29,  $d_p$  starts from 2 nm, which is the diameter of incipient soot defined in the model, increases through surface growth, and asymptotically approaches its final value,  $d_{p,\infty}$ . The characteristic time  $\tau_{d_{p,\infty}}$ , defined as the time at which  $d_p$

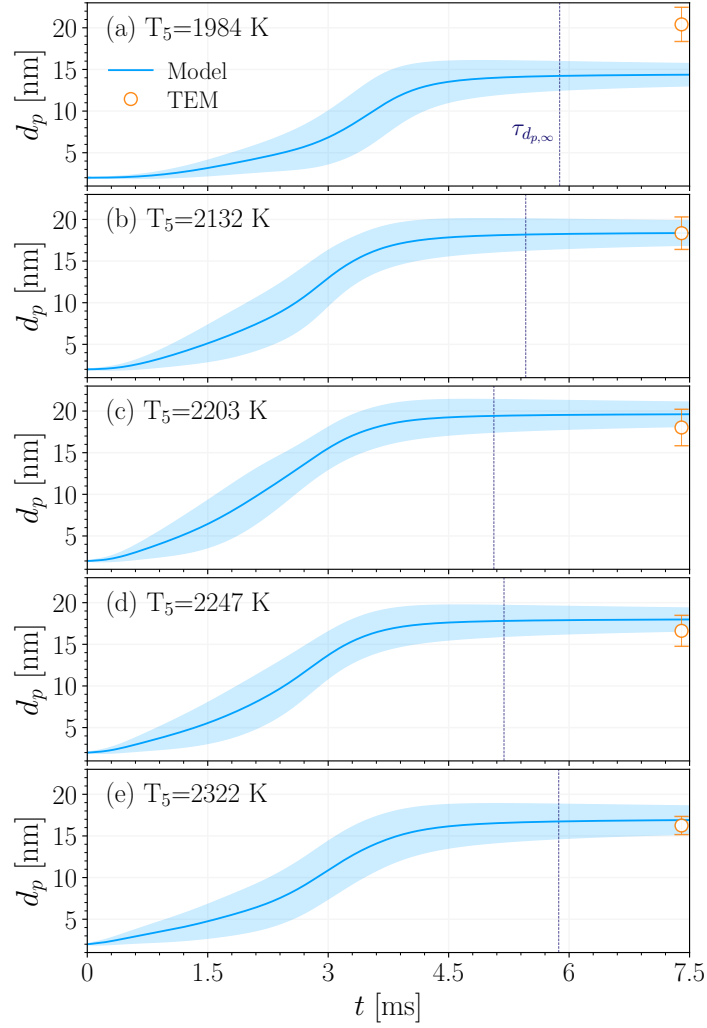


Fig. 4.29 The time histories of average primary particle diameter,  $d_p$  compared with TEM measurement. The shaded area, and error bar represents the  $d_p$  arithmetic standard deviation from the simulations and measurements, respectively. The dashed line specifies the time when  $d_p$  reaches 99% of its final value.

reaches 99% of  $d_{p, \infty}$ , remains below 6 ms for all  $T_5$ . These results indicate that no significant evolution of the primary particle diameter occurs beyond  $\tau_{d_p, \infty}$ . Therefore,  $d_p$  measured from collected TEM samples provides a representative measure of soot morphology within the studied time window. The predicted  $d_{p, \infty}$  is in close agreement with the measurement, except for a noticeable underprediction at  $T_5=1984$  K.  $d_{p, \infty}$  varies in a narrow range of 14-21 nm across various conditions. Primary particles have a relatively narrow size distribution; the standard deviation of  $d_p$  increases due to persistent inception and surface growth, reaches a maximum of 3.8 nm, and finally converges to  $\approx 1.5$  nm. Table 4.6 lists arithmetic and geometric means and their

Table 4.6 The primary particle diameter measurements from TEM images.  $d_p$  is arithmetic mean,  $d_{p,g}$  geometric mean,  $\sigma_p$  arithmetic standard deviation, and  $\sigma_{p,g}$  geometric standard deviation.

| $T_5$ [K] | $d_p$ [nm]  |       | $d_{p,g}$ [nm] |       | $\sigma_p$ [nm] |       | $\sigma_{p,g}$ |       |
|-----------|-------------|-------|----------------|-------|-----------------|-------|----------------|-------|
|           | TEM         | Model | TEM            | Model | TEM             | Model | TEM            | Model |
| 1984      | <b>20.4</b> | 14.4  | <b>20.3</b>    | 14.3  | <b>2.1</b>      | 1.3   | <b>1.10</b>    | 1.10  |
| 2132      | <b>18.3</b> | 18.4  | <b>18.3</b>    | 18.3  | <b>2.0</b>      | 1.5   | <b>1.11</b>    | 1.08  |
| 2203      | <b>18.0</b> | 19.6  | <b>17.9</b>    | 19.6  | <b>2.2</b>      | 1.5   | <b>1.13</b>    | 1.08  |
| 2247      | <b>16.6</b> | 18.0  | <b>16.5</b>    | 17.9  | <b>1.9</b>      | 1.4   | <b>1.12</b>    | 1.08  |
| 2322      | <b>16.3</b> | 16.9  | <b>16.2</b>    | 16.8  | <b>1.1</b>      | 1.7   | <b>1.07</b>    | 1.11  |

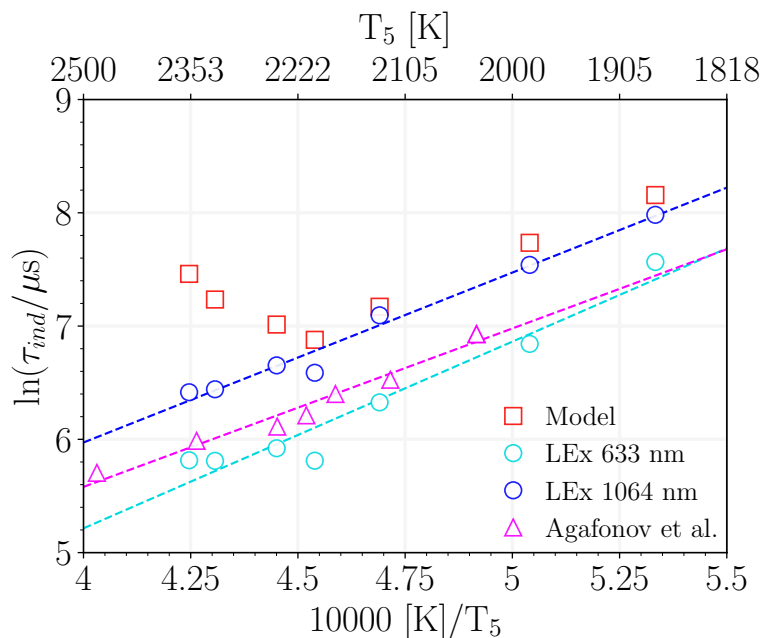


Fig. 4.30 The predicted soot induction time,  $\tau_{ind}$ , compared with light extinction measurements at 633 nm and 1064 nm, and with the data from Agafonov et al. [213]. The dashed line is the Arrhenius fit to the measurements.

corresponding standard deviations for the primary particle diameter computed from TEM measurements and model predictions. The difference between arithmetic ( $d_p$ ) and geometric ( $d_{p,g}$ ) remains less than 0.8% across various conditions.

### 4.3.5 The effect of temperature

The soot induction time ( $\tau_{ind}$ ) is defined as the time extinction level exceeds the noise floor, and it provides a measure of the earliest detectable soot mass and avoid effects of

pressure gradients at later times. The noise floor is  $f_v E(m) = 2 \times 10^{-9}$ , or  $f_v \approx 8$  ppb (set by beam steering effects). Fig. 4.30 demonstrates the predicted  $\tau_{ind}$  along with the measurements at 1064 nm and 633 nm that closely follow an Arrhenius-like behavior, expressed as  $\tau_{ind} = A_{ind} \exp(E_{ind}/RT)$  [213], where  $E_{ind}$  is defined as the activation energy of soot inception. The value of  $E_{ind}$  is  $\approx 130$  kJ for both wavelengths, consistent with the range suggested in the literature [191], but 1064 nm measurements result in longer induction times.  $\tau_{ind}$  obtained from 633 nm measurements are in agreement with the measurements by Agafonov et al. [213] for 5% CH<sub>4</sub> using the same wavelength. The observed difference in  $\tau_{ind}$  between two wavelengths is due to higher absorbance at 633 nm, which has been attributed to the non-negligible contribution of large PAHs to absorption at 633 nm [214]. In fact, Migliorini et al. [103] showed that the absorption of gaseous species extends up to 700 nm. However, PAHs smaller than circumcoronene (C<sub>54</sub>H<sub>10</sub>) are not likely to absorb in wavelengths above 550 nm [215].

The model closely reproduces the experimental trends in the low-to-mid temperature range (1800 K-2200 K), but deviates from the measurements for  $T_5 > 2200$  K. In fact, the model predicts an inverse temperature dependence for  $\tau_{ind}$  relative to PAH concentration, reaching a minimum near the temperature of maximum PAH abundance ( $\approx 2200$  K) and increasing at higher temperatures where PAH concentrations decline. The carbon yield at  $\tau_{ind}$  is close to 0.1% for  $T_5 \geq 1984$  K. The analysis of simulations results at  $\tau_{ind}$  suggests that inception accounts for 4.5%-6.7% of total soot mass, while the contribution of PAH adsorption decreases from 88% at  $T_5 = 1875$  K and 1984 K to 50% at 2355 K. Therefore, the majority of carbon mass at  $\tau_{ind}$  originates from precursors that exhibit a bell-shaped temperature dependence. Further analysis suggests that carbonization prolongs the induction time by suppressing HACA rates, but does not alter the temperature dependence of  $\tau_{ind}$  (Fig. A.9). Additional simulations were conducted to assess the sensitivity of  $\tau_{inc}$  to precursor selection, in which individual PAHs in the CRECK mechanism were treated separately as the sole precursor. All PAHs produced a similar inverted bell-shaped temperature dependence of  $\tau_{inc}$ , as shown in Fig. 4.30.

As shown in Fig. 4.31, a bell-shaped temperature dependence of  $f_v$  is observed in the light extinction measurements at 633 nm and 1064 nm at 2, 3, 4, and 5 ms. As discussed earlier, larger  $f_v$  values are inferred at 633 nm across the studied  $T_5$  range due to stronger absorption at this wavelength compared to 1064 nm. The temperature dependence of  $f_v$  is primarily governed by that of soot precursors (Fig. A.10) and evolves with time without significant changes in its overall shape, with the peak remaining consistently at  $T_5 = 2203$  K. The model reproduces this temperature dependence in

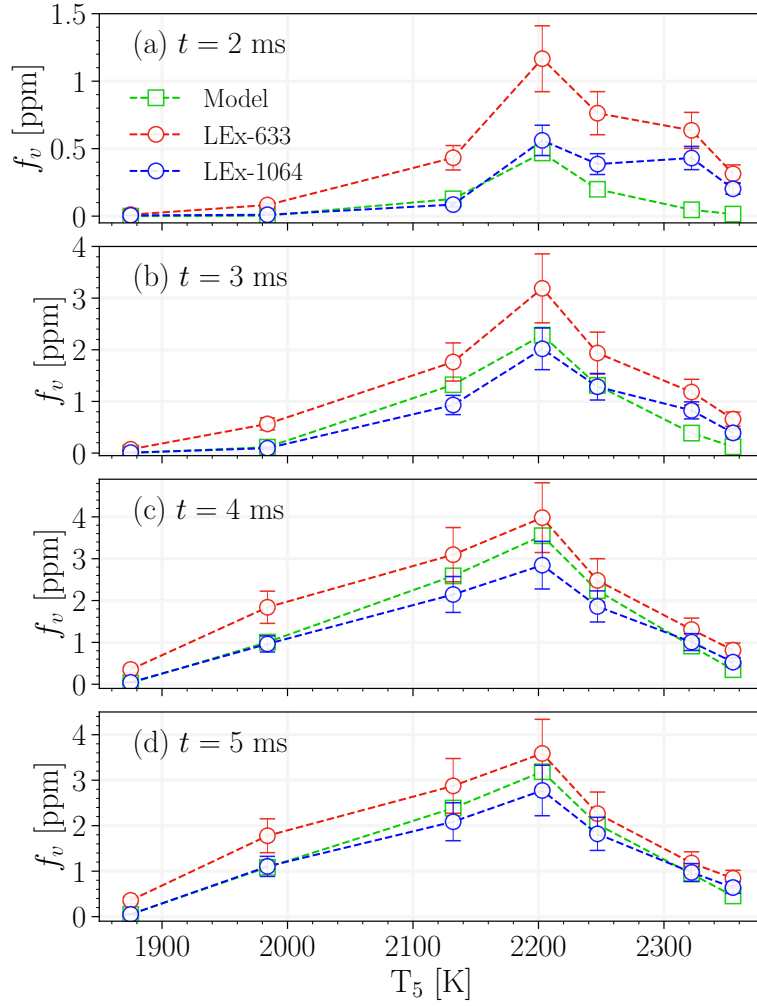


Fig. 4.31 The soot volume fraction,  $f_v$ , from light extinction at  $\lambda = 633$  nm sampled at 2 ms (a), 3 ms (b), 4 ms (c), and 5 ms and compared with the simulation results for  $T_5 = 1875, 1984, 2132, 2203, 2247, 2355$  K. Errors bars indicate experimental uncertainty due to variability in  $E(m)$ , and the dashed line is added to show the trends.

close agreement with the measurements. However, at 2 ms, the model noticeably underpredicts  $f_v$  for  $T_5 > 2203$  K, consistent with the overestimation of induction time in this temperature range. This discrepancy may be attributed to missing chemical pathways for PAH formation at high temperatures, which would otherwise accelerate inception and PAH adsorption [216].

Fig. 4.32 reveals a significant discrepancy between the predicted and measured temperature dependence of  $d_p$ . While the TEM measurements exhibit a decreasing trend with increasing  $T_5$ , the model predicts a bell-shaped profile similar to that of  $f_v$ , with a peak at 2203 K. No data point was obtained for TEM at  $T_5 = 1875$  K because the collected particles appear as compact carbonaceous lumps with poorly defined



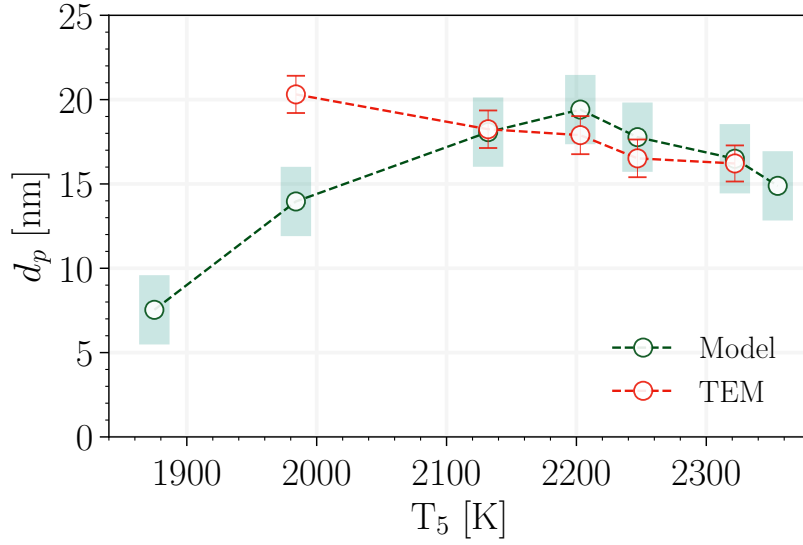


Fig. 4.32 The final primary particle diameter,  $d_p$ , from TEM measurements compared with the model predictions.

boundaries between primary particles rather than chain-like aggregates (Fig. A.14), which makes the identification of individual primary particles by visual inspection highly uncertain. Nevertheless, some identifiable structures are close to 30 nm, supporting the consistently decreasing trend in  $d_p$  inferred from the TEM measurements.

The significant underprediction of  $d_p$  at 1984 K, despite the close agreement in the predicted and measured  $f_v$  time histories (Fig. 4.27a), can be attributed to the coalescence of primary particles, which increases  $d_p$  but is not accounted for in the model. Higher temperatures promote the formation of turbostratic graphite-like order, which inhibits complete merging of particles [217]. At the same time, coalescence alters particle surface area and therefore affects surface growth via HACA, which in turn influences  $f_v$  predictions.

In addition, condensation of residual aromatic species beyond 7.5 ms may further contribute to larger primary particle sizes. An upper limit for the increase in  $d_p$  was estimated for all conditions by assuming that (i) all residual species containing six or more carbon atoms, equivalent to benzene and larger species, are converted to soot and (ii) the total number of primary particles ( $N_{pri}$ ) remains constant. The revised  $d_p$  was calculated as [192]:

$$d_p = \left( \frac{6W_{carbon}}{\pi\rho_{soot}} \frac{C_{tot} + C_{6\geq}}{N_{pri} \cdot Av} \right)^{1/3}, \quad (4.6)$$

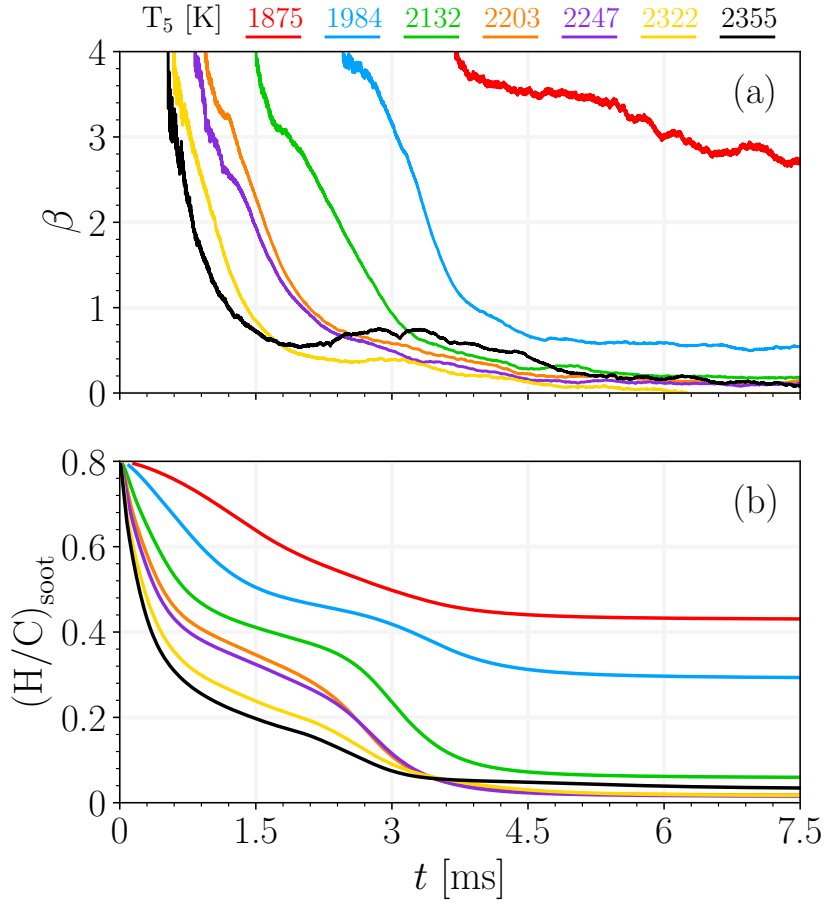


Fig. 4.33 The evolution of (a) maturity index,  $\beta$ , obtained from extinction measurements at 633 nm and 1064 nm, and (b) the predicted H/C ratio of soot particles at various  $T_5$ .

where  $C_{tot}$  is the total carbon mass of soot gained through surface growth mechanisms, and  $C_{6\geq}$  is the total carbon mass in benzene and larger species. Under these assumptions,  $d_p$  increases to 25.6 nm at 1875 K from 7.5 nm and to 16.6 nm at 1984 K from 14 nm, whereas the increase at higher  $T_5$  remains below 1 nm (Fig. A.11) resulting in a decreasing temperature dependence similar to the profile obtained from TEM measurements.

Fig. 4.33a depicts the maturity index,  $\beta$ , inferred from the extinction ratio at 633 nm and 1064 nm [209] as

$$\beta = \ln \left( \frac{E(m, \lambda_{633})}{E(m, \lambda_{1064})} \right) / \ln \left( \frac{\lambda_{1064}}{\lambda_{633}} \right). \quad (4.7)$$

The progression from high to low  $\beta$  with increasing time reflects the transformation of soot from disordered PAH clusters to particles with concentric graphitic layers. This

structural evolution is accompanied by chemical carbonization, manifested as a decrease in the hydrogen-to-carbon (H/C) ratio due to dehydrogenation [218]. As shown in Fig. 4.33b,  $\beta$  exhibits strong qualitative agreement with the predicted H/C ratio of soot particles in both time history and temperature dependence. In all cases, both quantities show an initial rapid decline whose rate increases with  $T_5$ , followed by a slower decrease toward asymptotic values  $\approx 0$ , indicating increasing soot maturity and weak spectral dependence. Notably, the  $\beta$  and H/C profiles at 1875 K and 1984 K converge to higher final values than those at  $T_5 \geq 2132$  K, indicating incomplete carbonization and lower structural ordering under these conditions. In contrast, the higher- $T_5$  cases approach similar late-time values, suggesting that once a threshold temperature is exceeded, soot maturity becomes relatively insensitive to further increases in  $T_5$  within the studied range.



# Chapter 5

## Conclusions and Recommendations

### 5.1 Conclusions

This work presents Omnisoot as a robust computational tool built on Cantera to simulate soot formation coupled with gas-phase chemistry across various combustion and pyrolysis scenarios. Omnisoot integrates four reactor models, two particle dynamics models, and four inception and surface growth models, providing a comprehensive platform for analyzing uncertainties in predicting soot yield and morphology originating from chemical kinetics, inception processes, and surface growth rates.

Omnisoot was employed to elucidate differences among inception models in shock tubes, flow reactors, and perfectly stirred reactors. Global adjustment factors were applied to inception and surface growth rates to accurately reproduce experimental data for each target scenario across a range of parameters, including temperature, pressure, composition, and flow rates. The performance of inception models was evaluated based on soot yield, morphology, size distribution, inception and surface growth rates, and carbon mass source analysis. Although different inception models predicted similar carbon yields that closely matched experimental observations, they produced varying morphological characteristics. This highlights the importance of characterizing soot morphology to better constrain inception flux and surface growth rate predictions.

Simulations of ethylene pyrolysis in a flow reactor demonstrated the temperature sensitivity of inception models. Irreversible models (Irreversible Dimerization and Dimer Coalescence) effectively captured the bimodal PSD resulting from high inception flux in the lower-temperature region near the reactor exit due to their weak temperature dependence. However, the Reactive Dimerization and E-Bridge models generated nearly unimodal distributions due to their exponential temperature dependence, causing a significant drop in inception flux in the same region.

The PSD sampled at the outlet of a flow reactor downstream of a perfectly stirred reactor showed good agreement with experimental measurements across three equivalence ratios. Simulations indicated that active inception and surface growth primarily occur at high temperatures within the perfectly stirred reactor and at the entrance region of the flow reactor, far upstream of the sampling location. Under these conditions, the particle size distribution, morphology, and inception flux predictions were largely consistent across all inception models, although notable differences were observed in soot volume fraction due to variations in predicted HACA growth rate.

The imposed reactor model in Omnisoot was used to simulate soot formation during shock-tube pyrolysis of 5%, 10%, and 30% methane over a temperature range of 1800–2500 K and pressures near 4 atm. The simulation results were compared with time-resolved measurements of key gas-phase species and soot volume. The performance of several kinetic mechanisms were evaluated, indicating that FFCM2 and CRECK reproduced the time history of  $\text{CH}_4$ ,  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_4$ , and  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_2$  in close agreement with the measurements despite significant differences in pathways. The analysis suggests that methane conversion and intermediate yields strongly depend on temperature and fuel concentration, with significant model–measurement deviations for  $\text{CH}_4$  mole fraction emerging at 30% loading due to increased absorption interference. Carbon flux analysis highlighted the dominant role of  $\text{C}_3\text{H}_3$  in channeling carbon toward  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_2$  and PAHs, and the role of  $\text{P-C}_3\text{H}_4$  as a key precursor of  $\text{C}_3\text{H}_3$ . CRECK coupled with E-Bridge Modified model captured the time and temperature trends of  $f_v$  at 5% and 10% loadings, but a substantial overprediction with similarities in time trends is observed at 30% loading, indicating potential missing chemistry or physical effects that could inhibit surface growth at higher loadings.

Simulations using the CRECK mechanism accurately reproduced methane conversion and acetylene yields. The gas-phase chemistry solver was coupled with a sectional population balance model that accounts for CB inception, surface growth, and the reduction in H/C due to carbonization.

Further analysis was performed for 5%  $\text{CH}_4$  pyrolysis by quantifying primary particle diameter using TEM images of samples collected after each shock-tube test. Simultaneous calibration of the model using both  $f_v$  and  $d_p$  provided strong constraints on inception, PAH adsorption, HACA surface growth, and carbonization rates, highlighting the importance of morphology data in avoiding non-unique calibrations based solely on  $f_v$ . The model reproduced the time history of  $f_v$  and the final  $d_p$  in good agreement with the measurements. Four stages of CB evolution were identified: (I) an induction period dominated by precursor formation, (II) rapid increase in  $f_v$  driven by

rising surface growth rates, (III) transition toward final yield, composition, and  $d_p$  as surface growth wanes, and (IV) a coagulation-dominated stage in which primary particle diameters are chemically frozen while the agglomerate mobility diameter continues to increase.

The analysis showed that PAH adsorption dominates CB mass growth at lower temperatures and early times, whereas HACA becomes the primary contributor with increasing  $T_5$ . The model reproduced the bell-shaped temperature dependence of  $f_v$  but overpredicted induction times at  $T_5 > 2200$  K, suggesting the presence of missing high-temperature PAH formation pathways that would accelerate inception and PAH adsorption. TEM measurements revealed a decreasing trend in primary particle diameter with increasing  $T_5$ , while the model predicted a bell-shaped dependence.

The maturity index,  $\beta$ , inferred from the extinction ratio at 633 nm and 1064 nm, exhibited strong similarities to the predicted H/C ratio of CB particles, which is used in the model as a measure of surface reactivity. Both  $\beta$  and H/C decrease rapidly at early times before approaching near-asymptotic values, with the rate of the initial decline increasing with  $T_5$ .

## 5.2 Recommendations

### 5.2.1 Reactor network

The current structure of Omnisoot provides four reactor models, including two close (batch) and two open (continuous) reactors. While single reactor are useful tools for description of lab-scale reactive systems under controlled conditions, large-scale industrial devices with complex flow fields are often represented as a series of interconnected open reactor models [219]. Similar levels of complexity are also encountered in plasma pyrolysis processes used for CB synthesis [220]. Therefore, the development and implementation of a reactor network framework within Omnisoot is an essential next step to enable more realistic process representation and to support reactor design and optimization studies.

### 5.2.2 Extended oxidation model

The oxidation model in Omnisoot describes the removal of carbon atoms through surface reactions with OH and O<sub>2</sub>. However, it does not account for diffusion of O<sub>2</sub> into the soot bulk and the resulting internal oxidation, which becomes significant at temperatures between 600 and 1100 K. There is also growing evidence that soot gasification by CO<sub>2</sub>

and  $\text{H}_2\text{O}$  can reduce primary particle size and alter the nanostructure of soot [221]. Although these processes do not directly affect the current predictive capability of Omnisoot for CB synthesis conditions, extending the oxidation model to include such effects is an important step toward ensuring its applicability across a wider temperature range and for different carrier gas compositions.

### 5.2.3 Flame solver

Soot formation in laminar burner-stabilized premixed and counterflow diffusion flames has been extensively studied in the literature. Standardized datasets are available on the ISF website<sup>1</sup>, which provide a wide range of measurements, including species mole fractions, particle size distributions, soot volume fraction, and primary particle diameter. Accurate simulation of these flame configurations requires a one-dimensional solver, which is not currently available in Omnisoot. Development of such a solver is underway and is presently in the preliminary stages of implementation and validation.

### 5.2.4 Coalescence and sintering

The current version of Omnisoot treats primary particles as hard solid spheres with a minimum diameter of 2 nm that attach through point contact after collision. As a result, coalescence and sintering of primary particles are not explicitly considered. It has been hypothesized that nascent soot may initially exist in a liquid-like phase and subsequently transform into solid spheres through carbonization [222]. The transition from a coalescence-dominated regime to agglomeration has been represented in some soot models using a critical particle diameter [57]. However, the occurrence and extent of soot coalescence remain debated in the literature [35]. Emerging experimental evidence and new benchmark datasets can provide guidance for developing and calibrating sub-models in Omnisoot that account for possible coalescence effects.

Similarly, several experimental studies suggest that reheating can reduce the mobility diameter and surface area of soot agglomerates due to a sintering mechanism activated at elevated temperatures [17]. Sintering models based on characteristic time, originally developed for inorganic nanoparticles, have recently been applied to soot particles in flames [223] and have shown promising results. Implementing these formulations in Omnisoot and evaluating their performance across a range of operating conditions is therefore an important objective for future development.

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<sup>1</sup><https://www.adelaide.edu.au/cet/isfworkshop/data-sets>



### 5.2.5 Fouling effect

Reactor fouling represents a critical challenge in CB synthesis, particularly in furnace processes, where wall deposition of compact carbonaceous material formed from contaminants in feedstocks such as heavy oils forces frequent shutdowns for cleaning, thereby reducing reactor availability and increasing operating costs. These deposits form at elevated temperatures in the presence of ash, trace metals, and highly reactive precursors, and they modify local heat transfer, residence time, and quench conditions, which ultimately degrade CB yield and product quality. At present, Omnisoot does not include a dedicated fouling module. However, its existing framework could be extended to account for wall deposition by combining targeted experiments with simple models that describe the rate of carbon deposition and the resulting changes in reactor performance.

### 5.2.6 Formation of non-agglomerate structures

Pyrolysis and combustion of hydrocarbons can also lead to the formation of carbonaceous materials with non-agglomerate structures such as graphene [224]. There are currently no well-defined mechanisms that clearly distinguish the formation pathways of soot from those leading to non-agglomerate carbon structures. Developing a mechanisms that link precursor chemistry, local temperature and pressure to the emergence of ordered non-agglomerate structures would therefore improve the ability of Omnisoot to predict the full spectrum of carbonaceous products.



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# Appendix A

## Supplementary data and results

This chapter includes the supplementary material mentioned in the thesis but are the central part of discussions.

### A.1 Code validation

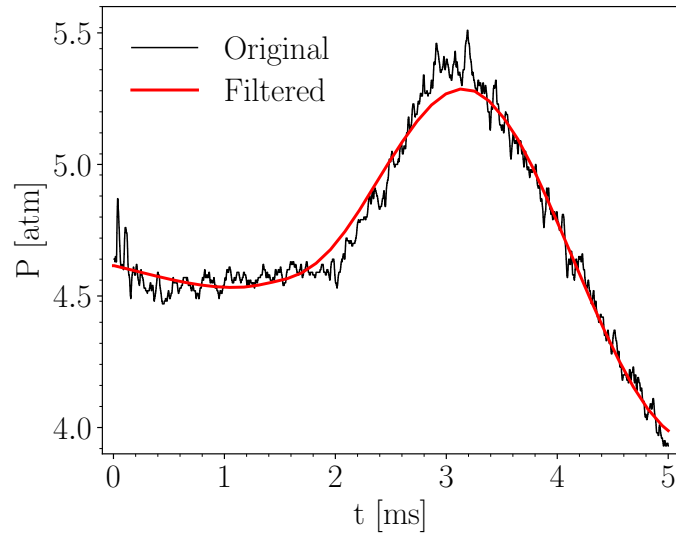


Fig. A.1 The pressure time history (black line) measured by the Stanford group for pyrolysis of 5%CH<sub>4</sub> at  $T_5 = 2355$  K and  $P_5 = 4.64$  atm, and filtered (red line) with reduced fluctuations used to specify the pressure of the reactor

## A.2 Fundamental analysis of PAH growth models

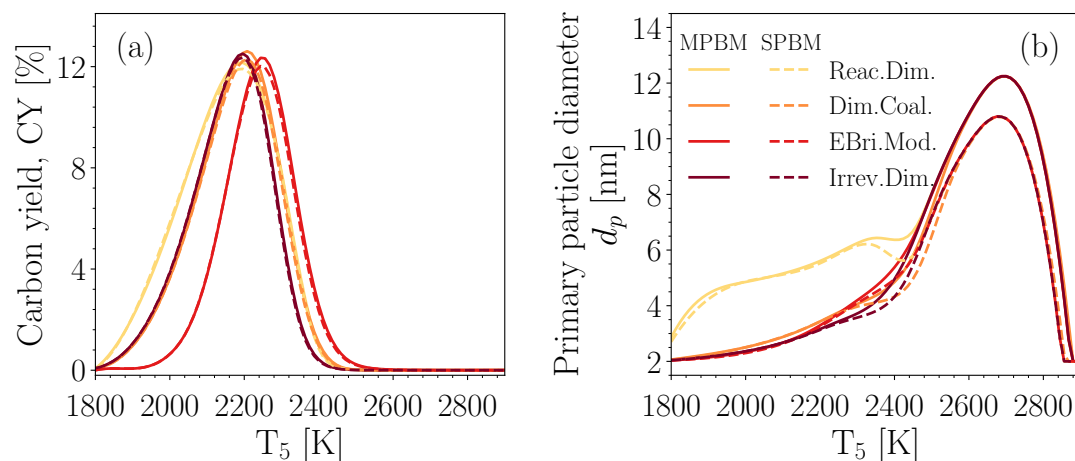


Fig. A.2 The comparison of CY (a) and primary particle diameter,  $d_p$ , at  $t = 1.5$  ms obtained using MPBM and SPBM models for the case optimized using equal adjustment factors to minimize the prediction error.

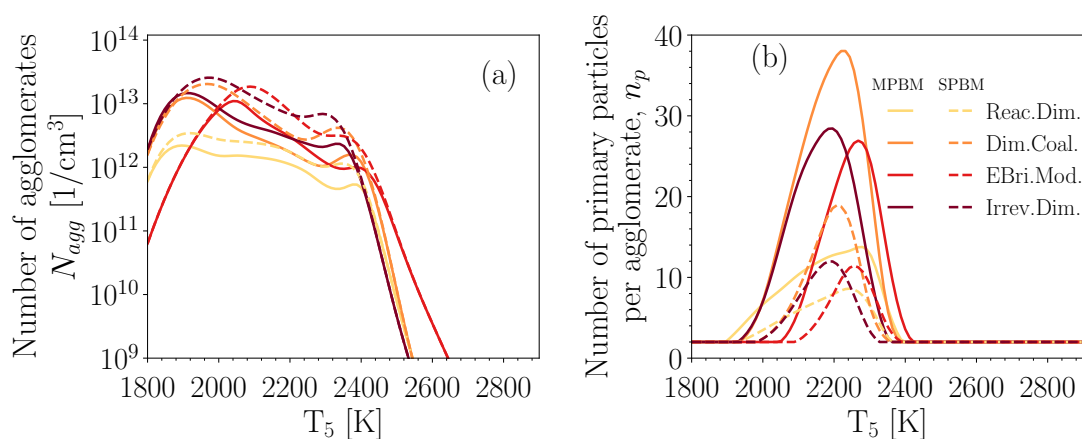


Fig. A.3 The temperature dependence of total number of agglomerates,  $N_{agg}$  (a), number of primary particles per agglomerate,  $n_p$  (b), at  $t = 1.5$  ms obtained using MPBM and SPBM models for the case optimized using equal adjustment factors to minimize the prediction error.



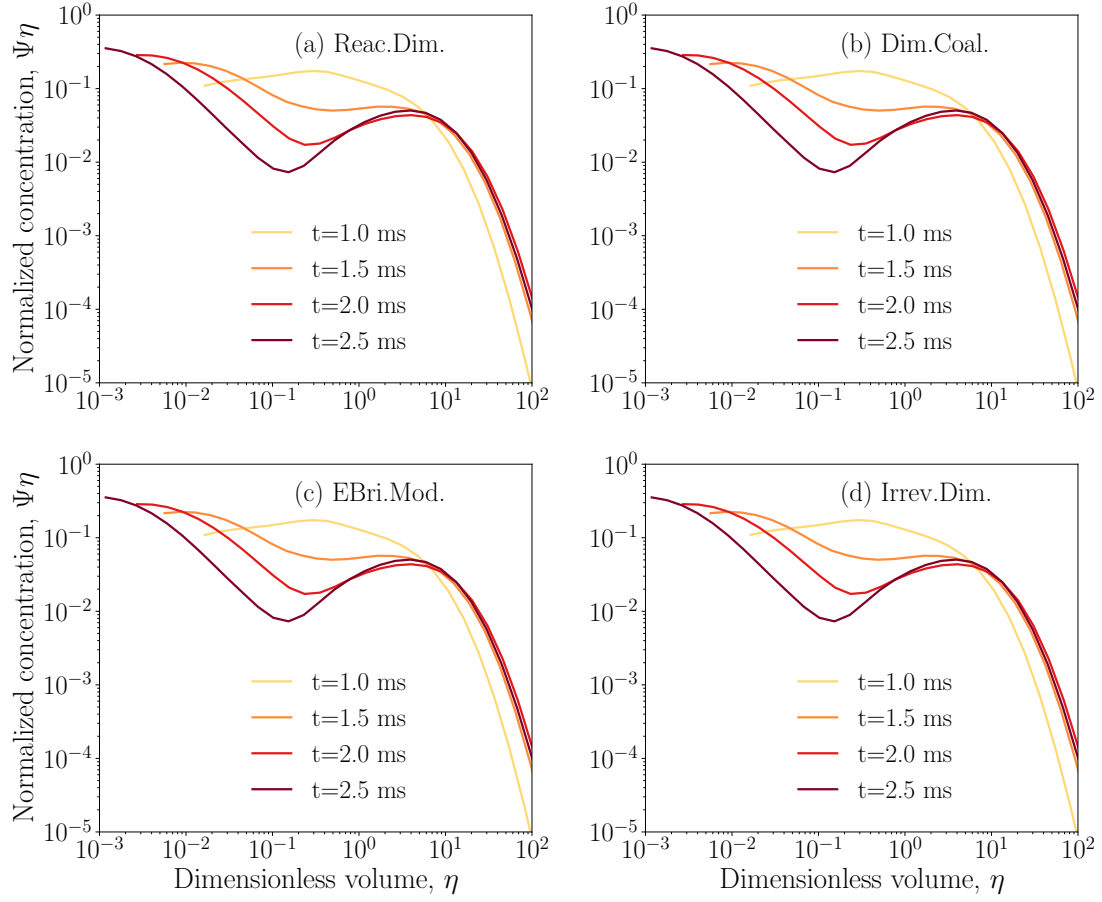


Fig. A.4 The non-dimensional particle size distribution during 5%CH<sub>4</sub>-Ar at T<sub>5</sub> = 2200 K that evolves from 1 ms to 2.5 ms indicating SPSPD is not attained yet.

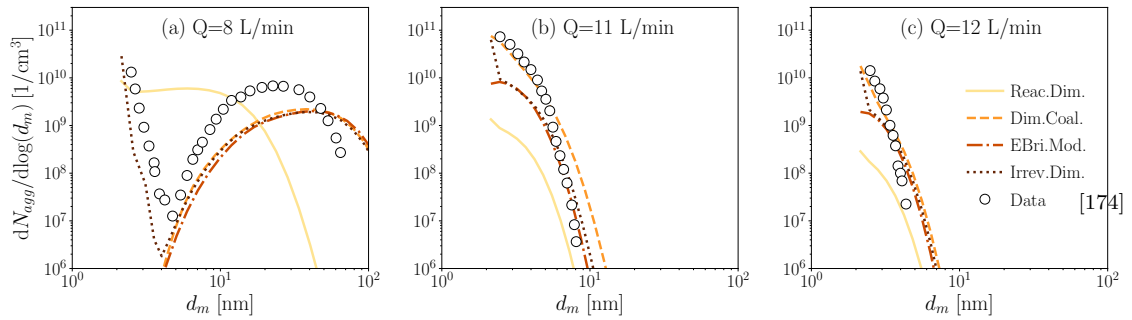


Fig. A.5 The particle size distribution at the end of PFR for Q = 8 (a), 11 (b), and 12 L/min (c) obtained using Caltech mechanism, SPBM and different inception models calibrated to match the predictions with measurement [174].

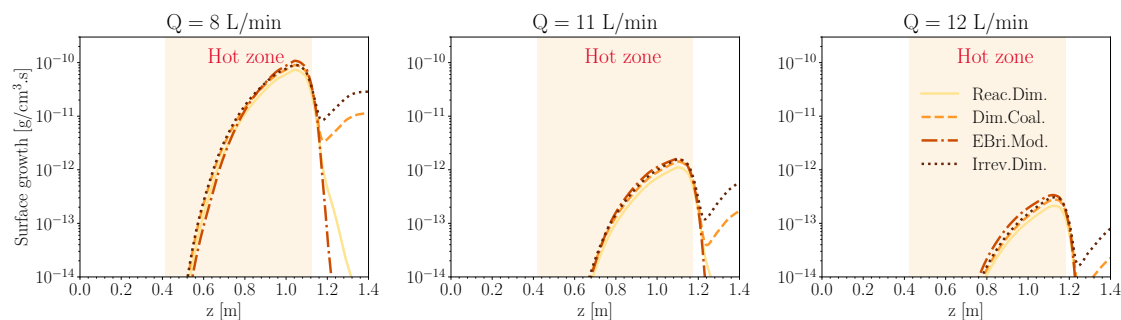


Fig. A.6 The surface growth by HACA and PAH adsorption combined along the PFR for  $Q = 8$  (a),  $11$  (b), and  $12$  L/min (c) obtained using KAUST mechanism, SPBM and different inception models. The yellow area represents the hot zone ( $T > 0.9T_{\max}$ ).

### A.3 Identifying stages of carbon black formation

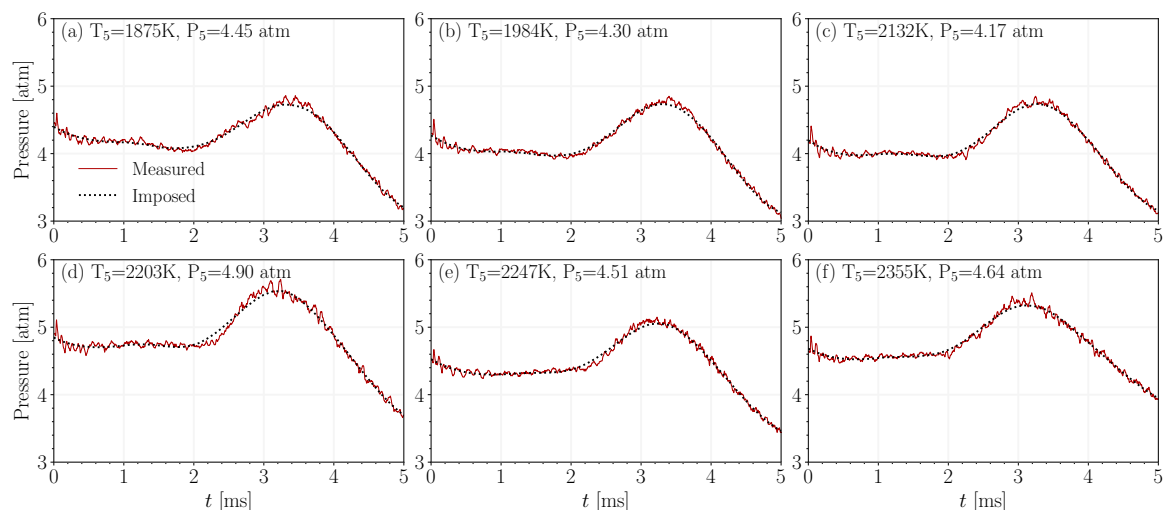


Fig. A.7 The measured pressure trace and the filtered profile imposed in the model for the entire temperature range

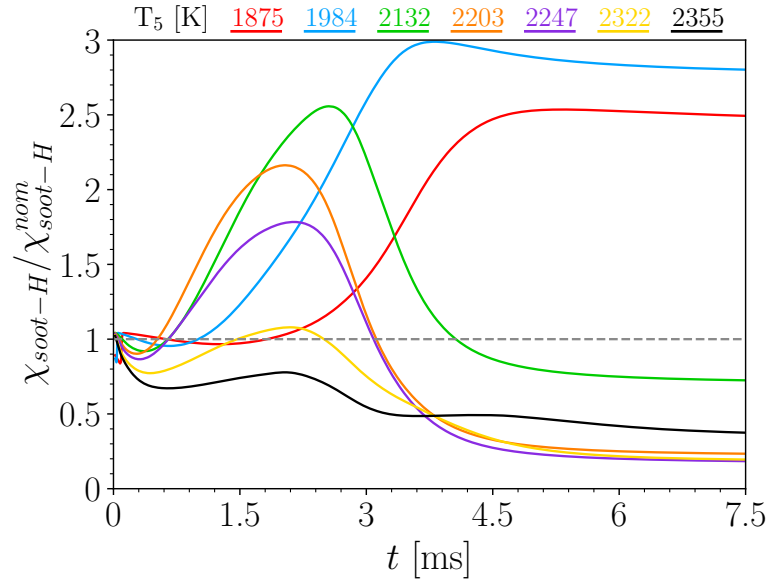


Fig. A.8 The number of hydrogenated sites,  $\chi_{soot-H} = H_{tot}/A_{tot}$  normalized by its nominal value of  $\chi_{soot-H}^{nom} = 2.3 \times 10^{19}$  sites/m<sup>2</sup>.

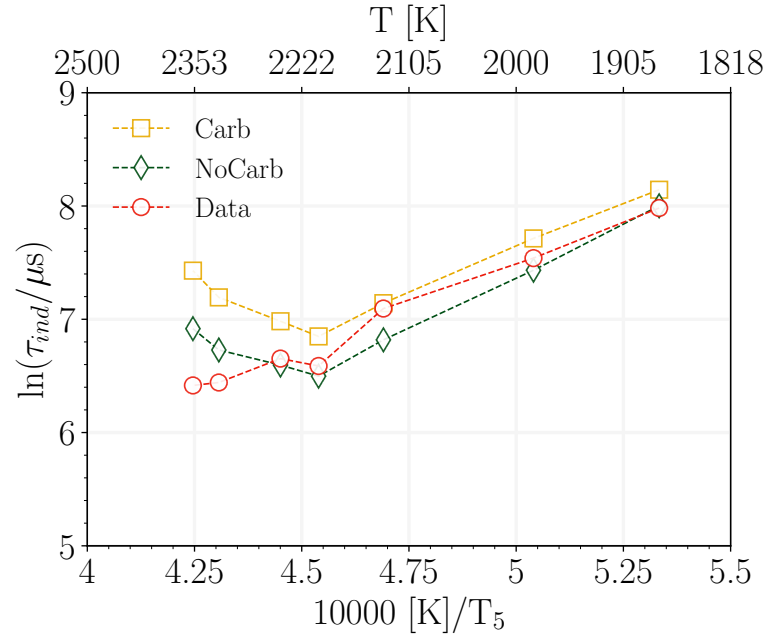


Fig. A.9 The effect on carbonization on CB induction time.

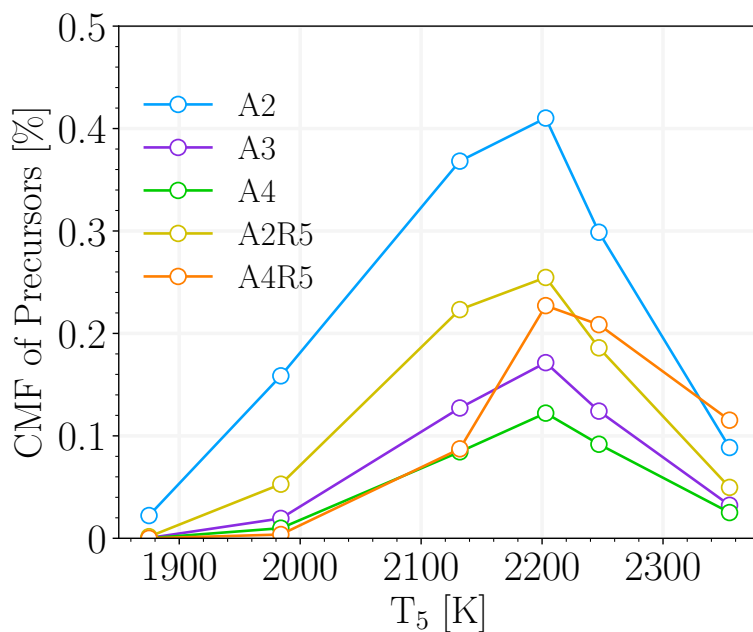


Fig. A.10 The carbon mass fraction of CB precursors at 0.5 ms

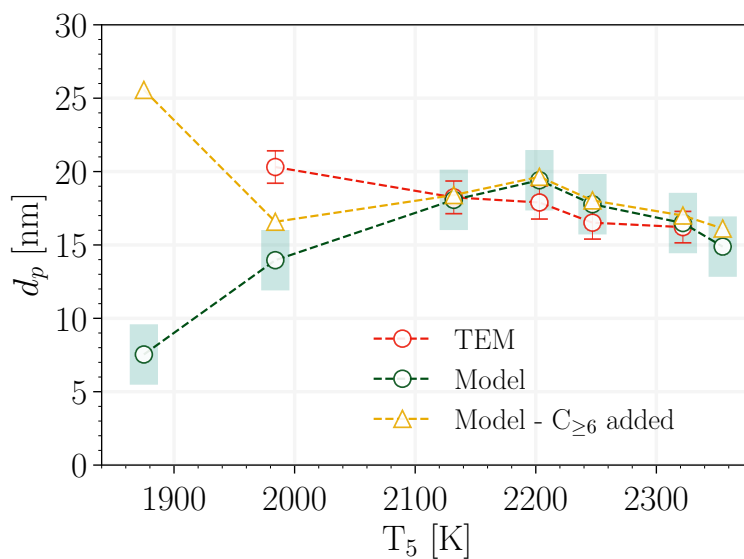


Fig. A.11 The final primary particle diameter,  $d_p$ , considering the additional carbon mass from condensation of benzene and larger species on CB compared with  $d_p$  from TEM measurements and the model predictions at 7.5 ms.

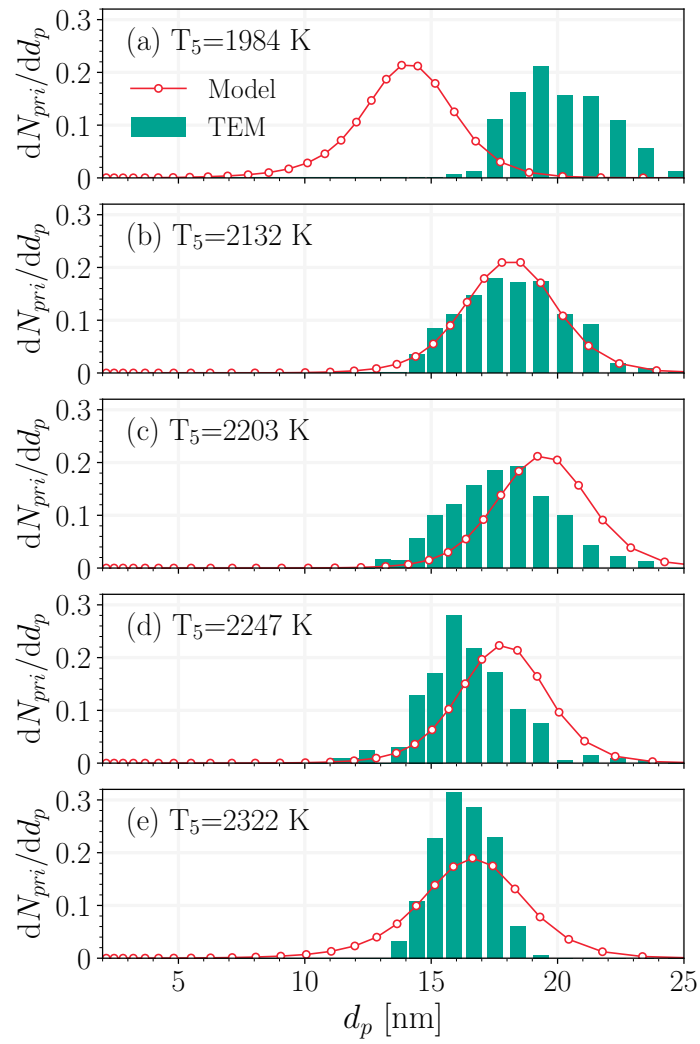


Fig. A.12 The size distribution of primary particles from TEM measurements compared with the model predictions.

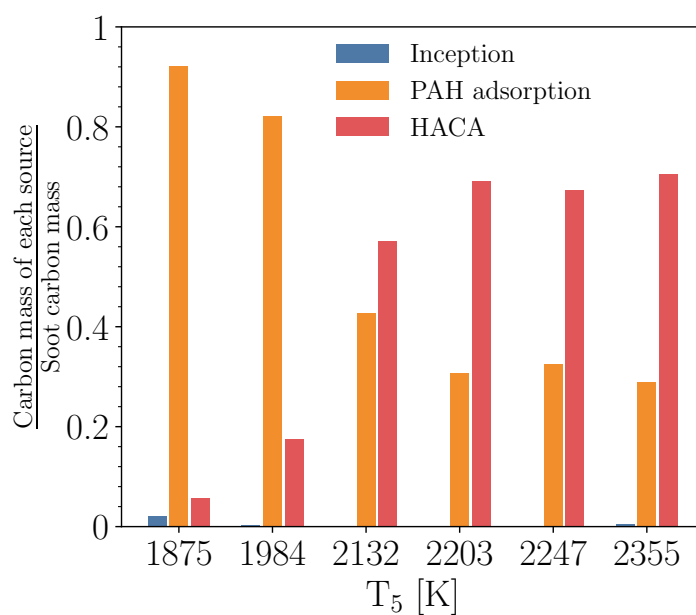


Fig. A.13 The CB mass from inception, PAH adsorption and HACA normalized by total carbon mass at  $t=5$  ms

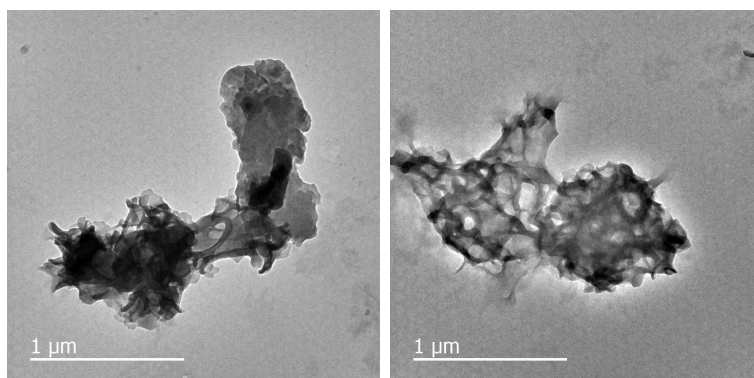


Fig. A.14 Samples of TEM images collected for  $T_5=1875$  K that shows a compact carbonaceous lump with not clear boundaries between primary particles.

## A.4 Soot formation at high fuel loadings

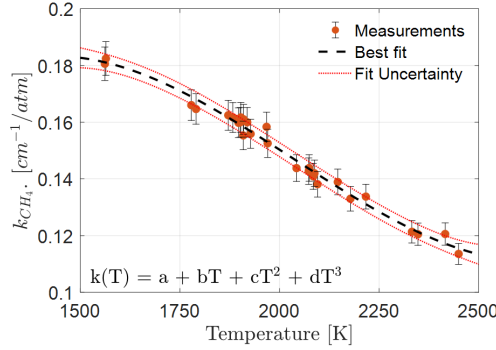


Fig. A.15 Measurements of temperature-dependent CH<sub>4</sub> absorption coefficient near 3.366  $\mu\text{m}$ . The fit coefficients are  $a = -0.3845$ ,  $b = 9.618 \times 10^{-4}$ ,  $c = -5.169 \times 10^{-7}$ ,  $d = 8.467 \times 10^{-11}$  for  $T$  in K

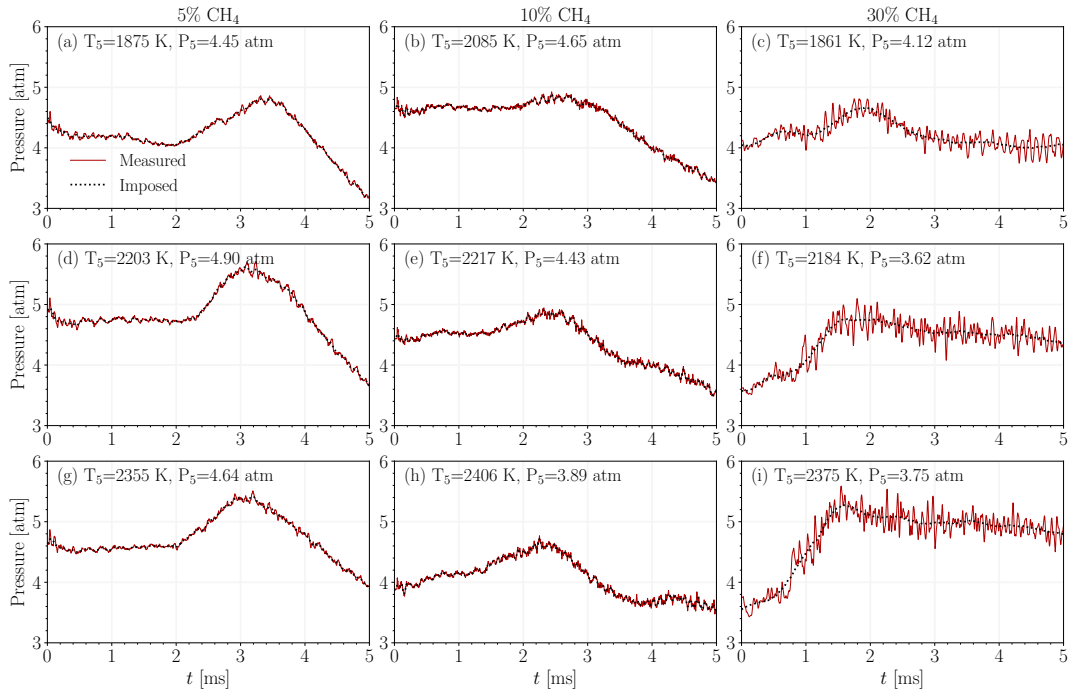


Fig. A.16 The measured pressure trace and the filtered profile imposed in the model for (a, d, g) 5%, (b, c, h) 10%, and 30% CH<sub>4</sub> pyrolysis at  $T_5 \approx 1900, 2200, \text{ and } 2400$  K.

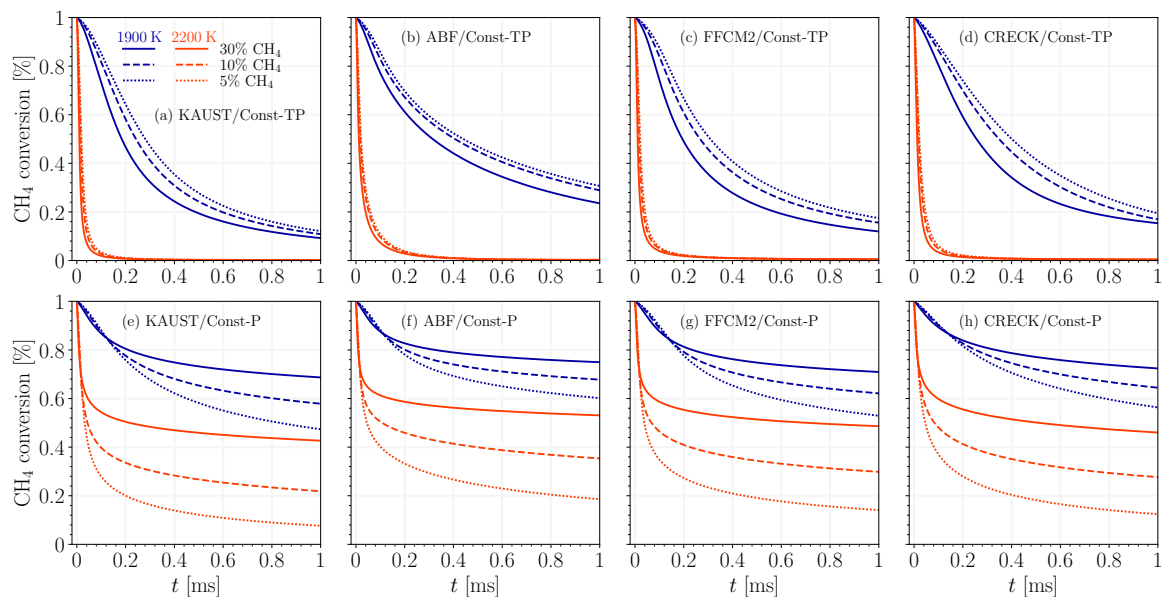


Fig. A.17 The  $\text{CH}_4$  conversion predicted using various kinetic models in Const-TP and Const-P simulations.

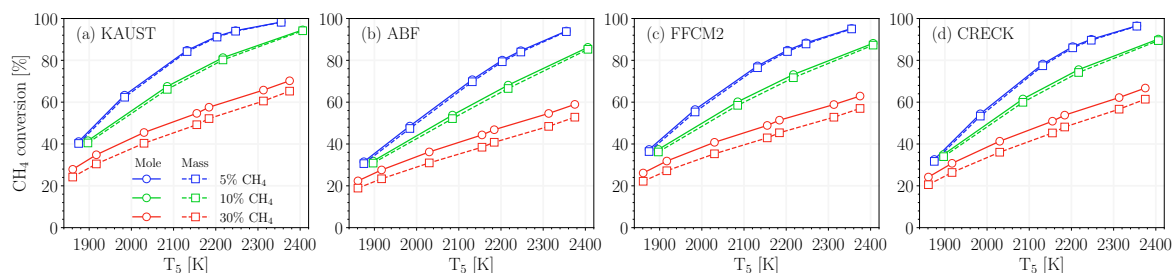


Fig. A.18 The  $\text{CH}_4$  conversion at 1 ms computed using the method based on normalized mole fraction (circles) and carbon mass fraction (squares) predicted using various kinetic models.

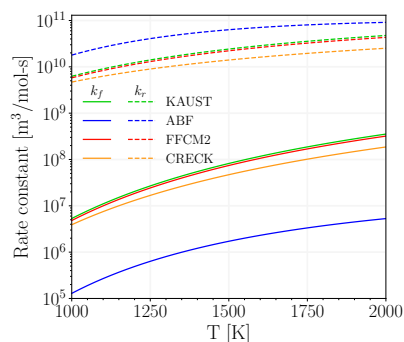


Fig. A.19 The comparison of forward and reverse rate constant of  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_2 + \text{CH}_3 \leftrightarrow \text{P-C}_3\text{H}_4 + \text{H}$ .



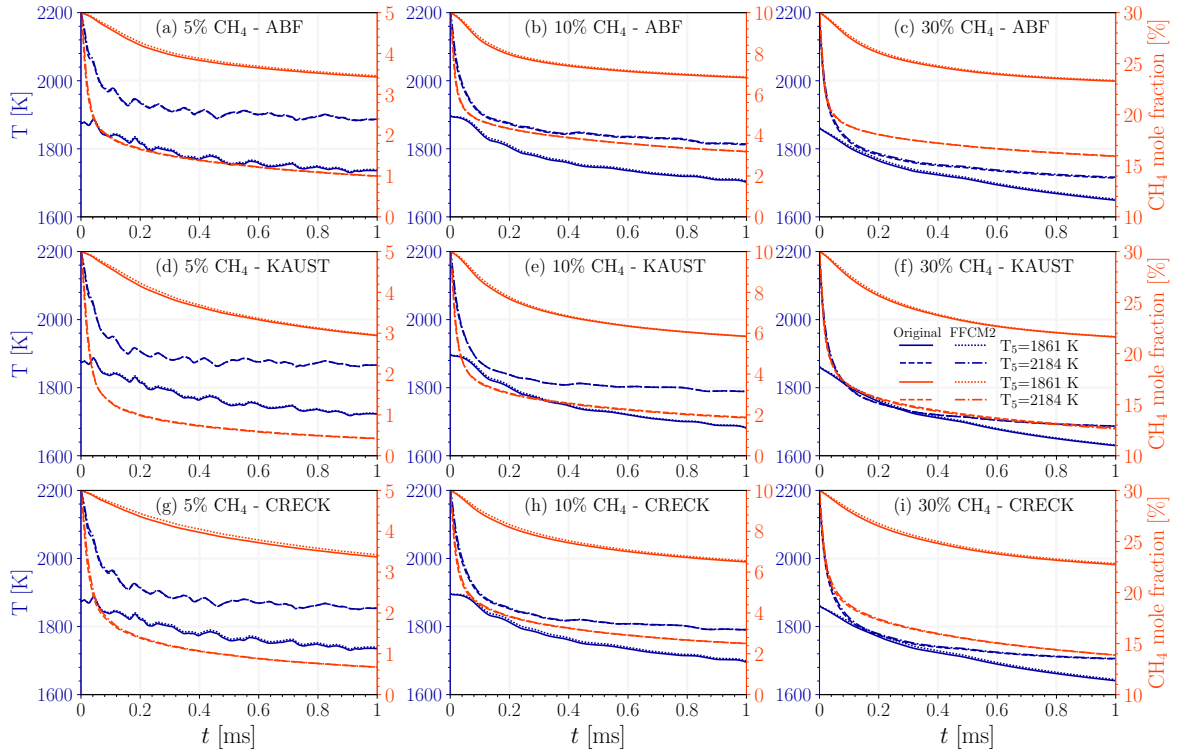


Fig. A.20 The comparison of temperature and  $\text{CH}_4$  mole fraction predicted using ABF, KAUST and CRECK using original rates (dashed line) and the modified (dotted) rates for methane decomposition reactions,  $\text{CH}_4 + (\text{M}) \longleftrightarrow \text{CH}_3 + \text{H}$  and  $\text{CH}_4 + \text{H} \leftrightarrow \text{CH}_3 + \text{H}_2$ . The modified rates were taken from FFCM2.

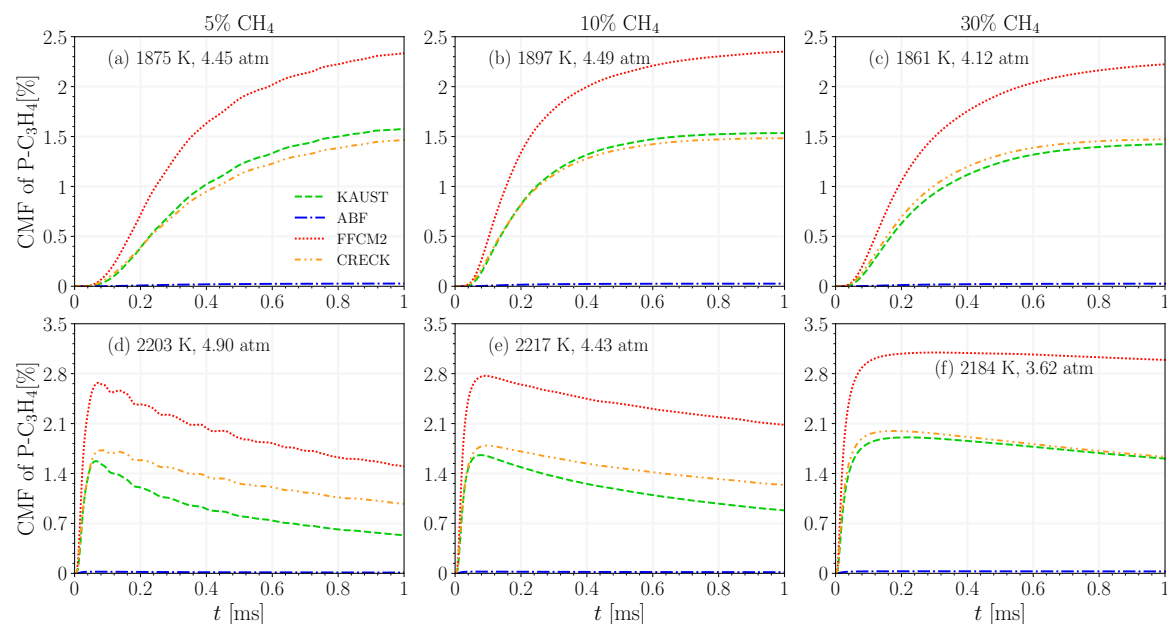


Fig. A.21 The carbon mass fraction of propyne ( $P-C_3H_4$ ) predicted using various kinetic models for 5%, 10% and 30%  $CH_4$  at  $T_5 \approx 1900$  K and 2200 K.

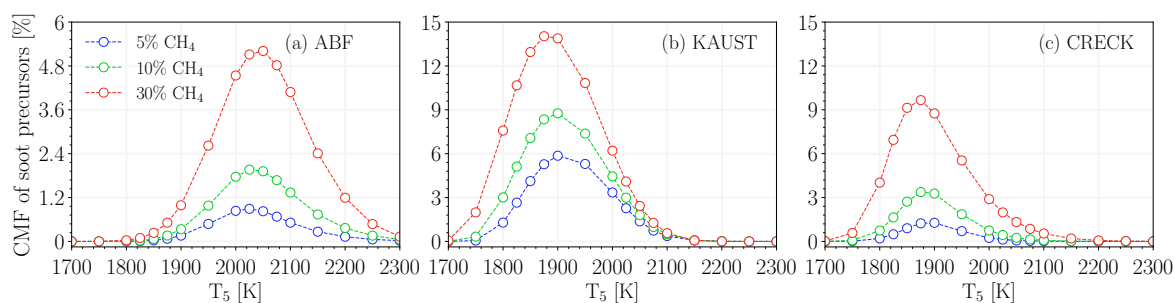


Fig. A.22 The CMF of soot precursors combined at 1 ms over  $1700\text{ K} < T_5 < 2300\text{ K}$  predicted using (a) ABF, (b) KAUST, and (c) CRECK for 5%, 10%, and 30% loadings.

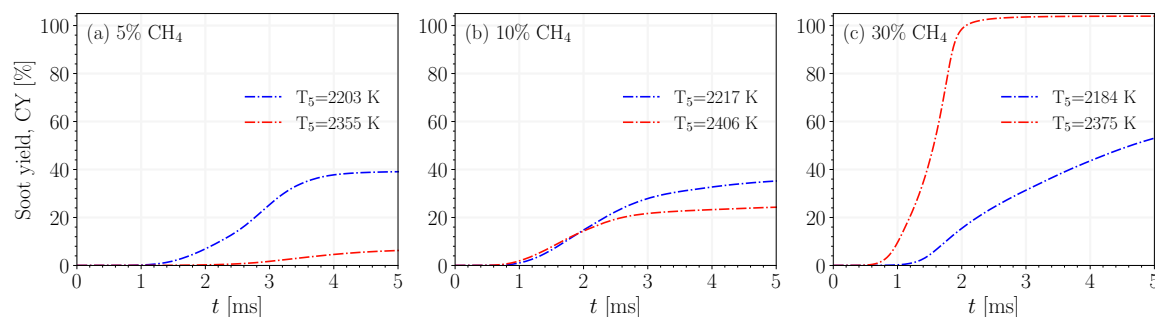


Fig. A.23 The time history of soot yield, CY, for (a) 5%, (b) 10%, and (c) 30%  $CH_4$  pyrolysis predicted using CRECK at  $T_5 \approx 2200$  K and 2400 K.

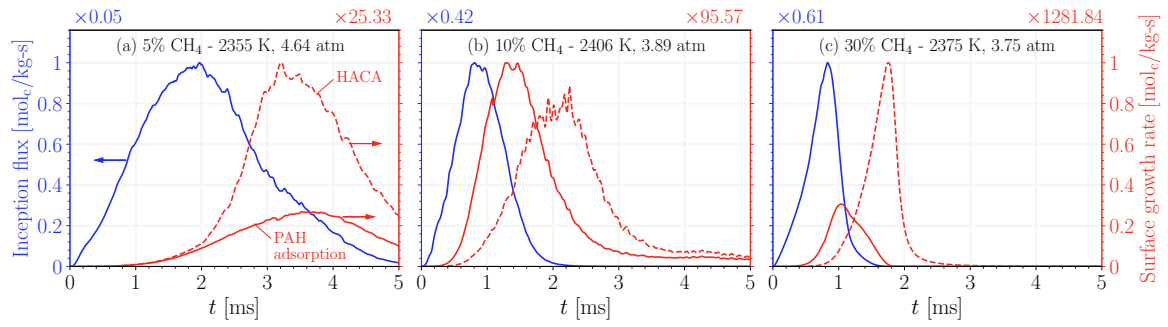


Fig. A.24 The soot inception flux and surface growth rates via PAH adsorption and HACA (a) 5%, (b) 10%, and (c) 30%  $\text{CH}_4$  pyrolysis predicted using CRECK at  $T_5 \approx 2400$  K.